o/"Ideology tries to answer this question
by way of rehabilitating psychoanalysis in its philosophical core - as a theory indebted to Hegel's dialectics and readable only against this background. This cannot but appear, perhaps, as the worst possible move to have made: trying to save psychoanalysis, a discredited theory (and practice), by reference to an even more discredited theory, the worst kind of speculative philosophy rendered irrelevant by the progress of modern SClence.
However, as Lacan taught us, when we are confronted with an apparently clear choice, sometimes the correct thing to do is choose the worst option. Thus my wager was (and is) that, through their interaction (reading Hegel through Lacan and vice versa), psychoanalysis and Hegelian dialectics may simultaneously redeem themselves, shedding their old skins and emerging in a new unexpected shape.
Let us take Hegel's dialectics at its most 'idealist' - with the notion of the sublation [AtifhebuI{9"l of all immediate-material reality. The fundamental operation of Atifhebu118 is reduction: the sublated thing survives, but in an 'abridged' edition, as it were, torn out of its life-world context, stripped down to its essential features, all the movement and wealth of its life reduced to a fIxed mark. It is not that, after the abstraction of Reason has done its mortifyingjob with its fIXed categories or notional determinations, speculative 'concrete universality' somehow returns us to the fresh greenness ofLife; rather, once we pass from empirical reality to its

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notional Azifhebung, the immediacy of Life is lost forever. There is nothing more foreign to Hegel than a lamentation for the richness of reality that gets lost when we proceed to its conceptual grasp. Recall Hegel's unambiguous celebration of the absolute power of Understanding from his Foreword to the Phenomenology: 'The action of separating the elements is the exercise of the force of Understanding, the most astonishing and greatest of all powers, or rather the absolute power.' This celebration is in no way qualified; that is, Hegel's point is trot that this power is nonetheless later 'sublated' into a subordinate moment of the unifYing totality of Reason. The problem with Understanding is, rather, that it does not unleash this power to the end, that it takes it as external to the thing itself-hence the standard notion that it is merely ourUnderstanding ('mind') that separates in its imagination what in 'reality' belongs together, so that the Understanding's 'absolute power' is merely the power of our imagination, which in no way concerns the reality of the thing so analysed. We pass from Understanding to Reason not when this analysis, or tearing apart, is overcome in a synthesis that brings us back to the wealth of reality, but when this power of'tearing apart' is displaced from being 'merely in our mind' into things themselves, as their inherent power of negativity.
Back in the 1960s, one 'progressive' theorist of education touched a chord when he published the results of a simple experiment: he asked a group offive-year-olds to draw an image of themselves playing at home; then, he asked the same group to do it again two years later, after they had been through a year and a half of primary school. The difference was striking: the self-portraits of the five-year-olds were exuberant, lively, full of colours, surrealisti

om them,
how to constrain our gaze and teach it to grasp only the notional determination.
Hegel's formulation is here very precise: the reduction to the signifjring 'unary feature' contracts actuality to possibility, in the precise Platonic sense in which the notion (idea) of a thing always has a deontological dimension to it, designating what the thi,¥! should become in order to be fulfy what it is. 'Potentiality' is thus not simply the name for the essence of a thing actualized in the multitude of empirical things (the idea of a chair as a potentiality actualized in empirical chairs). The multitude of a thing's actual properties is not simply reduced to the inner core of this thing's 'true reality'; what is more important is that the signifYing reduction accentuates (profiles) the thing's inner potentiaL When I call someone 'my teacher', I thereby outline the horizon of what I expect from him; when I refer to a thing as 'chair', I profile the way I intend to use it in future. When I observe the world around me through the lenses of a language, I perceive its actuality through the lenses of the potentialities hidden, latently present, in it. What this means is that potentiality appears 'as such', becomes actual as potentiality, only through language: it is the appellation of a thing that brings to light ('posits') its potentials.
Once we grasp Arifhebung in this way, we can immediately see what is wrong with one of the main topics of the pseudo-Freudian dismissal of Hegel: the notion of Hegel's System as being the highest and most overblown expression of an oral economy. Is not the Hegelian Idea effectively a voracious devourer which 'swallows up' every object it comes

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upon? No wonder Hegel saw himself as Christian: for him, the ritual eating of bread transubstantiated into Christ's flesh signals that the Christian subject can integrate and digest God himself without remainder. Is, consequently, the Hegelian conceiving/grasping not a sublimated version of digestion? Hegel writes,
If the individual human being does something, achieves something, attains a goal, this fact must be grounded in the way the thing itself, in its concept, acts and behaves. If! eat an apple, I destroy its organic self-identity and assimilate it to myself That I can do this entails that the apple in itself, already, in advance, before I take hold of it, has in its nature the determination of being subject to destruction, having in itself a homogeneity with my digestive organs such that I can make it homogeneous with mysel£5
Is what he offers not a lower version of the cognition process itself in which, as he likes to point out, we can only grasp the object if this object itself already 'wants to be with/by us'? One should push this metaphor to the end: the standard critical reading constructs the Hegelian absolute Substance-Subject as thoroughly constipated - retaining within itself the swallowed content. Or, as Adorno put it in one of his biting remarks (which, as is all too often the case with him, misses the mark), Hegel's system 'is the belly turned mind',6 pretending that it swallowed the entire indigestible Otherness . . . But what about the counter-movement: Hegelian shitting? Is the subject of what Hegel calls 'absolute Knowledge' not also a thoroughly emptied subject, a subject reduced to the role of pure observer (or, rather, registrar) of the self-movement of t

t proper, an art no longer subordinated to the
task of representing spiritual reality?
The way abrogation relates to sublation is not that of a si?ple succession
or external opposition, not 'first you eat, then you shit'. Shitting is the
immanent cOlle/usioll of the entire process: without it, we would be dealing
with the 'spurious infinity' of an endless process of sublation. The process
of sublation itself can only reach its end by way of the counter-move:
contrary to what one would initially imagine, these two processes of
sublation and abrogation are completely interdependent. Considering
the last moment of absolute spirit [philosoplfy], one readily notes the
synonymy between the verbs atifheben and befteien ['to liberate'], as well
as ablegen ['to discard', 'to remove', 'to take away} Speculative abrogation,
in no way alien to the process of Azifhebung, is indeed its fulfilment.
Abrogation is a sublation ofsublation, the result of the Azifhebung s work
on itself and, as such, its transformation. The movement of suppression
and preservation produces this transformation at a certain moment in
history, the moment of Absolute Knowledge. Speculative abrogation is
the absolute sublatioll, ifby 'absolute' we mean a relief or sublation that
frees from a certain type of attachment. '0
10 Catherine Malabou, The Future ifHI!el, London: Routledge, 2005. p. 156.

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True cognition is thus not only the notional 'appropriation' of its object:
the process of appropriation goes on only as long as cognition remains
incomplete. The sign of its completion is that it liberates its object, lets
it be, drops it. This is why and how the movement of sublation has to
culminate in the self-relating gesture of sublating itselE
So, what about the obvious counter-argument? Is the part which is
abrogated, released, not precisely the arbitrary, passing aspect of the object,
that which the notional mediation/reduction can afford to drop as being
the part which is in itself worthless? This, precisely, is the illusion to be
avoided, for two reasons. First, it is precisely as discarded that the released
part is, on the contrary, and if one may be permitted to insist on the excre-
mental metaphor, the manure of spiritual development, the ground out
of which further development will grow. The release of Nature into its
own thus lays the foundation of Spirit proper, which can develop itself
only out of Nature as its inherent self-sublation. Second (and more fimda-
mentally), what is released into its own being in speculative cognition is
ultimately the object of cognition itself which, when truly grasped [begrif-
fin], no longer has to rely on the subject's active intervention, but develops
itself following its own conceptual automatism, with the subject reduced
to a passive observer who, allowing the thing to deploy its potential with-
out any intervention of his own (Ziltun), merely registers the process. This
is why Hegelian cognition is simultaneously both active and passive, but
in a sense which radically displaces the Kantian notion of cognition as the
unity of activity and passivity. In Kant, the subject actively synthesizes
(confers unity on) the content (sensuous multiplicity) by which he is
passively affected. For Hegel, on the contrary, at the level of Absolute
Knowledge, the cognizing subject is thoroughly passivized: he no longer
intervenes in the object, but merely registers the

herefore, no transition takes place; the simple
being to which the Idea determines itself remains perfectly transparent
to it and is the Notion that, in its determination, abides with itself The
passage is therefore to be understood here rather in this manner, that
the Idea freely releases itselfin its absolute self-assurance and inner poise.
By reason of this freedom, the form of its determinateness is also utterly
free - the externality of space and time existing absolutely on its own
account without the moment of subjectivity.l] Hegel repeatedly insist's
here on this 'absolute liberation' being thoroughly different from the
standard dialectical 'transition'. But how? The suspicion lurks that Hegel's
'absolute liberation' relies on the absolute mediation of all otherness: I
set the Other free only after I have completely internalized it . . . However,
is this really the case?
One should here reread Lacan's critique of Hegel: what if, far from
denying what Lacan calls the 'subjective disjunction', Hegel on the contrary
asserts a previously unheard-of division that runs through the (particular)
sul?ject as well as through the (universalj substantial order of'coliectivi!J: uniting
the two? That is to say, what if the 'reconciliation' berween the Particular
and the Universal occurs precisely through the division that cuts across
the two? The basic 'postmodern' reproach to Hegel - that his dialectics
admits antagonisms and splits only to resolve them magically in a higher
lZ
Hegel, The Science ojLogic, p. 843·
13
Hegel, philosop1!J of Mind, Par. 57.

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synthesis-mediation - strangely contrasts with the good old Marxist
reproach (already formulated by Schelling) according to which Hegel
resolves antagonisms only in 'thought', through conceptual mediation,
while in reality they remain unresolved. One is tempted to accept this
second reproach at face value and use it against the first one: what if this
is the proper answer to the accusation that Hegelian dialectics magically
resolves antagonisms? What if, for Hegel, the poinr, precisely, is to not
'resolve' antagonisms 'in reality', but simply to enact a parallax shift by
means of which antagonisms are recognized' as such' and thereby perceived
in their 'positive' role?
The passage from Kant to Hegel is thus much more convoluted than it
may appear :.let us approach it again by way of their different attitudes to
the ontological proof of God's existence. Kant's rejection of this proof takes
as its starting point his thesis that being is not a predicate: if one knows all
the predicates of an entity, its being (existence) does not follow, that is, one
cannot conclude a being from a notion. (The anti-Leibniz line is obvious
here, since, according to Leibniz, two objects are indistinguishable if all of
their predicates are the same.) The implication for the ontological proof of
God is clear: in the same way that I can have a perfect notion of 100 thalers
and yet still not have them in my pocket, I can have a perfect notion of
God and yet God still may not exist. Hegel's first remark on this line of
reasoning is that 'being' is the poorest, most imperfect, notional deter-
mination (everything 'is' in some way, even my craziest phantasmagorias);
it is only through further notional determinations that we get to existence,
to reality, to actuality, which are all much more than mere being. His
second remark is that

the gap between notion and existence is precisely
the mark of finitude; it holds for finite objects like 100 thalers, but not
for God: God is not something I can have (or not have) in my pocket . . .
On a first approach, it may seem that the opposition between Kant and
Hegel is here ultimately that between materialism and idealism: Kant insists
on a minimum of materialism (the independence of reality with regard to
notional determinations), while Hegel totally dissolves reality in its notional
determinations. However, Hegel's true point lies elsewhere: it involves a

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much more radical 'materialist' claim that a complete notional
determination of an entity - to which one would only have to add 'being'
in order to arrive at its existence - is in itself an abstract notion, an empty
abstract possibility. The lack of (a certain mode ofj being is always also an
inherent lack of some notional determination - say, for a thing to exist as
part of opaque material reality, a whole set of notional conditions-
determinations have to be met(and other determinations have to be lacking).
With regard to 100 thalers (or any other empirical object), this means that
their notional determination is abstract, which is why they possess an opaque
empirical being and not full actuality. So when Kant draws a parallel between
God and the 100 thalers, one should ask a simple and naive question: does
Kant realfy possess a (fully developed) concept of God?
This brings us to the true finesse of Hegel's argumentation, which is
directed in two ways, both against Kant and against Anselm's classic version
of the ontological proof of God. Hegel's argument against Anselin's proof
is not that it is too conceptual, but that it is not conceptual enough: Anselm
does not develop the concept of God, he just refers to it as the sum of all
perfections which, as such, is precisely beyond the comprehension of our
finite human minds. Anselm merely presupposes 'God' as an impenetrable
reality beyond our comprehension (i.e., outside the notional domain), in
other words, his God is precisely not a concept (something posited by our
conceptual work), but a purely presupposed pre-or non-conceptual reality.
Along the same lines, albeit in the opposite sense, one should note the
irony in the fact that Kant talks about thalers, that is, about money, whose
existence as money is not 'objective', but depends on 'notional'
determinations. It is true, as Kant says, that having a concept of 100 thalers
is not the same as having them in your pocket; but ?et us imagine a process
of rapid inflation which totally devalues the 100 thalers in your pocket;
in this case, the same object is there in reality, but it is no longer money,
having become a meaningless and worthless coin. In other words, money
is precisely an object whose status depends on how we 'think' about it: if
people no longer treat this piece of metal as money, if they no longer
'believe' in it as money, it no longer is money.

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With regard to material reality, the ontological proof of God's existence
should thus be turned around: the existence of material reality bears
witness to the fact that the Notion is not fully actualized. Things
. 'materially exist' not when they meet certain notional requirements, but
when they foil to meet them - material reality is as such a sign of
imperfection. With regard to truth, this

means that, for Hegel, the truth
of a proposition is inherently notional, determined by the immanent
notional content, not a matter of comparison between notion and reality
- in Lacanian terms, there is a non-All (p£l.f-tou‡ of truth. It may sound
strange to invoke Hegel apropos the non-All: is Hegel not the philosopher
of All par excellence? However, Hegelian truth is precisely without any
external limitation/exception that would serve as its measure or standard,
which is why its criterion is absolutely immanent: one compares a state-
ment with itself, with its own process of enunciation.
When Alain Badiou emphasizes the undecidability of a Truth-Event,
his position is radically different from the standard deconstructionist
notion of undecidability.'4 For Badiou, undecidability means that there
are no neutral 'objective' criteria for an Event: an Event appears as such
only to those who recognize themselves in its call; or, as Badiou puts it,
an Event is self-relating, it includes itself- its own nomination - among
its components. While this does mean that one has to decide about an
Event, such an ultimately groundless decision is not 'undecidable' in the
standard sense; it is, rather, uncannily similar to the Hegelian dialectical
process in which, as Hegel himself made clear already in the Introduction
to his Phenomenology, a 'figure of consciousness' is not measured by any
external standard of truth but in an absolutely immanent way, through
the gap between itself and its own exemplification/staging. An Event is
thus 'non-All' in the precise Lacanian sense of the term: it is never fully
verified precisely because it is infinite/unlimited, that is, because there is
no external limit to it. And the conclusion to be drawn here is that, for
the very same reason, the Hegelian 'totality' is also 'non-All'.
14 See Alain Badiou, L '!tre et /'fvenement, Paris: Editions de Minuit, 1989.

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Back to our main line of argument. What this means is that the exter-
nality of Nature with regard to the Idea is not that of the Idea's constitutive
exception: it is not that Nature is set free as the exception that guarantees
the Wholeness of the Idea's self-mediation. It is not the case that, once
this mediation is completed (that is, after the Idea's dialectical progress
can no longer be propelled by the Idea's own incompleteness - its failure
to correspond to its own notion), the completed Idea needs an external Other
(Nature) to sustain the complete and closed circle of its self-mediation. Nature
is, rather, the mark of the non-All of the Idea's totality.
So, to pursue the rather tasteless metaphor, Hegel was not a sublimated
coprophagist, as the usual notion of the dialectical process would lead us
to believe. The matrix of the dialectical process is not that of excrementation-
externalization followed by a swallowing (reappropriation) of the external-
ized content, but, on the contrary, of appropriation followed by the
excremental move of dropping it, releasing it, letting it go. What this
means is that one should not equate externalization with alienation. The
externalization which concludes a cycle of dialectical process is not alien-
ation, it is the highest point of dis-alienation: one really reconciles oneself
with some objective content not when one still has to strive to master
and control it, but when one can afford the supreme sovereign gesture of
releasing this c

use implies necessarily a certain short circuit, an illusion of the type 'I was already there' which, as Michel P/cheux - who has given us the most elaborated version of the theory of interpellation - pointed out, is not without its comical effects: the short circuit of'no wonder you were interpellated as proletarian, when you are a proletarian'.J Here, P?cheux is supplementing Marxism with the Marx Brothers, whose well-known joke goes: 'You remind me of Emanuel Ravelli.' 'But I am Emanuel Ravelli.' 'Then no wonder you look like him!'

In contrast to this Althusserian ethics of alienation in the symbolic 'process without subject', we may denote the ethics implied by Lacanian psychoanalysis as that of separation. The famous Lacanian motto not to give way on one's desire (ne pas cider sur son dfsir) - is aimed at the fact that we must not obliterate the distance separating the Real from its symbolization: it is this surplus of the Real over evety symbolization that functions as the object-cause of desire. To come to terms with this surplus (or, more. precisely, leftover) means to acknowledge a fundamental deadlock ('antagonism'), a kernel resisting symbolic integration-dissolution. The best way to locate such an ethical position is via its opposition to the traditional

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Michel P?cheux, Lal18ul1fje, Semalltia alld Ideology, New York: Macmillan, 1982.

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Marxist notion of social antagonism. This traditional notion implies two interconnected features: (1) there exists a certain fundamental antagonism possessing an ontological priority to 'mediate' all other antagonisms, determining their place and their specific weight (class antagonism, economic exploitation); (2) historical development brings about, if not a necessity, at least an 'objective possibility' of solving this fundamental antagonism and, in this way, mediating all other antagonisms - to recall the well-known Marxist formulation, the same logic which drove mankind into alienation and class division also creates the condition for its abolition - 'die Wunde schliesst der Speer nur, der sie schlug' [the wound can be healed only by the spear which made it] -as Wagner, Marx's contemporary, said through the mouth of ParsifaL

It is upon the unity of these two features that the Marxist notion of the revolution, of the revolutionary situation, is founded: a situation of metaphorical condensation in which it finally becomes clear to the everyday consciousness that it is not possible to solve any particular question without solving them all - that is, without solving the fundamental question which embodies the antagonistic character of the social totality. In a 'normal', pre-revolutionary state of things, everybody is fighting his own particular battles (workers are striking for better wages, feminists are fighting for the rights of women, democrats for political and social freedoms, ecologists against the exploitation of nature, participants in the peace movements against the danger of war, and so on). Marxists are using all their skill and adroitness of argument to convince the participants in these particular struggles that the only real solution to their problem is to be found in the global revolution: as long as social relations are dominated by Capital, there will always be sexism in relations between the sexes, there will always be a threat of global war, there will always be a danger that po

ew Man without antagonistic tension.
We have the same logic with ecology: man as such is 'the wound of nature', there is no return to the natural balance; to accord with his milieu, the only thing man can do is accept fully this cleft, this fissure, this structural rooting-out, and to try as far as possible to patch things up afterwards; all other solutions - the illusion of a possible return to nature, the idea of a total socialization of nature - are a direct path to totalitarianism.
We have the same logic with feminism: 'there is no sexual relationship': that is, the relation between sexes is by definition 'impossible', antagonistic; there is no final solution, and the only basis for a somewhat bearable relation between the sexes is an acknowledgement of this basic antagonism, this basic impossibility.
We have the same logic with democracy: it is - to use the worn-out phrase attributed to Churchill - the worst of all possible systems; the only problem is that there is no other which would be better. That is to say, democracy always entails the possibility of corruption, of the rule of dull mediocrity, the only problem is that every attempt to elude this inherent risk and to restore 'real' democracy necessarily brings about its opposire - it ends in the abolition of democracy itself Here it would be possible to defend a thesis that the first post-Marxist was none other than Hegel himself: according to Hegel, the antagonism of civil society cannot be suppressed without a fall into totalitarian terrorism - only afterwards can the state limit its disastrous effects.

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It is the merit of Ernest Ladau and Chantal Mouffe that they have, in Heaemof9! and Soa'alist Strategy, developed a theory of the social field founded on such a notion of antagonism - on an acknowledgement of an original 'trauma', an impossible kernel which resists symbolization, totalization, symbolic integration. Every attempt at symbolization-totalization comes afterwards: it is an atrempt to suture an original cleft - an atrempt which is, in the last resort, by definition doomed to failure. They emphasize that we must not be 'radical' in the sense of aiming at a radical solution: we always live in an interspace and in borrowed time; every solution is provisional and temporary, a kind of postponing of a fundamental impossibility. Their term 'radical democracy' is thus to be taken somehow paradoxically: it is precisely not'radical' in the sense of pure, true democracy; its radical character implies, on the contrary, that we can save democracy only by taking into account its own radical imposill!J. Here we can see how we have reached the opposite extreme of the traditional Marxist standpoint: in traditional Marxism, the global solution-revolution is the condition of the effective solution of all particular problems, while here every provisional, temporarily successful solution of a particular problem entails an acknowledgement of the global radical deadlock, impossibility, the acknowledgement of a fundamental antagonism.
My thesis (developed in Ie plus sublime des Iy;steriques: Hegel passe) is that the most consistent model of such an acknowledgement of antagonism is offered by Hegelian dialectics: far from being a story of its progressive overcoming, dialectics is for Hegel a systematic notation of the failure of all such attempts - 'absolute knowledge' denotes a subjective position

Marx, Freud: the ana!JIsis afform

According to Lacan, it was none other than Karl Marx who invented the notion of symptom. Is this Lacanian thesis just a sally of wit, a vague analogy, or does it possess a pertinent theoretical foundation? If Marx really articulated the notion of the symptom as it is also at work in the Freudian field, then we must ask ourselves the Kantian question, concerning the epistemological 'conditions of possibility' of such an encounter: how was it possible for Marx, in his analysis of the world of commodities, to produce a notion which applies also to the analysis of dreams, hysterical phenomena, and so on?

The answer is that there is a fundamental homology between the interpretative procedure of Marx and Freud - more precisely, between their analysis of commodity and of dreams. In both cases the point is to avoid the properly fetishistic fascination of the 'content' supposedly hidden behind the form: the 'secret' to be unveiled through analysis is not the content hidden by the form (the form of commodities, the form of dreams) but, on the contrary, the secret' afthis form itself The theoretical intelligence of the form of dreams does not consist in penetrating from the manifest content to its 'hidden kernel', to the latent dream-thoughts; it consists in the answer to the question: why have the latent dream-thoughts assumed such a form, why were they transposed into the form of a dream? It is the same with commodities: the real pro blem is not to penetrate to the 'hidden

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kernel' of the commodity - the determination of its value by the quantity of the work consumed in its production - but to explain why work assumed the form of the value of a commodity, why it can affirm its social character only in the commodity-form of its product.

The notorious reproach of 'pansexualism' addressed at the Freudian interpretation of dreams is already a commonplace. Hans-Jiirgen Eysenck, a severe critic of psychoanalysis, long ago observed a crucial paradox in the Freudian approach to dreams: according to Freud, the desire articulated in a dream is supposed to be - as a rule, at least - unconscious and at the same time of a sexual nature, which contradicts the majority of examples analysed by Freud himself, starting with the dream he chose as an introductory case to exemplifY the logic of dreams, the famous dream ofIrma's injection. The latent thought articulated in this dream is Freud's attempt to get rid of the responsibility for the failure of his treatment ofIrma, a patient of his, by means of arguments of the type 'it was not my fault, it was caused by a series of circumstances . . .'; but this 'desire', the meaning of the dream, is obviously. neither of a sexual nature (it rather concerns professional ethics) nor unconscious (the failure of Irma's treatment was troubling Freud day and night).'

This kind of reproach is based on a fundamental theoretical error: the identification of the unconscious desire at work in the dream with the 'latent thought' - that is, the signification of the dream. But as Freud continually emphasizes, there is nothing 'unconscious' in the 'latent dream-thought': this thought is an entirely 'normal' thought which can be articulated in the syntax of everyday, common language; topologically, it belongs to the system of , consciousness/preconsciousness'; the subject is usually aware of

notion of money as a 'pre-phallic', 'anal' object is acceptable - provided that we do not forget how this postulated existence of the sublime body depends on the symbolic order: the indestructible 'body-within-the-body' exempted from the effects of wear and tear is always sustained by the guarantee of some symbolic authority:

A coin has it stamped upon its body that it is to serve as a means of exchange and not as an object of use. Its weight and metallic purity are guaranteed by the issuing authority so that, if by the wear and tear of circulation it has lost in weight, full replacement is provided. Its physical matter has visibly become a mere carrier of its social function.'O

If, then, the 'real abstraction' has nothing to do with the level of'reality', of the effective properties, of an object, it would be wrong for that reason to conceive of it as a 'thought-abstraction', as a process taking place in the 'interior' of the thinking subject: in relation to this 'interior', the abstraction appertaining to the act of exchange is in an irreducible way external, decentred - or, to quote Sohn-Rethel's concise formulation: 'The exchange abstraction is not thought, but it has the flnn of thought.'

Here we have one of the possible definitions of the unconscious: the flnn ofthou,ght whose ontological status is not that ofthou,ght, that is to say, the form of thought external to the thought itself - in short, some Other Scene external to the thought whereby the form of the thought is already articulated in advance. The symbolic order is precisely such a formal order which supplements and/or disrupts the dual relationship of 'external' factual reality and 'internal' subjective experience; Sohn-Rethel is thus quite justified in his criticism of Althusser, who conceives abstraction as a process taking place entirely in the doma,in of knowledge and refuses for that reason the category of ' real abstraction' as the expression of an 'epistemological confusion'. The 'real abstraction' is unthinkable in the frame of the fundamental Althusserian epistemological distinction

10 Ibid., p. 59.

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between the 'real object' and the ' object of knowledge' in so far as it introduces a third element which subverts the very field of this distinction: the form of the thought previous and external to the thought - in short: the symbolic order.

We are now able to formulate precisely the 'scandalous' nature of Sohn-Rethel's undertaking for philosophical reflection: he has confronted the closed circle of philosophical reflection with an external place where its form is already 'staged'. Philosophical reflection is thus subjected to an uncanny experience similar to the one summarized by the old oriental formula 'thou art that': there, in the external effectivity of the exchange process, is your proper place; there is the theatre in which your truth was performed before you took cognizance of it. The confrontation with this place is unbearable because philosophy as such is difined 0/ its blindness to this place: it cannot take it into consideration without dissolving itself, without losing its consistency.

This does not mean, on the other hand, that everyday 'practical' consciousness, as opposed to the philosophical-theoretical one - the consciousness of the individuals partaking in the act of exchange - is not also subjected to a comple

sa"ousnes: Thus we have finally
reached the dimension of the symptom, because one of its possible definitions would also be 'a formation whose very consistency implies a certain non-knowledge on the part of the subject': the subject can 'enjoy his symptom' only in so far as its logic escapes him - the measure of the success of its interpretation is precisely its dissolution.

The sodal !JImptom

How, then, can we define the Marxian symptom? Marx 'invented the symptom' (Lacan) by means of detecting a certain fissure, an asymmetry, a certain 'pathological' imbalance which belies the universalism of the bourgeois 'rights and duties'. This imbalance, far from announcing the 'imperfect realization' of these univ?rsal principles - that is, an insufficiency to be abolished by further development - functions as their constitutive moment: the 'symptom' is, strictly speaking, a particular element which subverts its own universal foundation, a species subverting its own genus. In this sense, we can say that the elementary Marxian procedure of ' criticism of ideology' is already 'symptomatic': it consists in detecting a point of breakdown hetero8enous to a given ideological field and at the same time necessary for that field to achieve its do sun:, its accomplished form.

This procedure thus implies a certain logic of exception: every ideological Universal - for example freedom, equality - is 'false' in so far as it necessarily includes a specific case which breaks its unity, lays open its falsity. Freedom, for example: a universal notion comprising a number of species (freedom of speech and press, freedom of consciousness, freedom of commerce, political freedom, and so on) but also, by means of a structural necessity, a specific freedom (that of the worker to sell freely his own labour on the market) which subverts this universal notion. That is to say, this

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freedom is the very opposite of effective freedom: by selling his labour 'freely', the worker loses his freedom - the real content of this free act of sale is the worker's enslavement to capitaL The crucial point is, of course, that it is precisely this paradoxical freedom, the form of its opposite, which closes the circle of ' bourgeois freedoms'.

The same can also be shown for fair, equivalent exchange, this ideal of the market. When, in pre-capitalist society, the production of commodities has not yet attained universal character - that is, when it is still so-called 'natural production' which predominates - the proprietors of the means of production are still themselves producers (as a rule, at least): it is artisan production; the proprietors themselves work and sell their products on the market. At this stage of development there is no exploitation (in principle, at least - that is, if we do not consider the exploitation of apprentices, and so on); the exchange on the market is equivalent, every commodity is paid its full value. But as soon as production for the market prevails in the economic edifice of a given society, this generalization is necessarily accompanied by the appearance of a new, paradoxical type of commodity: the labour force, the workers who are not themselves proprietors of the means of production and who are consequently obliged to sell on the market their own labour instead of the products of their labour.

With this new commodity, the equivalent exchang

odity, money: we say that the value of a certain commodity is such-and-such amount of money. Consequently, the essential feature of commodity fetishism does not consist of the famous replacement of men with things ('a relation between men assumes the form of a relation between things'); rather, it consists of a certain misrecognition which concerns the relation between a structured network and one of its elements: what is really a structural effect, an effect of the network of relations between elements, appears as an immediate property of one of the elements, as if this property also belongs to it outside its relation with other elements.

Such a misrecognition can take place in a 'relation between things' as well as in a 'relation between men' - Marx states this explicitly apropos of the simple form of the value-expression. The commodity A can express its value only by referring itself to another commodity, B, which thus becomes its equivalent: in the value relationship, the natural form of the commodity B (its use-value, its positive, empirical properties) functions as a form of value of the commodity A; in other words, the body of B becomes for A the mirror of its value. To these reflections, Marx added the following note:

In a sort of way, it is with man as with commodities. Since he comes into the world neither with a looking-glass in his hand, nor as a Fichtian philosopher, to whom 'I am I' is sufficient, man first sees and recognizes hirnselfin other men. Peter only establishes his own identity as a man

14 Marx, Capita/' Volume I, p. 77.

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by first comparing himself with Paul as being oftike kind. And thereby Paut, just as he stands in his Pauline personality, becomes to Peter the type of the genus homo.'5

This short note anticipates in a way the Lacanian theory of the mirror stage: only by being reflected in another man - that is, in so far as this other man offers it an image of its unity - can the ego arrive at its self-identity; identity and alienation are thus strictly correlative. Marx pursues this homology: the other commodity (B) is an equivalent only in so far as A relates to it as to the form-of-appearance of its own value, only within this relationship.

But the appearance -and herein lies the effectofinversion proper to fetishism - the appearance is exactly opposite: A seems to relate to B as if, for B, to be an equivalent of A would not be a 'reflexive determination' (Marx) of A - that is as ifB would alreatfy in itseffbe the equivalent of A; the property of 'being-an-equivalent' appears to belong to it even outside its relation to A, on the same level as its other 'natural' effective properties constituting its use-value.

To these reflections, Marx again added a very interesting note:

Such expressions of relations in general, called by Hegel reflex-categories, form a very curious class. For instance, one man is king only because other men stand in the relation of subjects to him. They, on the contrary, imagine that they are subjects because he is king.'6

'Being-a-king' is an effect of the network of social relations between a 'king' and his 'subjects'; but - and here is the fetishistic misrecognition - to the participants of this social bond, the relationship appears necessarily in an inverse form: they think that they are subjects giving the king royal treatment because the king is already in himself, outsid

products of labour'.
This is why one has to look for the discovery of the symptom in the way Marx conceived the passage from feudalism to capiralism. With the establishment of bourgeois society, the relations of domination and servitude are repressed: formally, we are apparently concerned with free subjects whose interpersonal relations are discharged of all fetishism; the repressed truth - that of the persistence of domination and servitude - emerges in a symptom which subverts the ideological appearance of equality, freedom, and so on. This symptom, the point of emergence of the truth about social relations, is precisely the 'social relations between things' - in contrast to feudal society, where
no matter what we may think of the parts played by the different classes of people themselves in this society, the social relations between individuals in the performance of their labour appear at all events as their own mutual personal relations, and are not disguised under the shape of social relations between things, between the products oflabour.'8
'Instead of appearing at all events as their own mutual relations, the social relations between individuals are disguised under the shape of social relations between things' - here we have a precise definition of the hysterical symptom, of the 'hysteria of conversion' proper to capitalism.
18
Marx, Capital, Volume I, p. 82.

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Here Marx is more subversive than the majority of his contemporary critics who discard the dialectics of commodity fetishism as outdated: this dialectics can still help us to grasp the phenomenon of so-called 'totalitarianism'. Let us take as our starting point Umberto Eco's Name f! the Rose, precisely because there is something wrong with this book. This criticism does not apply only to its ideology, which might be called - on the model of spaghetti Westerns - spaghetti structuralism: a kind of simplified, mass-culture version of structuralist and post-structuralist ideas (there is no final reality, we all live in a world of signs referring to other signs . . .).
What should bother us about this book is its basic underlying thesis: the source of totalitarianism is a dogmatic attachment to the official word: the lack of laughter, of ironic detachment. An excessive commitment to Good may in itselfhecome the greatest Evil: real Evil is any kind offanatical dogmatism, especially that exerted in the name of the supreme Good. This thesis is already part of the enlightened version of religious belief itself: if we become too obsessed with the Good and with a corresponding hate for the secular, our obsession with Good may itself turn into a force of Evil, a form of destructive hatred for all that fails to correspond to our idea of Good. The real Evil is the supposedly innocent gaze which perceives in the world nothing but Evil, as in The Tum cifthe Screw by Henry James, in which the real Evil is, of course, the gaze of the storyteller (the young governess) herself . . .
First, this idea of an obsession with (a fanatical devotion to) Good turning into Evil masks the inverse experience, which is much more disquieting: how an obsessive, fanatical attachment to Evil may in itself acquire the status of an ethical position, of a position which is not guided by our egoistical interests. Consider only Mozart's Don Giovanni at the end of the opera, wh

n The Ethic ofP!JIchoanafysis, distances himself from the liberating gesture of saying finally that 'the emperor has no clothes'. The point is, as Lacan puts it, that the emperor is naked only beneath his clothes, so if there is an unmasking gesture of psychoanalysis, it is closer to Alphonse Allais's well-known joke, quoted by Lacan: somebody points at a woman and utters a horrified cry, 'Look at her, what a shame, under her clothes, she is totally naked'.'9

But all this is already well known: it is the classic concept of ideology as 'false consciousness', misrecognition of the social reality which is part of this reality itself Our question is: Does this concept of ideology as a naive consciousness still apply to today's world? Is it still operating today? In the Critique of 9'nical Reason, a great bestseller in Germany, Peter Sloterdijk puts forward the thesis that ideology's dominant mode of functioning is cynical, which renders impossible - or, more precisely, vain -the classic critical-ideological procedure. The cynical subject is quite aware of the distance between the ideological mask and the social reality, but he none the less still insists upon the mask. The formula, as proposed by Sloterdijk, would then be: 'they know very well what they are doing, but still, they are doing it'. Cynical reason is no longer naive, but is a paradox

19 Jacques Lacan, Le slmillaire flll L'ethique de fa p!ycllanafyse, Paris: Seuil, 1986, p. 231.

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of an enlightened false consciousness: one knows the falsehood very well, one is well aware of a particular interest hidden behind an ideological universality, but still one does not renounce it.

We must distinguish this cynical position strictly from what Sloterdijk calls kynicism. Kynicism represents the popular, plebeian rejection of the official culture by means of irony and sarcasm: the classical kynical procedure is to confront the pathetic phrases of the ruling official ideology - its solemn, grave tonality - with everyday banality and to hold them up to ridicule, thus exposing behind the sublime noblesse of the ideological phrases the egotistical interests, the violence, the brutal claims to power. This procedure, then, is more pragmatic than argumentative: it subverts the official proposition by confronting it with the situation of its enunciation; it proceeds ad hominem (for example when a politician preaches the duty of patriotic sacrifice, kynicism exposes the personal gain he is making from the sacrifice of others).

Cynicism is the answer of the ruling culture to this kynical subversion: it recognizes, it takes into account, the particular interest behind the ideological universality, the distance between the ideological mask and the reality, but it still finds reasons to retain the mask. This cynicism is not a direct position of immorality, it is more like morality itself put in the service of immorality - the model of cynical wisdom is to conceive probity, integrity, as a supreme form of dishonesty, and morals as a supreme form of profligacy, the truth as the most effective form of a lie. This cynicism is therefore a kind of perverted 'negation of the negation' of the official ideology: confronted with illegal enrichment, with robbery, the cynical reaction consists in saying that legal enrichment is a lot more effective and, moreover, protected by the law. As Berrolt Brecht puts it

oney, they know very well
that there is nothing magical about it - that money, in its materiality, is simply an expression of social relations. The everyday spontaneous ideology reduces money to a simple sign giving the individual possessing it a right to a certain part of the social product. So, on an everyday level, the individuals know very well that there are relations between people behind the relations between things. The problem is that in their social activity itself, in what they are doing, they are acting as if money, in its material reality, is the immediate embodiment of wealth as such. They are fetishists in practice, not in theory. What they' do not know', what they misrecognize, is the fact that in their social reality itself, in their social activity - in the act of commodity exchange - they are guided by the fetishistic illusion.
To make this clear, let us again take the classic Marxian motive of the speculative inversion of the relationship between the Universal and the Particular. The Universal is just a property of particular objects which really exist, but when we are victims of commodity fetishism it appears as if the concrete content of a commodity (its use-value) is an expression of its abstract universality (its exchange-value) - the abstract Universal, the Value, appears as a real Substance which successively incarnates itself in a series of concrete objects. That is the basic Marxian thesis: it is already the effective world of commodities which behaves like a Hegelian subject-substance, like a Universal going through a series of particular embodiments. Marx speaks about 'commodity metaphysics', about the

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'religion of everyday life'. The roots of philosophical speculative idealism are in the social reality of the world of commodities; it is this world which behaves 'idealistically' - or, as Marx puts it in the first chapter of the first edition of Capital:
This inversion through which what is sensible and concrete counts only as a phenomenal form of what is abstract and universal, contrary to the real state of things where the abstract and the universal count only as a property of the concrete - such an inversion is characteristic of the expression of value, and it is this inversion which, at the same time, makes the understanding of this expression so difficult. If! say: Roman law and German law are both laws, it is something which goes by itsel£ But if, on the contrary, I say: THE Law, this abstract thing, realizes itself in Roman law and in German law, i.e. in these concrete laws, the interconnection becomes mystical.20
The question to ask again is: where is the illusion here? We must not forget that the bourgeois individual, in his everyday ideology, is definitely not a speculative Hegelian: he does not conceive the particular contentas resulting from an autonomous movement of the universal Idea. He is, on the contrary, a good Anglo-Saxon nominalist, thinking that the Universal is a property of the Particular - that is, of really existing things. Value in itself does not exist, there are just individual things which, among other properties, have value. The problem is that in his practice, in his real activity, he acts as if the particular things (the commodities) were just so many embodiments of universal Value. To rephrase Marx: He knows ve!J' well that Roman law and Genan law arejust two kinds o

human subjects) and things. But
a Lacanian reading can give this formulation a new, unexpected twist: the subversive power of Marx's approach lies precisely in the way he uses the opposition of persons and things.
In feudalism, as we have seen, relations between people are mystified, mediated through a web of ideological beliefs and superstitions. They are the relations between the master and his servant, whereby the master exerts his charismatic power of fascination, and so forth. Although in capitalism the subjects are emancipated, perceiving themselves as free from medieval religious superstitions, when they deal with one another they do so as rational utilitarians, guided only by their selfish interests. The point of Marx' s analysis, however, is that the things (commodities) themselves believe in their place, instead of the subjects: it is as if all their beliefs, superstitions and metaphysical mystifications, supposedly surmounted by the rational, utilitarian personality, are embodied in the 'social relations between things'. They no longer believe, but the things themselves believe for them.
This seems also to be a basic Lacanian proposition, contrary to the usual thesis that a beliefis something interior and knowledge something exterior (in the sense that it can be verified through an external procedure). Rather, it is belief which is radically exterior, embodied in the practical, effective procedure of people. It is similar to Tibetan prayer wheels: you write a

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prayer on a paper, put the rolled paper into a wheel, and turn it automatically, without thinking (or, if you want to proceed according to the Hegelian 'cunning of reason', you attach it to a windmill, so that it is moved around by the wind). In this way, the wheel itself is praying for me, instead of me - or, more precisely, I myself am praying through the medium of the wheel. The beauty of it all is that in my psychological inferiority I can think about whatever I want, I can yield to the most dirty and obscene fantasies, and it does not matter because - to use a good old Stalinist expression - whatever I am thinking, oijectivefy I am praying.
This is how we should grasp the fundamental Lacanian proposition that psychoanalysis is not a psychology: the most intimate beliefs, even the most intimate emotions such as compassion, crying, sorrow, laughter, can be transferred, delegated to others without losing their sincerity. In his seminar on The Ethic o/p.)lcoanafysis, Lacan speaks of the role of the Chorus in classical tragedy: we, the spectators, came to the theatre worried, full of everyday problems, unable to adj ust without reserve to the problems of the play, that is to feel the required fears and compassions - but no problem, there is the Chorus, who feels the sorrow and the compassion instead of us - or, more precisely, we feel the required emotions through the medium of the Chorus: 'You are then relieved of all worries, even if you do not feel anything, the Chorus will do so in your place'."
Even if we, the spectators, are just drowsily watching the show, objectively - to use again the old Stalinist expression - we are doing our duty of compassion for the heroes. In so-called primitive societies we find the same phenomenon in the form of'weepers', women hired to cry instead of us: so, through the medium of the other, we accomplish our duty of mourning

lity itselE
What we call 'social reality' is in the last resort an ethical construction;
it is supported by a certain as if(we act as ffwe believe in the almightiness
of bureaucracy, as ffthe President incarnates the will of the People, as if
the Party expresses the objective interest of the working class . . .). As soon
as the belief(which, let us remind ourselves again, is definitely not to be
conceived at a 'psychological' level: it is embodied, materialized, in the
effective functioning of the social field) is lost, the very texture of the social
field disintegrates. This was already articulated by Pascal, one ofAlthusser's
principal points of reference, in his attempt to develop the concept of'Ideo-
logical State Apparatuses'. According to Pascal, the interiority of our reason-
ing is determined by the external, nonsensical 'machine' - automatism of
the signifier, of the symbolic network in which the subjects are caught:
For we must make no mistake about ourselves: we are as much automa-
ton as mind . . . proofs only convince the mind; habit provides the
strongest proofs and those that are most believed. It inclines the
automaton, which leads the mind unconsciously along with it.22
Here Pascal produces the very Lacanian definition of the unconscious: 'the
automaton (i.e. the dead, senseless letter), which leads the mind
22
Blaise Pascal, Pens/cr, Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1966, p. 274.

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unconsciously [sans Ie savoi? with it'. It follows, from this constitutively
senseless character of the Law, that we must obey it not because it is just,
good or even beneficial, but simply because it is the law - this tautology
articulates the vicious circle of its authority, the fact that the last
foundation of the Law's authority lies in its process of enunciation:
Custom is the whole of equity for the sole reason that it is accepted.
That is the mystic basis of its authority. Anyone who tries to bring it
back to its first principle destroys it. '3
The only real obedience, then, is an 'external' one: obedience out of
conviction is not real obedience because it is already 'mediated' through
our subjectivity - that is, we are not really obeying the authority but
simply following our judgement, which tells us that the authority deserves
to be obeyed in so far as it is good, wise, beneficent . . . Even more than
for our relation to 'external' social authority, this inversion applies to our
obedience to the internal authority of belief it was Kierkegaard who wrote
that to believe in Christ because we consider him wise and good is a dread-
ful blasphemy - it is, on the contrary, only the act of belief itself which
can give us an insight into his goodness and wisdom. Certainly we must
search for rational reasons which can substantiate our belief, our obedience
to the religious command, but the crucial religious experience is that these
reasons reveal themselves only to those who already believe - we find
reasons attesting our belief because we already believe; we do not believe
because we have found sufficient good reasons to believe.
'External' obedience to the Law is thus not submission to external
pressure, to so-called non-ideological 'brute force', but obedience to the
Command in so far as it is 'incomprehensible', not understood; in so far
as it retains a 'traumatic', 'irrational' character: far from hiding its full
authority, this traumati

conditioned by your factual behav-
iour1 is the paradoxical status of a beliefbefore beli by following a custom, the subject believes without knowing it, so that the final conversion is merely a formal act by means of which we recognize what we have already believed. In other words, what the behaviourist reading of Pascalian 'custom' misses is the crucial fact that the external custom is always a material support for the subject's unconscious. The main achievement of Marek Kaniewska's film Another Countty is to designate, in a sensitive and delicate way, this precarious status of 'believing without knowing it' - precisely apropos of the conversion to Communism.
Another Countty is a film a clef about the relationship between two Cambridge students, the Communist Judd (real model: John Cornford, idol of the Oxford student left, who died in 1936 in Spain) and the rich homosexual Guy Bennett, who later becomes a Russian spy and tells the story in retrospect to an English journalist who visits him in his Moscow exil? (real model: Guy Burgess, of course). There is no sexual relationship between them; Judd is the only one who is not sensitive to Guy's charm ('the exception to the Bennett rule', as Guy puts it): precisely for that reason, he is the point of Guy's transferential identification.
The action occurs in the 'public school' environment of the thirties: the patriotic empty talk, the terror of the student-heads (‚gods') over ordinary students; yet in all this terror there is something non-binding, not quite serious; it has the ring of an amusing travesty concealing a universe in which enjoyment actually reigns in all its obscenity, above all in the form of a ramified network of homosexual relations - the real terror is, rather, the unbearable pressure of enjoyment. It is for this reason that Oxford and Cambridge in the 1930S offered such a rich field for the KGB: not only because of the 'guilt complex' of rich students doing so well in the midst of the economic and social crisis, but above all because of this stuffy atmosphere of enjoyment, the very inertia of which creates an unbearable tension, a tension which could be dissolved only by a 'totalitarian' appeal to renunciation of the enjoyment - in Germany, it was Hitler

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who knew how to occupy the place of this appeal; in England, at least among the elite students, the KGB hunters were best versed in it.
The film is worth mentioning for the way it depicts Guy's conversion: its delicacy is attested by the very fact that it does not depict it, that it only lays all the elements for it. That is to say, the flashback to the 1930S which occupies the main part of the film stops at the precise point at which Guy is already converted, although he does not yet know it - the film is delicate enough to leave out the formal act of conversion; it suspends the flashback in a situation homologous to one in which somebody is already in love but is not yet aware of it, and for this reason gives expression to his love in the form of an excessively cynical attitude and defensive agressivity towards the person with whom he is in love.
What is, then, looking doser, the denouement of the film? Two reactions to this situation of stuffy enjoyment are opposed: Judd's renunciation, his openly declared Communism (it is for this reason that he couldn't be a KGB agent), and on the other side Guy as a repres

entative of the extreme,
putrefied hedonism whose game, however, starts to £all apart (the 'gods' have humiliated him by a ritual beating because his personal enemy, a patriotic career seeker, has unmasked his homosexual relationship with a younger student: in this way, Guy lost a promised opportunity to become a 'god' himself the following year). At this point, Guy becomes aware of the fact that the key to the dissolution of his untenable situation lies in his transferential relationship to Judd: this is nicely indicated by two details.
First, he reproaches Judd for not himselfbeing liberated from bourgeois prejudices - in spite of all his talk about equality and fraternity, he still thinks that 'some persons are better than others because of the way they make love'; in short, he catches the subject on whom he has a transference in his inconsistency, in his lack. Second, he reveals to the naive Judd the very mechanism of transference: Judd thinks that his belief in the truth of Communism results from his thorough study of history and the texts of Marx, to which Guy replies, 'You are not a Communist because you understand Marx, you understand Marx because you are a Communistl'

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- that is to say, Judd understands Marx because he presupposes in advance that Marx is the bearer ofknowledge enabling access to the truth ofhistory, like the Christian believer who does not believe in Christ because he has been convinced by theological arguments but, on the contrary, is susceptible to theological arguments because he is already illuminated by the grace of belie£
In a first, naive approach it could appear that because of these two features Guy is on the brink ofliberating himself from his transference on Judd (he catches Judd in his inconsistency, and even unmasks the very mechanism of transference to boot), but the truth is none the less the opposite: these two features only confirm how 'those in the know are lost' [/cr non-dupcr eTTentJ, as Lacan would say. Precisely as one 'in the know', Guy is caught in transference - both reproaches of Judd receive their meaning only against the background that his relationship with Judd is already a transferential one (as with the analysand who finds such pleasure in discovering small weaknesses and mistakes in the analyst precisely because the transference is already at work).
The state in which Guy finds himselfimmediately before his conversion, this state of extreme tension, is best rendered by his own answer to Judd's reproach that he is himself to blame for the mess he is in (ifhe had only proceeded with a little discretion and hidden his homosexuality instead of flaunting it in a provocative and defiant way, there would have been no unpleasant disclosure to ruin him): 'What better cover for someone like me than total indiscretion?' This is, of course, the very Lacanian definition of deception in its specifically human dimension, where we deceive the Other by means of the truth itself: in a universe in which all are looking for the true face beneath the mask, the best way to lead them astray is to wear the mask of truth itsel£ But it is impossible to maintain the coincidence of mask and truth: far from gaining us a kind of'immediate contact with our fellow-men', this coincidence renders the situation unbearable; all communication is impossible because we are totally isolated through the ve

ry disclosure - the sine qua non of successful communication
is a minimum of distance between appearance and its hidden rear.

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The only door open is thus escape into belief in the transcendent
'another country' (Communism) and into conspiracy (becoming a KGB
agent), which introduces a radical gap between the mask and the true face.
So when, in the last scene of the flashback, Judd and Guy traverse the
college courtyard, Guy is already a believer: his fate is sealed, even if he
does not yet know it. His introductory words, 'Wouldn't it be wonderful
if Communism were really true?', reveal his belief, which is for the time
being still delegated, transferred on to another - and so we can immediately
pass on to the Moscow exile decades later where the only leftover of enjoy-
ment binding the old and crippled Guy to his country is the memory of
cricket.
Kafka, critic ojAlthusser
The externality of the symbolic machine (‚automaton') is therefore not
simply external: it is at the same time the place where the fate of our inter-
nal, most 'sincere' and 'intimate' beliefs is in advance staged and decided.
When we subject ourselves to the machine of a religious ritual, we already
believe without knowing it; our belief is already materialized in the exter-
nal ritual; in other words, we already believe unconsdousfy, because it is
from this external character of the symbolic machine that we can explain
the status of the unconscious as radically external - that of a dead letter.
Belief is an affair of obedience to the dead, uncomprehended letter. It is
this short-circuit between the intimate belief and the external 'machine'
which is the most subversive kernel of Pascali an theology.
of course, in his theory ofIdeological State Apparatuses, Althusser gave
an elaborated, contemporary version of this Pascalian 'machine';27 but the
weak point ofhis theory is that he or his school never succeeded in thinking
out the link between Ideological State Apparatuses and ideological inter-
pellation: how does the Ideological State Apparatus (the Pascalian
'machine', the signifYing automatism) 'internalize' itself; how does it
27 Louis Althusser, ES in Ideology, London: Verso, 1984.

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produce the effect of ideological belief in a Cause and the interconnecting
effect of subjectivarion, of recognition of one's ideological position? The
answer to this is, as we have seen, that this external 'machine' of State
Apparatuses exercises its force only in so far as it is experienced, in the uncon-
scious economy of the subject, as a traumatic, senseless injunction. Althusser
speaks only of the process of ideological interpellation through which the
symbolic machine ofideology is 'internalized' into the ideological experience
of Meaning and Truth: but we can learn from pascal that this 'internalization',
by structural necessity, never fully succeeds, that there is always a residue,
a leftover, a stain of traumatic irrationality and senselessness sticking to it,
and that this leftover, far .from hinderil18 the foIl submission 0/ the subject to the
ideological command, is the ve!y condition o/it: it is precisely this non-integrated
surplus of senseless traumatism which confers on the Law its unconditional
authority: in other words, which - in so far as it escapes ideological sense -
sustains what we might call the

: a little scene, a small story, which includes this
irritating element. However, the external irritation soon becomes too
strong and the subject is awakened.
The Lacanian reading is directly opposed to this. The subject does
not awake himself when the external irritation becomes too strong; the
logic of his awakening is quite different. First he constructs a dream, a
story which enables him to prolong his sleep, to avoid awakening into
reality. But the thing that he encounters in the dream, the reality of his
desire, the Lacanian Real - in our case, the reality of the child's reproach
to his father, 'Can't you see that I am burning?', implying the father's
fundamental guilt - is more terrifying than so-called external reality
itsel£ and that is why he awakens: to escape the Real of his desire, which
announces itselfin the terrifying dream. He escapes into so-called reality
to be able to continue to sleep, to maintain his blindness, to elude awak-
ening into the Real of his desire. We can rephrase here the old 'hippy'
motto of the 1960s: reality is for those who cannot support the dream.
'Reality' is a fantasy-construction which enables us to mask the Real of
our desire!9
It is exactly the same with ideology. Ideology is not a dreamlike illusion
that we build to escape insupportable reality; in its basic dimension it is
a fantasy-construction which serves as a support for our 'reality' itself: an
'illusion' which structures our effective, real social relations and thereby
masks some insupportable, real, impossible kernel (conceptualized by
Emesto Laclau and Chantal Mouffe as 'antagonism': a traumatic social
division which cannot be symbolized). The function of ideology is not to
offer us a point of escape from our reality but to offer us the social reality
itself as an escape from some traumatic, real kernel. To explain this logic,
let us refer again to The Four Fundamental Concepts o/PZcho-Anafysis.I° Here
Lacan mentions the well-known paradox ofZhuang Zi, who dreamt of
being a butterfly, and after his awakening posed himself a question: how
29 Jacques Lacan, The Four FundameJZtal Concepts I!fPsycho Anafysis, Harmondsworth:
Penguin, 1979, chapters 5 and 6.
30 Ibid., Chapter 6.

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does he know that he is not now a butterfly dreaming of being Zhuang
Zi? Lacan's commentary is that this question is justified, for two reasons.
First, it proves that Zhuang Zi was not a fool. The Lacanian definition
of a fool is somebody who believes in his immediate identity with himself;
somebody who is not capable of a dialectically mediated distance towards
himself, like a king who thinks he is a king, who takes his being-a-king
as his immediate property and not as a symbolic mandate imposed on
him by a network of inter subjective relations of which he is a part (example
of a king who was a fool thinking he was a king: Ludwig II of Bavaria,
Wagner's patron).
However, this is not all; ifit were, the subject could be reduced to a
void, to an empty place in which his or her whole content is procured
by others, by the symbolic network of inter subjective relations: I am 'in
myself a nothingness, the positive content of myself is what I am for
others. In other words, if this were all, Lacan's last word would be a
radical alienation of the subject. His content, 'what he is', would be
determined by an exterior signifying network offering him the points
o

ble: we find the same paradox in a well-known drawing by Escher of two hands drawing each other.

The Lacanian thesis is, on the contrary, that there is always a hard kernel, a leftover which persists and cannot be reduced to a universal play of illusory mirroring. The difference between Lacan and 'naive realism' is that for Lacan, the onfy point at which we approach this hard kernel of tile Real is indeed the dream. When we awaken into reality after a dream, we usually say to ourselves 'it was just a dream', thereby blinding ourselves to the fact that in our everyday, wakening reality we are nothil18 but a cOl1sdOUSI1e5S of this dream. It was only in the dream that we approached the fantasy-framework which determines our activity, our mode of acting in reality itsel£

It is the same with the ideological dream, with the determination of ideology as a dreamlike construction hindering us from seeing the real state of things, reality as such. In vain do we try to break out of the ideological dream by 'opening our eyes and trying to see reality as it is', by throwing away the ideological spectacles: as the subjects of such a post-ideological, objective, sober look, free of so-called ideological prejudices, as the subjects of a look which views the facts as they are, we remain throughout 'the consciousness of our ideological dream'. The only way to break the power of our ideological dream is to confront the Real of our desire which announces itself in this dream.

Let us examine anti-Semitism. It is not enough to say that we must liberate ourselves from so-called 'anti-Semitic prejudices' and learn to see Jews as they really are - in this way we will certainly remain victims of these so-called prejudices. We must confront ourselves with how the ideological figure of the 'Jew' is invested with our unconscious desire, with how we have constructed this figure to escape a certain deadlock of our desire.

Let us suppose, for example, that an objective look would confirm - why not? - that Jews really do financially exploit the rest of the population, that they do sometimes seduce our young daughters, that some of them do not wash regularly. Is it not clear that this has nothing to do with the

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real roots of our anti-Semitism? Here, we have only to remember the Lacanian proposition concerning the pathologically jealous husband: even if all the facts he quotes in support of his jealousy are true, even if his wife really is sleeping around with other men, this does not change one bit the fact that his jealousy is a pathological, paranoid construction.

Let us ask ourselves a simple question: in the Germany of the late 1930S, what would be the result of such a non-ideological, objective approach? Probably something like: 'The Nazis are condemning the Jews too hastily, without proper argument, so let us take a cool, sober look and see if they are really guilty or not; let us see if there is some truth in the accusations against them.' Is it really necessary to add that such an approach would merely confirm our so-called 'unconscious prejudices' with additional rationalizations? The proper answer to anti-Semitism is therefore not 'Jews are really not like that' but 'the anti-Semitic idea ofJew has nothing to do with Jews; the ideological figure of a Jew is a way to stitch up the inconsistency of our own ideological system.'

That is why we are al

so unable to shake so-called ideological prejudices
by taking into account the pre-ideological level of everyday experience.
The basis of this argument is that the ideological construction always
finds its limits in the field of everyday experience - that it is unable to
reduce, to contain, to absorb and annihilate this level. Let us again take a
typical individual in Germany in the late 1930S. He is bombarded by
anti-Semitic propaganda depicting a Jew as a monstrous incarnation of
Evil, the great wire-puller, and so on. But when he returns home he
encounters Mr Stern, his neighbour, a good man to chat with in the
evenings, whose children play with his. Does not this everyday experience
offer an irreducible resistance to the ideological construction?
The answer is, of course, no. If everyday experience offers such a resist-
ance, then the anti-Semitic ideology has not yet really grasped us. An ideol-
0gy is really 'holding us' only when we do not feel any opposition between
it and reality - that is, when the ideology succeeds in determining the
mode of our everyday experience of reality itselE How then would our
poor German, ifhe were a good anti-Semite, react to this gap between the

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ideological figure of the Jew (schemer, wire-puller, exploiting our brave
men and so on) and the common everyday experience of his good neigh-
bour, Mr Stern? His answer would be to turn this gap, this discrepancy
itself, into an argument for anti-Semitism: 'You see how dangerous they
really are? It is difficult to recognize their real nature. They hide it behind
the mask of everyday appearance - and it is exactly this hiding of one's
real nature, this duplicity, that is a basic feature of the Jewish nature.' An
ideology really succeeds when even the facts which at first sight contradict
it start to function as arguments in its favour.
Surplus-value and surplus-e'!ioyment
Herein lies the difference from Marxism: in the predominant Marxist
perspective the ideological gaze is a partial gaze overlooking the totali[Y of
social relations, whereas in the Lacanian perspective ideology rather
designates a totali[Y seton ifciT18 the tracesofits own impossibili[Y. This differ-
ence corresponds to the one which distinguishes the Freudian from the
Marxian notion of fetishism: in Marxism a fetish conceals the positive
network of social relations, whereas in Freud a fetish conceals the lack
('castration,) around which the symbolic network is articulated.
In so far as we conceive the Real as that which 'always returns to the same
place', we can deduce another, no less crucial difference. From the Marxist
point of view, the ideological procedure par excellence is that of folse' etemal-
ization and/or universalization:. a state which depends on a concrete historical
conjunction appears as an eternal, universal feature of the human c?ndition;
the interest of a particular class disguises itself as universal human interest
. . . and the aim of the 'criticism of ideology' is to denounce this false
universality, to detect behind man in general the bourgeois individual;
behind the universal rights of man the form which renders possible capitalist
exploitation; behind the 'nuclear family' as a trans-historical constant the
historically specified and limited form of kinship relations, and so on.
In the Lacanian perspective, we should change the terms and desig-
nate as the most

'cunning' ideological procedure the very opposite of

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externalization: an over-rapid histon"cization. Let us take one of the common-places of the Marxist-feminist criticism of psychoanalysis, the idea that its insistence on the crucial role of the Oedipus complex and the nuclear-family triangle transforms a historically conditioned form of patriarchal family into a feature of the universal human condition: is not this effort to historicize the family triangle precisely an attempt to elude the 'hard kernel' which announces itself through the 'patriarchal family' - the Real of the Law, the rock of castration? In other words, if over-rapid universal-ization produces a quasi-universal Image whose function is to make us blind to its historical, socio-symbolic determination, over-rapid historicization makes us blind to the real kernel which returns as the same through diverse historicizations/symbolizations.

It is the same with a phenomenon that designates most accurately the 'perverse' obverse of twentieth-century civilization: concentration camps. All the different attempts to attach this phenomenon to a concrete image ('Holocaust', 'Gulag' . . "), to reduce it to a product of a concrete social order (Fascism, Stalinism . . .) - what are they if not so many attempts to elude the fact that we are dealing here with the 'real' of our civilization which returns as the same traumatic kernel in all social systems? (We should not forget that concentration camps were an invention of ' liberal' England, dating from the Boer War; that they were also used in the US to isolate the Japanese population, and so on.)

Marxism, then, did not succeed in taking into account, coming to terms with, the surplus-object, the leftover of the Real eluding symbolization - a fact all the more surprising if we recall that Lacan modelled his notion of surplus-enjoyment on the Marxian notion of surplus-value. The proof that Marxian surplus-value announces effectively the logic of the Lacanian objet petit a as the embodiment of surplus-enjoyment is already ptovided by the decisive formula used by Marx, in the third volume of Capital, to designate the logical-historical limit of capitalism: 'the limit of capital is capital itself, i.e. the capitalist mode of production'.

This formula can be read in two ways. The first, usual historicist-evolutionist reading conceives it, in accordance with the unfortunate

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paradigm of the dialectics of productive forces and relations of production, as that of' content' and 'form'. This paradigm follows roughly the metaphor of the serpent which, from time to time, sheds its skin, which has grown too tight: one posits as the last impetus of social development - as its (so to speak) 'natural', 'spontaneous' constant - the incessant growth of the productive forces (as a rule reduced to technical development); this ' spon-taneous' growth is then followed, with a greater or lesser degree of delay, by the inert, dependent moment, the relationship of production. We have thus epochs in which the relations of production are in accordance with the productive forces, then those forces develop and outgrow their 'social clothes', the frame of relationships; this frame becomes an obstacle to their further development, until social revolution again co-ordinates forces and relations by

replacing the old relations with new ones which correspond
to the new state of forces.
If we conceive the formula of capital as its own limit from this point
of view, it means simply that the capitalist relation of production which
at first made possible the fast development of productive forces became
at a certain point an obstacle to their further development: that these
forces have outgrown their frame and demand a new form of social
relations.
Marx himself is of course far from such a simplistic evolutionary idea.
If we need convincing of this, we have only to look at the passages in
Capitalwhere he deals with the relation between formal and real subsump-
tion of the process of production under Capital: the formal subsumption
precedesthe real one; that is, Capital first subsumes the process of production
as it found it (artisans, and so on), and only subsequently does it change
the productive forces step by step, shaping them in such a way as to create
correspondence. Contrary to the above-mentioned simplistic idea, it is
then the flnn of the relation of production which drives the development
of productive forces - that is, of its 'content'.
All we have to do to render impossible the simplistic evolutionary
reading of the formula 'the limit of capital is capital itself is to ask a very
simple and obvious question: how do we define, exactly, the moment -

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albeit only an ideal one - at which the capitalist relation of production
become an obstacle to the further development of the productive forces?
Or the obverse of the same question: when can we speak of an accordance
between productive forces and relation of production in the capitalist
mode of production? Strict analysis leads to only one possible answer:
never.
This is exactly how capitalism differs from other, previous modes of
production: in the latter, we can speak of periods of'accordance' when the
process of social production and reproduction goes on as a quiet, circular
movement, and of periods of convulsion when the contradiction
between forces and relations aggravates itself; whereas in capitalism
this contradiction, the discord forces/relations, is contained in its ve!y concept
(in the form of the contradiction between the social mode of production
and the individual, private mode of appropriation). It is this internal
contradiction which compels capitalism to permanent extended repro-
duction - to the incessant development of its own conditions of production,
in contrast to previous modes of production where, at least in their 'normal'
state, [re)production goes on as a circular movement.
If this is so, then the evolutionist reading of the formula of capital as
its own limit is inadequate: the point is not that, at a certain moment of
its development, the frame of the relation of production starts ro constrict
further development of the productive forces; the point is that it is t/zis
ve!y immanent limit, this 'internal contradiction? which drives capitalism into
permanent development. The 'normal' state of capitalism is the permanent
revolutionizing of its own conditions of existence: from the very beginning
capitalism 'putrefies', it is branded by a crippling contradiction, discord,
by an immanent want of balance: this is exactly why it changes, develops
incessantly - incessant development is the only way for it to resolve again
and again, come to terms wi

he fact that in the field of the
signifier and only in this field, we can change, we can bring about the past?
The past exists as it is included, as it enters (into) the synchronous net of the signifier - that is, as it is symbolized in the texture of the historical memory -and that is why we are all the time 'rewriting history', retroactively giving the elements their symbolic weight by including them in new textures - it is this elaboration which decides retroactively what they 'will have been'. The Oxford philosopher Michael Dummett has written two very interesting articles included in his collection of essays Truth and Other fniomas: 'Can an Effect Precede its Cause?' and 'Bringing About the Past': the Lacanian answer to these two enigmas would be: yes, because the symptom as a 'return of the repressed' is precisely such an effect which precedes its cause (its hidden kernel, its meaning), and in working through the symptom we are precisely 'bringing about the past' - we are producing the symbolic reality of past, long-forgotten traumatic events.
One is therefore tempted to see in the 'time paradox' of science-fiction novels a kind of hallucinatory 'apparition in the Real' of the elementary structure of the symbolic process, the so-called internal, internally inverted eight: a circular movement, a kind of snare where we can progress only in such a manner that we 'overtake' ourselves in the transference, to find ourselves later at a point at which we have already been. The paradox consists in the fact that this superfluous detour, this supplementary snare of overtaking ourselves ('voyage into the future') and then reversing the time direction ('voyage into the past') is not just a subjective illusionj perception of an objective process taking place in so-called reality independently of these illusions. That supplementary snare is, rather, an internal condition, an internal constituent of the so-called 'objective' process itself only through this additional detour does the past itself, the 'objective' state of things, become retroactively what it always was. Transference is, then, an illusion, but the point is that we cannot bypass it and reach directly for the Truth: the Truth itself is constituted throUfJh

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the illusion proper to the transference - 'the Truth arises from misrecognition' (Lacan). If this paradoxical structure is not yet clear, let us take another science-fiction example, William Tenn's well-known story 'The Discovery of Morniel Mathaway'. A distinguished art historian takes a journey in a time machine from the rwenty-fifth century to our day to visit and study in vivo the immortal Morniel Mathaway, a painter not appreciated in our time but later discovered to have been the greatest painter of the era. When he encounters him, the art historian finds no trace of a genius, just an imposter, a megalomaniac, even a swindler who steals his time machine from him and escapes into the future, so that the poor art historian stays tied to our time. The only action open to him is to assume the identity of the escaped Mathaway and to paint under his name all his masterpieces that he remembers from the future - it is he himself who is really the misrecognized genius he was looking for!
This, therefore, is the basic paradox we are aiming at: the subject is confronted with a scene from the past that he wants to change, to me

lready part of the state of things we are looking
at, the way our error is part of the Truth itsel£ This paradoxical structure
in which the Truth arises from misrecognition also gives us the answer
to the question: why is the transference necessary, why must the analysis
go through it? The transference is an essential illusion by means of which
the final Truth (the meaning of a symptom) is produced.
We find the same logic of the error as an internal condition of truth
with Rosa Luxemburg, with her description of the dialectics of the revo-
lutionary process. We are alluding here to her argument against Eduard
Bernstein, against his revisionist fear of seizing power 'too soon', 'prema-
turely', before the so-called 'objective conditions' had ripened - this was,
as is well known, Bernstein's main reproach to the revolutionary wing of
social democracy: they are too impatient, they want to hasten, to outrun
the objective logic of historical development. Rosa Luxemburg's answer
is that the first seizures of power are necessanfy 'premature': the only way
for the working class to reach its 'maturity', to await the arrival of the
'appropriate moment' for the seizure of power, is to form itself, to educate
itself for this act of seizure, and the only possible way of achieving this
education is precisely the 'premature' attempts . . . If we merely wait for
the 'appropriate moment' we will never live to see it, because this 'appro-
priate moment' cannot arrive without the subjective conditions of the
maturity of the revolutionary force (subject) being fulfilled - that is, it
, can arrive only after a series of'premature', failed attempts. The opposition
to the 'premature' seizure of power is thus revealed as opposition to the
seizure of power as such, in general: to repeat Robespierre's famous phrase,
the revisionists want a 'revolution without revolution'.
If we look at this closely, we perceive that what is at stake in Rosa
Luxemburg's argument is precisely the impossibility of metalanguage in
the revolutionary process: the revolutionary subject does not 'conduct',
'direct' this process from an objective distance, he is constituted through

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this process, and because of this - because the temporality of the revolution
passes through subjectivity - we cannot 'make the revolution at *e right
moment' without the previous 'premature', failed attempts. Here; in the
opposition between Bernstein and Luxemburg, we have the opposition
between the obsessional (man) and the hysterical (woman): the obsessional
is delaying, putting off the act, waiting for the right moment, while the
hysteric (so to speak) overtakes herself in her act and thus unmasks the
falsity of the obsessional's position. This is also what is at stake in Hegel's
theory of the role of repetition in history: 'a political revolution is generally
sanctioned by the opinion of the people only when it is renewed' - that
is, it can succeed only as a repetition of a first failed attempt. Why this
need for repetition?
Hegel developed his theory of repetition apropos of the case of Julius
Caesar's death: when Caesar consolidated his personal power and strength-
ened it to imperial proportions, he acted 'objectively' (in itselfj in accor-
dance with historical truth, historical necessity - the Republican form was
losing its validity, the only form of government which could save the
unity of the Roman st

ate was monarchy, a state based upon the will of a
single individual; but it was still the Republic which prevailed formally
(for itself, in the opinion of the people) - the Republic 'was still alive only
because she forgot that she was already dead', to paraphrase the famous
Freudian dream of the father who did not know he was already dead: 'His
father was alive once more and was talking to him in his usual Wq,Y, but [the
remarkable thing was thaJ he had realfy died, onfy he did not know it.4
To the ' opinion' which still believed in the Republic, Caesar's amassing
of personal power - which was, of course, contrary to the spirit of the
Republic - appeared an arbitrary act, an expression of contingent individual
self-will: the conclusion was that if this individual (Caesar) were to be
removed, the Republic would regain its full splendour. But it was precisely
the conspirators against Caesar (Brutus, Cassius, and the others) who -
following the logic of the 'cunning of reason' - attested the Truth (that
4 Freud, The Interpretation o/Dreams, p. 559.

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is, the historical necessity) of Caesar: the final result, the outcome of
Caesar's murder, was the reign of Augustus, the first caesar. The Truth
thus arose from failure itself in failing, in missing its express goal, the
murder of Caesar fulfilled the task which was, in a Machiavellian way,
assigned to it by history: to exhibit the historical necessity by denouncing
its own non-truth - its own arbitrary, contingent character.;
The whole problem of repetition is here: in this passage from Caesar
(the name of an individual) to caesar (title of the Roman emperor). The
murder of Caesar - historical personality - provoked, as its final result,
the installation of caesarism: Caesar-person repeats itself as caesar-title. What
is the reason, the driving force, of this repetition? At first sight the answer
seems to be clear: the delay of the consciousness as to the 'objective' histor-
ical necessity. A certain act through which breaks historical necessity is
perceived by the consciousness (the 'opinion of the people') as arbitrary,
as something which also could not have happened; because of this percep-
tion people try to do away with its consequences, to restore the old state
of things, but when this act repeats itselfit is finally perceived as an expres-
sion of the underlying historical necessity. In other words, repetition is
the way historical necessity asserts itself in the eyes of'opinion'.
But such an idea of repetition rests upon the epistemologically naive
presupposition of an objective historical necessity, persisting independ-
ently of consciousness (of the ' opinion of the people') and asserting itself
finally through repetition. What is lost in this notion is the way so-called
historical necessity itself is constituted through misrecognition, through the
initial failure of'opinion' to recognize its true character - that is, the way
truth itself arises from misrecognition. The crucial point here is the
changed symbolic status of an event: when it erupts for the first time it
is experienced as a contingent trauma, as an intrusion of a certain non-
symbolized Real; only through repetition is this event recognized in its
symbolic necessity - it finds its place in the symbolic network; it is
5
G. W. F. Hegel, !lor/esul7gen aber die philosophie del' Gesdzidzte, Frankfurt: Surkhamp
Verlag, 19

nomenology oj
Spirit; Mansfield Park the Sdence oj"Logic and Emma the Encyclopaedia . . . No wonder, then, that we find in Pride and Prejudice the perfect case of this dialectic of truth arising from misrecognition. Although they belong to different social classes - he is from an extremely rich aristocratic family, she from the impoverished middle classes - Elizabeth and Darcy feel a strong mutual attraction. Because of his pride, his love appears to Darcy as something unworthy; when he asks for Elizabeth's hand he confesses openly his contempt for the world to which she belongs and expects her to accept his proposition as an unheard-of honour. But because of her prejudice, Elizabeth sees him as ostentatious, arrogant and vain: his condescending proposal humiliates her, and she refuses him.
This double failure, this mutual misrecognition, possesses a structure of a double movement of communication where each subject receives from the other its own message in the inverse form: Elizabeth wants to present herself to Darcy as a young cultivated woman, fun of wit, and she gets from him the message 'you are nothing but a poor empty-minded creature,

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full offaIse jines-sf; Darcy wants to present himself to her as a proud gentleman, and he gets from her the message 'your pride is nothing but contemptible arrogance'. After the break in their relationship each discovers, through a series of accidents, the true nature of the other - she the sensitive and tender nature of Darcy, he her real dignity and wit - and the novel ends as it should, with their marriage.
The theoretical interest of this story lies in the fact that the failure of their first encounter, the double misrecognition concerning the real nature of the other, functions as a positive condition of the final outcome: we cannot go directly for the truth, we cannot say, 'If, from the very beginning, she had recognized his real nature and he hers, their story could have ended at once with their marriage.' Let us take as a comical hypothesis that the first encounter of the future lovers. was a success - that Elizabeth had accepted Darcy's first proposal. What would happen? Instead ofbeing bound together in true love they would become a vulgar everyday couple, a liaison of an arrogant, rich man and a pretentious, empty-minded young girl. If we want to spare ourselves the painful roundabout route through the misrecognition, we miss the Truth itself: only the 'working-through' of the misrecognition allows us to accede to the true nature of the other and at the same time to overcome our own deficiency - for Darcy, to free himself of his false pride; for Elizabeth, to get rid of her prejudices.
These two movements are interconnected because Elizabeth encounters, in Darcy's pride, the inverse image of her own prejudices; and Darcy, in Elizabeth's vanity, the inverse image of his own false pride. In other words, Darcy's pride is not a simple, positive state of things existing independently of his relationship with Elizabeth, an immediate property ofhis nature; it takes place, it appears, onfy flom the perspective ofher prgudices, vice versa, Elizabeth is a pretentious empty-minded girl onfy in Darry's arrogant view. To articulate things in Hegelian terms: in the perceived deficiency of the other, each perceives- - without knowing it - the fllsity 0/ his/herownsuijective position; the deficiency

nalytic cure, the dissolution of trans-
ference and 'going through the fantasy': when the Pole breaks out in fury he has already stepped out of transference, but he has yet to traverse his fantasy - this is achieved only by realizing how, through his deception, the Jew has kept his word. The fascinating' secret' which drives us to follow the Jew's narration carefully is precisely the Lacanian oijet petit a, the chimerical object of fantasy, the object causing our desire and at the same time - this is its paradox - posed retroactively by this desire; in 'going through the fmtasy' we experience how this fantasy-object (the 'secret') only materializes the void of our desire.

Another well-known joke possesses exactly the same structure, but this is usually overlooked - we are referring, of course, to the joke about the Door of the Law from the ninth chapter of Kafka's Tn·a!, to its final turn-around when the dying man from the country asks the door-keeper: 'Everyone strives to attain the law, how does it come about, then, that in all these years no one has come seeking admittance but me?' The door-keeper perceives that the man is at the end of his strength and his hearing is failing, so he bellows in his ear: 'N a one but you could

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gain admittance through this door, since the door was intended only for you. I am now going to shut it.'6

This final twist is perfectly homologous to the one at the end of the story about the Pole and the Jew: the subject experiences how he (his desire) was part of the game from the very beginning, how the entrance was meant only for him, how the stake of the narration was only to capture his desire. We could even invent another ending for Kafka's story to bring it nearer to the joke about the Pole and the Jew: after the long wait, the man from the country breaks out in fury and begins to cry at the door-keeper: 'You dirty rascal, why do you pretend to guard the entrance to some enormous secret, when you know very well that there is no secret beyond the door, that this door is intended only for me, to capture my desire!' and the door-keeper (if he were an analyst) would answer him calmly: 'You see, now you've discovered the real secret: beyond the door is only what your desire introduces there . . . '

In both cases, the nature of the final twist follows the Hegelian logic of surmounting, of abolishing the 'bad infinity'. That is to say, in both cases the starting point is the same: the subject is confronted with some substantial Truth, a secret from which he is excluded, which evades him ad infinitum - the inaccessible heart of the Law beyond the infinite series of doors; the unattainable last answer, the last secret of how the Jews extract money from us, awaiting us at the end of the Jew's narration (which could go on ad infinitum). And the solution is the same in both cases: the subject has to grasp how, from the very start of the game, the door concealing the secret was meant only for him, how the real secret at the end of the Jew's narration is his own desire - in short, how his external position vis-a-vis the Other (the fact that he experiences himself as excluded from the secret of the Other) is internal to the Other itsel£ Here we encounter a kind of , reflexivity' which cannot be reduced to philosophical reflection: the very feature which seems to exclude the subject from the Other (his

6 Kafka,

Ymptom
This dialectics of overtaking ourselves towards the future and simultaneous retroactive modification of the past - dialectics by which the error is internal to the truth, by which the misrecognition possesses a positive ontological dimension - has, however, its limits; it stumbles on to a rock upon which it becomes suspended. This rock is of course the Real, that which resists symbolization: the traumatic point which is always missed but none the less always returns, although we try - through a set of different strategies - to neutralize it, to integrate it into the symbolic order. In the perspective of the last stage ofLacanian teaching, it is precisely the symptom which is conceived as such a real kernel of enjoyment, which persists as a surplus and returns through all attempts to domesticate it, to gentrifY it (if we may be permitted to use this term adapted to designate strategies to domesticate the slums as 'symptoms' of our cities), to dissolve it by means of explication, of putting-into-words its meaning.
To exemplify this shift of emphasis in the concept of symptom in Lacan's teaching, let us take a case which is today again attracting public attention: the wreck of the Titanic. of course, it is already a commonplace to read Titanicas a symptom in the sense of'knot of meanings': the sinking of the Titanic had a traumatic effect, it was a shock, 'the impossible happened', the unsinkable ship had sunk; but the point is that precisely as a shock, this sinking arrived at its proper time - 'the time was waiting for it': even before it actually happened, there was already a place opened, reserved for it in fantasy-space. It had such a terrific impact on the 'social imaginary' by virtue of the fact that it was expected. It was foretold in amazing detail:
In 1898 a sttuggling author named Morgan Robertson concocted a novel about a fabulous Atlantic liner, far larger than any that had ever been built. Robertson loaded his ship with rich and complacent people

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and then wrecked it one cold April night on an iceberg. This somehow showed the futility of everything, and in fact, the book was called Futiliry when it appeared that year, published by the firm of M. F. Mansfield.
Fourteen years later a British shipping company named the White Star Line built a steamer remarkably like the one in Robertson's novel. The new liner was 66,000 tons displacement; Robertson's was 70,000. The real ship was 882.5 feet long; the fictional one was 800 feet. Both vessels were triple screw and could make 24-25 kno?s. Both could carry about 3,000 people, and both had enough lifeboats for only a fraction of this number. But, then, this did not seem to matter because both were labeled 'unsinkable'.
On April 1 0, 1912, the real ship left Southampton on her maiden voyage to New York. Her cargo included a priceless copy of the Rubajyat ojOmar Khayyam and a list of passengers collectively worth two hundred and fifty million dollars. On her way over she too struck an iceberg and went down on a cold April night.
Robertson called his ship the Titan; the White Star Line called its ship the Titanid
The reasons, the background for this incredible coincidence, are not difficult to guess: at the turn of the century, it was already part of the Zeitgeist that a certain age was coming to an end - the age of peaceful progress, of well-defined and stable class dis

ts symbolic
status, by providing it with a meaning. We usually say that the fascinating presence of a Thing obscures its meaning; here, the opposite is true: the meaning obscures the terrifying impact of its presence.

From !ymptom to sinthome

This, then, is the symptom - and it is on the basis of this notion of the symptom that we must locate the fact that in the final years of Lacan's teaching we find a kind of universalization of the symptom: almost everything that is becomes in a way symptom, so that finally even woman is determined as the symptom of man. We can even say that 'symptom' is Lacan's final answer to the eternal philosophical question 'Why is there something instead of nothing?' - this 'something' which 'is' instead of nothing is indeed the symptom.

The general reference of the philosophical discussion is usually the triangle world - language-subject, the relation of the subject to the world of objects, mediated through language; Lacan is usually reproached for his 'absolutism of the signifier' - the reproach is that he does not take into account the objective world, that he limits his theory to the interplay of subject and language; as if the objective world does not exist, as ifit is only the imaginary effect-illusion of the signifier's play. But Lacan's answer to this reproach is that not only does the world - as a given whole of objects - not exist, but that neither do language and subject exist: it is already a classic Lacanian thesis that 'the big Other [that is, the symbolic order as a consistent, closed totality] does not exist', and the subject is denoted by $, the crossed, blocked S, a void, an empty place in the signifier's structure.

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At this point we must of course ask ourselves the naive but necessary question: if the world and language and subject do not exist, what does exist; more precisely: what confers on existing phenomena their consistency? Lacan's answer is, as we have already indicated, symptom. To this answer, we must give its whole anti-post-structuralist emphasis: the fundamental gesture of post-structuralism is to deconstruct every substantial identity, to denounce behind its solid consistency an interplay of symbolic overdetermination -briefly, to dissolve the substantial identity into a network of non-substantial, differential relations; the notion of symptom is the necessary counterpoint to it, the substance of enjoyment, the real kernel around which this signifying interplay is structured.

To seize the logic of this universalization of symptom, we must connect it with another universalization, that of foreclosure (VerweifUng). In his unpublished Seminar, J.-A. Miller ironically spoke of the passage from special to general theory of foreclosure (alluding, of course, to Einstein's passage from special to general theory of relativity). When Lacan introduced the notion offoreclosure in the 1950S, it designated a specific phenomenon of the exclusion of a certain key-signifier (point de capitan, Name-of-the-Father) from the symbolic order, triggering the psychotic process; here, the foreclosure is not proper to language as such but a distinctive feature of the psychotic phenomena. And, as Lacan reformulated Freud, what was foreclosed from the Symbolic returns in the Real - in the form ofhallucinatory phenomena, for example.

However, in the last years of his teaching Lacan gave universal

even after the completed interpretation, the subject is not prepared to renounce his symptom; that is why he 'loves his symptom more than himself. In locating this dimension of enjoyment in the symptom, Lacan proceeded in two stages.

First, he tried to isolate this dimension of enjoyment as that offantCl9', and to oppose symptom and fantasy through a whole set of distinctive features: symptom is a signifying formation which, so to speak, 'overtakes itself towards its interpretation - that is, which can be analysed; fantasy is an inert construction which cannot be analysed, which resists interpretation. Symptom implies and addresses some non-barred, consistent big Other which will retroactively confer on it its meaning; fantasy implies a crossed-out, blocked, barred, non-whole, inconsistent Other - that is to say, it is filling out a void in the Other. Symptom (for example, a slip of the tongue) causes discomfort and displeasure when it occurs, but we embrace its interpretation with pleasure; we explain gladly to others the meaning of our slips; their 'intersubjective recognition' is usually a source of intellectual satisfaction. When we abandon ourselves to fantasy (for example, in daydreaming) we feel immense pleasure, but on the contrary it causes us great discomfort and shame to confess our fantasies to others.

In this way we can also articulate two stages of the psychoanalytic process: interpretation of symptoms - going through fantasy. When we are confronted with the patient's symptoms, we must first interpret them and penetrate through them to the fundamental fantasy as the kernel of enjoyment which is blocking the further movement of interpretation; then we must accomplish the crucial step of going through the fantasy, of obtaining distance from it, of experiencing how the fantasy-formation just masks, fills out a certain void, lack, empty place in the Other.

But here again another problem arose: how do we account for patients who have, beyond any doubt, gone through their fantasy, who have

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obtained distance from the fantasy-framework of their reality, but whose key symptom still persists? How do we explain this fact? What do we do with a symptom, with this pathological formation which persists not only beyond its interpretation but even beyond fantasy? Lacan tried to answer this challenge with the concept of sinthome, a neologism containing a set of associations (synthetic-artificial man, synthesis between symptom and fantasy, Saint Thomas, the saint . . .).9 Symptom as sinthome is a certain signifying formation penetrated with enjoyment: it is a signifier as a bearer ofjouis-sense, enjoyment-in-sense.

What we must bear in mind here is the radical ontological status of symptom: symptom, conceived as sinthome, is literally our only substance, the only positive support of our being, the only point that gives consistency to the subject. In other words, symptom is the way we - the subjects - 'avoid madness', the way we 'choose something (the symptom-formation) instead of nothing (radical psychotic autism, the destruction of the symbolic universe)' through the binding of our enjoyment to a certain signifYing, symbolic formation which assures a minimum of consistency to our being-in-the-world.

If the symptom in this radical dimension is unbound, it means literally 'the end of the world' - the only alternative to the symptom is

ritual, regardless ofhis suffering, while he desperately
asks them to have mercy on him and put an end to his suffering by simply
killing him - exactly like the child in 'A Country Doctor', who addresses the
narrator-doctor with the desperate request: 'Doctor, let me die'.
At frst sight, Wagner and Kafka are as far apart as they can be: on one
hand, we have the late-Romantic revival of a medieval legend; on the other,
the description of the fate of the individual in contemporary totalitarian
bureaucracy . . . but if we look closely we perceive that the fundamental
problem of Parsifal is eminently a bureaucratic one: the incapacity, the
incompetence of Am fort as in performing his ritual-bureaucratic duty. The
terri£Ying voice of Amfortas's father Titurel, this superego-injunction of
the living dead, addresses his impotent son in the first act with the words:
'Mein Sohn Amfortas, bist du am Amt?', to which we have to give all
bureaucratic weight: Are you at your post? Are you ready to officiate? In
a somewhat perfunctory sociological manner, we could say that Wagner's
Parsjfol is staging the historical fact that the classical Master (Amfortas) is
no longer capable of reigning in the conditions of totalitarian bureaucracy
and that he must be replaced by a new figure of a Leader (Parsifal).
In his film version of Parsjfol, Hans-Jiirgen Syberberg demonstrated
by a series of changes to Wagner's original - that he was well aware of this
fact. First there is his manipulation of the sexual difference: at the crucial
moment of inversion in the second act - after Kundry's kiss - Parsifal
changes his sex: the male actor is replaced by a young, cold female; what
is at stake here is no ideology of hermaphroditism but a shrewd insight
into the 'feminine' nature of totalitarian power, totalitarian Law is an
obscene Law, penetrated by enjoyment, a Law which has lost its formal
neutrality. But what is crucial for us here is another feature ofSyberberg's
version: the fact that he has externalized Amfortas's wound - it is carried
on a pillow beside him, as a nauseous partial object out of which, through

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an aperture resembling vaginal lips, trickles blood. Here we have the
contiguity with Kafka: it is as if the child's wound from 'A Country Doctor'
has externalized itself, becoming a separate object, gaining independent
existence or - to use Lacan's style - ex-sistence. That is why Syberberg
stages the scene where, just before the final denouement, Amfortas
desperately begs his attendants to run their swords through his body and
so relieve him of his unbearable torments, in a way which differs radically
from the customary way:
Already I feel the darkness of death enshroud me,
and must I yet again return to life?
Madmen! Who would force me to live?
Could you but grant me death!
(He tears open hisgannent)
Here I am - here is the open woundl
Here flows my blood, that poisons me.
Draw your weapons! Plunge your swords
in deep - deep, up to the hilt!
The wound is Amfortas's symptom - it embodies his filthy, nauseous enjoy-
ment, it is his thickened, condensed life-substance which does not let him
die. His words 'Here I am - here is the open wound!' are thus to be taken
literally: all his being is in this wound; if we annihilate it, he himself will
lose his positive ontological consistency and cease to exist. This scene is usually
staged in accordance

with Wagner's instructions: Amfortas tears open his
garment and points at the bleeding wound on his body; with Syberberg, who has eternalized the wound, Amfortas points at the nauseous partial object outside himself- that is, he does not point back at himself but there outside, in the sense of ' there outside I am, in that disgusting piece of the real consists all my substance!' How should we read this externality?
The first, most obvious solution is to conceive this wound as a !JImbolic one: the wound is externalized to show that it does not concern the body as such but the symbolic network into which the body is caught. To put

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it simply: the real reason for Amfortas's impotence, and therewith for the decay of his kingdom, is a certain blockage, a certain snag in the network of symbolic relations. 'Something is rotten' in this country where the ruler has trespassed a fundamental prohibition (he allowed himself to be seduced by Kundry); the wound is then just a materialization of a moral-symbolic decay.
But there is another, perhaps more radical reading: in so far as it sticks out from the (symbolic and symbolized) reality of the body, the wound is 'a little piece of real', a disgusting protuberance which cannot be integrated into the totality of ' our own body', a materialization of that which is 'in Amfortas more than Amfortas' and is thereby - according to the classic Lacanian formula - destroying him.ll It is destroying him, but at the same time it is the only thing which gives him consistency. This is the paradox of the psychoanalytic concept of the symptom: symptom is an element clinging on like a kind of parasite and 'spoiling the game', but if we annihilate it things get even worse: we lose all we had - even the rest which was threatened but not yet destroyed by the symptom. Confronted with the symptom we are always in a position of an impossible choice; illustrated by a well-known joke about the chief editor of one of Hearst' s newspapers: in spite of persuasion from Hearst, he did not want to take well-deserved leave. When Hearst asked him why he did not want to go on his holidays, the editor's answer was: 'I am afraid that if! were absent for a couple of weeks, the sales of the newspaper would fall; but I am even more afraid that in spite of my absence, the sales would not fall!' This is the symptom: an element which causes a great deal of trouble, but its absence would mean even greater trouble: total catastrophe.
To take, as a final example, Ridley Scott's film A lien: is not the disgusting parasite which jumps out of the body of poor John Hurt precisely such a symptom, is not its status precisely the same as that ofAmfortas's externalized wound? The cave on the desert planet into which the space travellers enter when the computer registers signs of life in it, and where the
11 Lacan, The Four Fundamental Concepts rfPsycho Allafysis, Chapter 10.

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polyp-like parasite sticks on to Hurt's face, has the status of the pre-symbolic Thing - that is, of the maternal body, of the living substance of enjoyment. The utero-vaginal associations aroused by this cave are almost too intrusive. The parasite adhering to Hurt's face is thus a kind of a 'sprout of enjoyment', a leftover of the maternal Thing which then functions as a symptom - the Real of enjoyment - of the group

marooned
in the wandering spaceship: it threatens them and at the same time constitutes them as a closed group. The fact that this parasitical object incessantly changes its form merely confirms its allamorphicstatus: it is a pure being of semblance. The ' alien', the eighth, supplementary passenger, is an object which, being nothing at all in itself, must none the less be added, annexed as an anamorphic surplus. It is the Real at its purest: a semblance, something which on a strictly symbolic level does not exist at all but at the same time the only thing in the whole film which actually exists, the thing against which the whole reality is utterly defenceless. One has only to remember the spine-chilling scene when the liquid pouring from the polyp-like parasite after the doctor makes an incision with a scalpel dissolves the metal floor of the space ship . . .
From this perspective of sillthome, truth and enjoyment are radically incompatible: the dimension of truth is opened through our misrecognition of the traumatic Thing, embodying the impossible jouis-sanee.
Ideologicaljouissance
With the designation of an inconsistency of the socio-symbolic Other, the positive side of which is obscene enjoyment, have we not consented also to the usual 'postmodernist' anti-Enlightenment resSeTltimellt? The text on the cover of the French edition of Lacan's Ecrits already belies such an understanding: Lacan conceives there his theoretical effort explicitly as a prolongation of the old struggle of Enlightenment. The Lacanian criticism of the autonomous subject and his power of reflection, of reflexive appropriation of his objective condition, is therefore far from any affirmation of some irrational ground escaping the reach of reason. Paraphrasing the

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well-known Marxian formula of capital itself as the limit of capitalism, we should say that according to Lacan the limit of Enlightenment is Enlightenment itself, its usually forgotten obverse already articulated in Descartes and Kant.
The leading motif of the Enlightenment is, of course, some variation of the injunction 'Reason autonomously!': 'Use your own head, free yourself of all prejudices, do not accept anything without questioning its rational foundations, always preserve a critical distance . . . '. But Kant had already, in his famous article 'What is Enlightenment?', added to this an unpleasant, disquieting supplement, introducing a certain fissure into the very heart of the Enlightenment project: 'Reason about whatever you want and as much as you want - but ob9'l' That is to say: as the autonomous subject of theoretical reflection, addressing the enlightened public, you can think freely, you can question aU authority; but as a part of the social 'machine', as a subject in the other meaning of the word, you must obey unconditionally the orders of your superiors. This fissure is proper to the project of Enlightenment as such: we find it already with Descartes, in his Discourse on Method. The obverse of the cogito doubting everything, questioning the very existence of the world, is the Cartesian 'provisional morality', a set of rules established by Descartes to enable him to survive in the everyday existence of his philosophical journey: the very first rule emphasizes the need to accept and obey the customs and laws of the country into which we were born without questioning their authori

of the moral Law consist?
Not in some remnants, leftovers of the empirical 'pathological' contents sticking to the pure form of the Law and smudging it, but in this film itself The moral Law is obscene in so far as it is its form itself which functions as a motivating force driving us to obey its command - that is, in so far as we obey moral Law because it is law and not because of a set of positive reasons: the obscenity of moral Law is the obverse of its formal character. of course, the elementary feature of Kant's ethics is to exclude all empirical, 'pathological' contents - in other words, all objects producing pleasure (or displeasure) - as the locus of our moral activity, but what remains hidden in Kant is the way this renunciation itself produces a certain surplus-enjoyment (the Lacanian plus-de-jouiiJ. Let us take the case of Fascism - the Fascist ideology is based upon a purely formal imperative: Obey, because you must! In other words, renounce enjoyment, sacrifice yourself and do not ask about the meaning ofit - the value of the sacrifice lies in its very meaninglessness; true sacrifice is for its own end; you mllst find positive fulftlment in the sacrifice itself, not in its instrumental value: it is this renunciation, this giving up of enjoyment itself, which produces a certain surplus-enjoyment.
This surplus produced through renunciation is the Lacanian oijet petit a, the embodiment of surplus-enjoyment; here we can also grasp why Lacan coined the notion of surplus-enjoyment on the model of the Marxian notion of surplus-value - with Marx, surplus-value also implies a certain renunciation of'pathological', empirical use-value. And Fascism is obscene in so far as it perceives directly the ideological form as its own end, as an end in itself- remember Mussolilli's famous answer to the question 'How do the Fascists justify their claim to rule Italy? What is their programme?' 'Our programme is very simple: we want to rule Italy!' The ideological
12 Jacques Lacan, terirs, Paris: Seuii, 1966.

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power of Fascism lies precisely in the feature which was perceived by liberal or leftist critics as its greatest weakness: in the utterly void, formal character of its appeal, in the fact that it demands obedience and sacrifice for their own sake. For Fascist ideology, the point is not the instrumental value of the sacrifice, it is the very form of sacrifice itself, 'the spirit of sacrifice', which is the cure against the liberal-decadent disease. It is also dear why Fascism was so terrified by psychoanalysis: psychoanalysis enables us to locate an obscene enjoyment at work in this act of formal sacrifice.
This is the hidden perverse, obscene dimension of Kantian moral formalism finally appearing in Fascism: it is here that Kantian formalism rejoins - or, more precisely, explicates - the logic of the second of Descartes' s maxims of provisional morality:
. . . that of being as firm and resolute in my actions as I could be, and not to follow less faithfully opinions the most dubious, when my mind was once made up regarding them, than if these had been beyond doubt. In this I should be following the example of travellers, who, finding themselves lost in a forest, know that they ought not to wander first to one side and then to the other, nor, still less, to stop in one place, but understand that they should continue to walk as straigh

signifiers through 'Communism', for example,
'class struggle' confers a precise and fixed signification to all other elements: to democracy (so-called 'real democracy' as opposed to 'bourgeois formal democracy' as a legal form of exploitation); to feminism (the exploitation of women as resulting from the class-conditioned division oflabour); to ecologism (the destruction of natural resources as a logical consequence of profit-orientated capitalist production); to the peace movement (the principal danger to peace is adventuristic imperialism), and so on.
What is at stake in the ideological struggle is which of the 'nodal points', pOlizts de capiton, will totalize, include in its series of equivalences, these free-floating elements. Today, for example, the stake of the struggle between neo-conservatism and social democracy is 'freedom': neo-conservatives try to demonstrate how egalirarian democracy, embodied in the welfare state, necessarily leads to new forms of serfdom, to the dependency of the individual on the totalitarian srate, while social democrats stress how individual freedom, to have any meaning at all, must be based upon democratic social life, equality of economic opportunity, and so forth.
In this way, every element of a given ideological field is part of a series of equivalences: its metaphorical surplus, through which it is connected with all other elements, determines retroactively its very identity (in a Communist perspective, to fight for peace means to fight against the capitalist order, and so on). But this enchainment is possible only qn condition that a certain signifier - the Lacanian 'One' - 'quilts' the whole field and, by embodying it, effectuates its identity.
Let us take the Laclau/Mouffe project of radical democracy: here, we have an articulation of particular struggles (for peace, ecology, feminism, human rights, and so on), none of which pretends to be the 'Truth', the last Signified, the 'true Meaning' of all the others; but the title 'radical democracy' itself indicates how the very possibility of their articulation implies the 'nodal', determining role of a certain struggle which, precisely as a particular struggle, outlines the horizon of all the other struggles.

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This determining role belongs, of course, to democracy, to 'democratic invention': according to Laclau and Mouffe, all other struggles (socialist, feminist . . .) could be conceived as the gradual radicalization, extension, application of the democratic project to new domains (of economic relations, of the relations between sexes . . .). The dialectical paradox lies in the fact that the particular struggle playing a: hegemonic role, far from enforcing a violent suppression of the differences, opens the very space for the relative autonomy of the particular struggles: the feminist struggle, for example, is made possible only through reference to democratic-egalitarian political discourse.
The first task of the analysis is therefore to isolate, in a given ideological field, the particular struggle which at the same time determines the horizon of its totality - to put it in Hegelian terms, the species which is its own universal kind. But this is the crucial theoretical problem: how does this determining, totalizing role of a particular struggle differ from the traditionally conceived 'hegemony' by which a certain struggle (workers' struggle in Marxism

) appears as the Truth of all the others, so that
all other struggles are in the last resort only forms of its expression, and
victory in this struggle offers us the key to vicrory in other domains? Or,
as the usual Marxist line of argument runs: only successful socialist
revolution will render possible the abolition of women's repression, the
end of the destructive exploitation of nature, relief from the threat of
nuclear destruction . . . In other words: how do we formulate the deter-
mining role of a particular domain without falling into a trap of essen-
tialism? My thesis is that Saul Kripke's antidescriptivism offers us the
conceptual tools to solve this problem.

Desmptivism versus antidesmptivism

We could call the basic experience upon which Kripke's antidescriptivism
is founded invasion of the bocfy snatchers, after the well-known 1950S science-
fiction film: an invasion of creatures from outer space which assume
human shape - they look exactly like human beings, they have all their

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properties, but in some sense this makes them aU the more uncannily
strange. This problem is the same as anti-Semitism (and for that reason
Invasion of the BOtfy Snatchers can be read as a metaphor for McCarthyite
anti-Communism in the 1950S): Jews are 'like us'; it is difficult to recognize
them, to determine at the level of positive reality that surplus, that evasive
feature, which differentiates them from all other people.

The stake of the dispute between descriptivism and antidescriptivism is
the most elementary one: how do names refer to the objects they denote?
Why does the word 'table' refer to a table? The descriptivist auswer is the
obvious one: because of its meaning; every word is in the first place the
bearer of a certain meaning - that is, it means a cluster of descriptive features
('table' means an object of a certain shape, serving certain purposes) and
subsequently refers to objects in reality in so far as they possess properties
designated by the cluster of descriptions. 'Table' means a table because a
table has properties comprised in the meaning of the word 'table'. Intention
thus has logical priority over extension: extension (a set of objects referred
to by a word) is determined by intention (by universal properties comprised
in its meaning). The antidescriptivist answer, in contrast, is that a word is
connected to an object or a set of objects through an act of'primal baptism',
and this link maintains itself even if the cluster of descriptive features which
initially determined the meaning of the word changes completely.

Let us take a simplified example from Kripke: if we ask the general
public for an identifYing description of'Kurt Godel', the answer would be
'the author of the proof of the incompleteness of arithmetic'; but suppose
that the proof was written by another man, Schmidt, a friend of Godel,
and that Godel murdered him and appropriated to himself the discovery
of the proof mentioned; in this case, the name 'Kurt Godel' would still
refer to the same Godel, although the identifying description would no
longer apply to him. The point is that the name 'Godel' has been linked
to a certain object (person) through a 'primal baptism', and this link holds
even if the original identifying description proves false. I This is the core

1
Saul Kripke, Namifl andNecessiry, Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1980,
pp. 8

- such a condition logically presupposes the existence of at least one other subject who knows a lot more about Smith - to whom the name 'Smith' is connected with a whole cluster of descriptive features (an old fat gentleman giving a course on the history of pornography . . .). In other words, the case offered by antidescriptivism as 'normal' (the transmission of the reference through an external causal chain) is only an' external' description (a description leaving out of consideration the intentional content) of a functioning which is 'parasitic' - that is, logically secondary.

To refute Searle, we have to demonstrate that his primitive tribe, in which language functions exclusively in a descriptive way, is not only empirically but also logically impossible. The Derridean procedure would, of course, be to show how the 'parasitic' use always corrodes, and has from the very start corroded, the purely descriptive functioning: how Searle's myth of a primitive tribe presents just another version of a totally transparent community in which referring is not blurred by any absence, by any lack.

The Lacanian approach would emphasize another feature: there is simply something missing in Searle's description of his tribe. If we are really concerned with language in a strict sense, with language as a social network in which meaning exists only in so far as it is intersubjectively recognized - with language which, by definition, cannot be 'private' - then it must be part of the meaning of each name that it refers to a certain object because this is its name, because others use this name to designate the object in question: every name, in so far as it is part of common language, implies this self-referential, circular moment. 'Others', of course ,

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cannot be reduced to empirical others; they rather point to the Lacanian 'big Other', to the symbolic order itselE

Here we encounter the dogmatic stupidity proper to a signifier as such, the stupidity which assumes the shape of a tautology: a name refers to an object because this object is called that - this impersonal form ('it is called') announces the dimension of the 'big Other' beyond other subjects. The example evoked by Searle as an epitome of parasitism - the example of speakers who know nothing about the object of which they are speaking and whose 'only intentional content might be that they are using the name to refer to what others are using it to refer to'5 - indicates, on the contrary, a necessary constituent of every 'normal' use of names in language as a social bond - and this tautological constituent is the Lacanian master-signifier, the 'signifier without signified'.

The ironic part of it is that this lack is actually inscribed in Searle's description in the form of a prohibition (' . . . there is a strict taboo in this tribe against speaking of the dead'): Searle's mythical tribe is thus a tribe of psychotics which - because of the taboo concerning names of dead persons - forecloses the function of the Name-of-the-Father - that is to say, prevents the transformation of the dead father into the rule of his Name. If, consequently, Searle's descriptivism misses the dimension of the big Other, antidescriptivism - at least in its predominant version - misses the small other, the dimension of the object as Real in the Lacanian sense: the distinction Real/reality. This is why it looks for that x, fo

ory' therefore
corresponds exactly to that of Searle' s myth of the primitive tribe: in both cases its function is to limit, to restrain the radical contingency of naming - to construct an agency guaranteeing its necessity. In the first instance, the reference is guaranteed by the 'intentional content' immanent to the name; in the second, it is guaranteed by the causal chain which brings us to the 'primal baptism' linking the word to the object. If, in this dispute between descriptivism and antidescriptivism, the 'truth' lies, for all that, in antidescriptivism, it is because antidescriptivism's error is of another kind: in its myth, antidescriptivism blinds itself to its own result, to what it 'has produced without knowing it'. The main achievement of anti-descriptivism is to enable us to conceive objet a as the real-impossible correlative of the 'rigid designator' - that is, of the point de capitan as 'pure' signifier.

Rigid designator and objet a

If we maintain that the point de capitan is a 'nodal point', a kind of knot of meanings, this does not imply that it is simply the 'richest' word, the word in which is condensed all the richness of meaning of the field it 'quilts': the point de capitan is rather the word which, asa word, on the level of the signifier itself, unifies a given field, constiUltes its identity: it is, so to speak, the wotd to which 'things' themselves refer to recognize themselves in their unity. Let us take the case of the famous advertisement for

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Marlboro: the picture of the bronzed cowboy, the wide prairie plains, and so on - all this ' connotes', of course, a certain image of America (the land of hard, honest people, oflimitless horizons . . .) but the effect of' quilting' occurs only when a certain inversion takes place; it does not occur until 'real' Americans start to identify themselves (in their ideological self-experience) with the image created by the Marlboro advertisement - until America itselfis experienced as 'Marlboro country'.

It is the same for all so-called 'mass-media symbols' of America - Coca-Cola, for example: the point is not that Coca-Cola 'connotes' a certain ideological experience-vision of America (the freshness of its sharp, cold . taste, and so on); the point is that this vision of America itself achieves its identity by identifying itself with the signifier 'Coke' - 'America, this is Coke!' could be the wording of an imbecile publicity device. The crucial point to grasp is that this device - 'Amenca [the ideological vision of a land in all its diversity], this is Coke [this signifier]!' - could not be inverted as 'Coke [this signifier], this is [this means] AmericaI' The only possible answer to the question 'What is Coke?' is already given in the advertisements: it is the impersonal 'it' ('Coke, this is itl') - 'the real thing', the unattainable X, the object-cause of desire.

Precisely because of this surplus-X, the operation of , quilting' is not circular-symmetrical - we cannot say that we gain nothing from it because Coke first connotes 'the spirit of America', and this 'spirit of America' (the cluster offeatures supposed to express it) is then condensed in Coke as its signifier, its signifYing representative: what we gain from this simple inversion is precisely the surplus-X, the object-cause of desire, that 'unat-tainable something' which is 'in Coke more than Coke

ience of meaning', itself
the horizon of an ideological field of meaning, is supported by some 'pure', meaningless 'signifier without the signified'.

The ideological anamorphosis

We can now see how the Kripkean theory of'rigid designator' - of a certain pure signifier which designates, and at the same time constitutes, the identity of a given object beyond the variable cluster of its descriptive properties - offers a conceptual apparatus enabling us to conceive precisely the status ofLaclau's 'anti-essentialism'. Let us take, for example, notions like 'democracy', 'socialism', 'Marxism': the essentialist illusion consists in the belief that it is possible to determine a definite cluster of features, of positive properties, however minimal, which defines the permanent essence of 'democracy' and similar terms - every phenomenon which pretends to be classified as 'democratic' should fulfil the condition of possessing this cluster offeatures. In contrast to this 'essentialist illusion', Laclau's anti-essentialism compels us to conclude that it is impossible to define any such essence, any cluster of positive properties which would remain the same in 'all possible worlds' - in all counterfactual situations. In the last resort, the only way to define 'democracy' is to say that it contains all political movements and organizations which legitimize, designate themselves as 'democratic'; the only way to define 'Marxism' is to say that this term designates all movements and theories which legitimize themselves through reference to Marx, and so on. In other words, the only possible definition of an object in its identity is that this is the object which is always designated by the same signifier - tied to the same

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signifier. It is the signifier which constitutes the kernel of the object's 'identity'.

Let us return again to 'democracy': is there - on the level of positive, descriptive features - really anything in common between the liberal-individualist notion of democracy and the real-socialist theory, according to which the basic feature of ' real democracy' is the leading role of the Party representing the ttue interests of the people and thus assuring their effective rule?

Here we should not be misled by the obvious but false solution that the real-socialist notion of democracy is simply wrong, degenerated, a kind of perverse travesty of true democracy - in the final analysis, 'democracy' is defined not by the positive content of this notion (its signified) but only by its positional-relational identity - by its opposition, its differential relation to 'non-democratic' - whereas the concrete content can vary in the extreme: to mutual exclusion (for real socialist Marxists, the term 'democratic' designates the very phenomena which, for a traditional liberalist, are the embodiment of anti-democratic totalitarianism).

This then is the fundamental paradox of the point de capiton: the 'rigid designator', which totalizes an ideology by bringing to a halt the metonymic sliding of its signified, is not a point of supreme density of Meaning, a kind of Guarantee which, by being itself excepted from the differential interplay of elements, would serve as a stable and fixed point of reference. On the contrary, it is the element which represents the agency of the signifier within the field of the signified. In itself it is nothing but a 'pure difference': its role

ngular element.
From what we have just said, it is also clear why the other cross point of the two vectots is marked by .s(0): at this point we find the signified, the meaning, which is a function of the big Other - which is produced as a retroactive effect of ' quilting', backwards from the point at which the relation between floating signifiers is fixed through reference to the synchronous symbolic code.
And why is the right, last part of the vector of the signifier S-S' - the part subsequent to the point de capitol! - designated as 'Voice'? To solve this enigma, we must conceive the voice in a strictly Lacanian way: not as a bearer of plenitude and self-presence of meaning (as with Derrida) but as a meaningless object, as an objectal remnant, leftover, of the signifying operation, of the capitonnage: the voice is what is left over after we subtract from the signifier the retroactive operation of , quilting' which produces meaning. The clearest concrete embodiment of this objectal status of the voice is the hypnotic voice: when the same word is repeated to us indefinitely we become disorientated, the word loses the last traces of its meaning, all that is left is its inert presence exerting a kind of somniferous hypnotic power - this is the voice as 'object', as the objectal leftover of the signifying operation.
There is yet another feature of the second form of the graph to be explained: the change at its bottom. Instead of the mythical intention (L\) and the subject ($) produced when this intention traverses the signifying chain, we have at the bottom right the subject which pierces the signifYing chain, and the product of this operation is now marked as 1(0). So, first: why is the subject displaced from left (result) to right (starting point of the vector)? Lacan himself points out that we are dealing here with the 'effect of retroversion' - with the transferential illusion according to which the subject becomes at every stage 'what it always already was': a retroactive effect is experienced as something which was already there from the beginning. Second point: why have we now at the bottom left, as the result of the subject's vector, I(O)? Here we have finally arrived at identjfication: 1(0)

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stands for symbolic identification, for the identification of the subject with some signifYing feature, trait (I), in the big Other, in the symbolic order. This feature is the one which, according to the Lacanian definition of the signifier, 'represents the subject for another signifier'; it assumes concrete, recognizable shape in a name or in a mandate that the subject takes upon himself and/or that is bestowed on him. This symbolic identification is to be distinguished from imaginary identification marked by a new level inserted between the vector of the signifier (S-S') and the symbolic identification: the axis connecting imaginary ego (e) and its imaginary other, i(o) - to achieve self-identity, the subject must identify himself with the imaginary other, he must alienate himself - put his identity outside himself, so to speak, into the image of his double.
The 'effect of retroversion' is based precisely upon this imaginary level - it is supported by the illusion of the self as the autonomous agent which is present from the very beginning as the origin of its acts: this imaginary self-experience is for the subject the way to m

isrecognize his radical
dependence on the big Other, on the symbolic order as his decentred cause. But instead of repeating this thesis of the ego's constitutive alienation in its imaginary Other - the Lacanian theory of the mirror stage which is to be situated precisely on the axis e-i(o)- we should rather focus our attention on the crucial difference between imaginary and symbolic identification.

Image and gaze

The relation between imaginary and symbolic identification - between the ideal ego [Idealich] and the ego-ideal [Ich-Idea? - is - to use the distinction made by Jacques-Alain Miller (in his unpublished Seminar) - that between 'constituted' and 'constitutive' identification: to put it simply, imaginary identification is identification with the image in which we appear likeable to ourselves, with the image representing 'what we would like to be', and symbolic identification, identification with the very place ftom where we are being observed,ftom where we look at ourselves so that we appear to ourselves likeable, worthy oflove.

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Our predominant, spontaneous idea of identification is that ofimitating models, ideals, image-makers: it is noted (usually from the condescending 'mature' perspective) how young people identify with popular heroes, pop singers, film stars, sportsmen . . . This spontaneous notion is doubly misleading. First, the feature, the trait on the basis of which we identifjr with someone, is usually hidden - it is by no means necessarily a glamorous feature.

Neglecting this paradox can lead to serious political miscalculations; let us mention only the 1986 Austrian presidential campaign, with the controversial figure ofWaldheim at its centre. Starting from the assumption that Waldheim was attracting voters because of his great-statesman image, leftists put the emphasis of their campaign on proving to the public that not only is Waldheim a man with a dubious past (probably involved in war crimes) but also a man who is not prepared to confront his past, a man who evades crucial questions concerning it - in short, a man whose basic feature is a refusal to 'work through' the traumatic past. What they overlooked was that it was precisely this feature with which the majority of centrist voters identified. Post-war Austria is a country whose very existence is based on a refusal to 'work through' its traumatic Nazi past - proving that Waldheim was evading confrontation with his past emphasized the exact trait-of-.identification of the majority of voters.

The theoretical lesson to be learned from this is that the trait-of-identification can also be a certain failure, weakness, guilt of the other, so that by pointing out the failure we can unwittingly reinforce the identification. Rightist ideology in particular is very adroit at offering people weakness or guilt as an identifjring trait: we find traces of this even with Hider. In his public appearances, people specifically identified themselves with what were hysterical outbursts of impotent rage - that is, they 'recognized' themselves in this hysterical acting out

But the second, even more serious error is to overlook the fact that imaginary identification is always identification on beha!fqfa certaingoze in the Other. So, apropos of every imitation of a model-image, apropos of every 'playing a role', the question to ask is:.forwhom is the subject enacting

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this role? which gaze is considered when the subject identifies himself with a certain image? This gap between the way I see myself and the point from which I am being observed to appear likeable to myself is crucial for grasping hysteria (and obsessional neurosis as its subspecies) - for so-called hysterical theatre: when we take the hysterical woman in the act of such a theatrical outburst, it is of course clear that she is doing this to offer herself to the Other as the object of its desire, but concrete analysis has to discover who - which subject - embodies for her the Other. Behind an extremely 'feminine' imaginary figure, we can thus generally discover some kind of masculine, paternal identification: she is enacting fragile femininity, but on the symbolic level she is in fact identified with the paternal gaze, to which she wants to appear likeable.

This gap is brought to its extreme with the obsessional neurotic: on the 'constituted', imaginary, phenomenal level he is of course caught in the masochistic logic of his compulsive acts, he is humiliating himself, preventing his success, organizing his failure, and so on; but the crucial question is again how to locate the vicious, superego gaze for which he is humiliating himself, for which this obsessional organizing of failure procures pleasure. This gap can best be articulated with the help of the Hegelian couple 'for-the-other'l'for-itself: the hysterical neurotic is experiencing himself as somebody who is enacting a role for the other, his imaginary identification is his 'being-for-the-other', and the crucial break that psychoanalysis must accomplish is to induce him to realize how he is himself this other for whom he is enacting a role - how his. being-for-the-other is his being-for-himself, because he is himself already symbolically identified with the gaze for which he is playing his role.

To make this difference between imaginary and symbolic identification clear, let us take some non-clinical examples. In his piercing analysis of Chaplin, Eisenstein exposed as a crucial feature of his burlesques a vicious, sadistic, humiliating attitude towards children: in Chaplin's films, children are not treated with the usual sweetness: they are teased, mocked, laughed at for their failures, food is scattered for them as if they were chickens, and so on. The question to ask here, however, is from which point must

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we look at children so that they appear to us as objects of teasing and mocking, not gentle creatures needing protection? The answer, of course, is the gaze ofthe children themselves - only children themselves treat their fellows this way; sadistic distance towards children thus implies the symbolic identification with the gaze of the children themselves.

At the opposite extreme, we find the Dickensian admiration of the 'good common people', the imaginary identification with their poor but happy, close, unspoiled world, free of the cruel struggle for power and money. But (and therein lies the falsity of Dickens) from where is the Dickensian gaze peering at the 'good common people' so that they appear likeable; from where if not from the point of view of the corrupted world of power and money? We perceive the same gap in Brueghel's late idyllic paintings of scenes from peasant life (country festivity, reapers during midday rest, and so on):

Arnold Hauser pointed out that these paintings
are as far removed as possible from any real plebeian ai:titude, from any mingling with the working classes. Their gaze is, on the contrary, the external gaze of the aristocracy upon the peasants' idyll, not the gaze of the peasants themselves upon their life.
The same goes, of course, for the Stalinist elevation of the dignity of the socialist ' ordinary working people': this idealized image of the working class is staged for rhe gaze of the ruling Party bureaucracy - it serves to legitimize their rule. That is why Milos Forman's Czech films were so subversive in mocking small, ordinary people: in showing their undignified ways, the futility of their dreams . . . this gesture was far more dangerous than making fun of the ruling bureaucracy. Forman did not want to destroy the bureaucrat's imaginary identification; he wisely preferred to subvert his symbolic identification by unmasking the spectacle enacted for his gaze.
From. (0) to I{O)
This difference between i(oJ and 1(0) - between ideal ego and ego-ideal - can be further exemplified by the way nicknames function in American and Soviet culture. Let us take two individuals, each of whom represents

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the supreme achievement of these two cultures: Charles 'Lucky' Luciano and IosifVissarionovich Dzhugash viii 'Stalin'. In the first case the nickname tends to replace the first name (we usually speak simply of'Lucky Luciano'), while in the second it regularly replaces the family name ('Iosif Vissarionovich Stalin'). In the first case the nickname alludes to some extraordinary event which has marked the individual (Charles Luciano was 'lucky' to have survived the savage torture of his gangster enemies) - it alludes, that is, to a positive, descriptive feature which fascinates us; it marks something that sticks out on the individual, something that offers itself to our gaze, something seen, not the point from which we observe the individual.
However, in the case ofIosifVissarionovich, it would be entirely erroneous to conclude in a homologous way that 'Stalin' (Russian for '[made] of steel') alludes to some steely, inexorable characteristic of Stalin himself: what is really inexorable and steely are the laws of the historical progress, the iron necessity of the disintegration of capitalism and of the passage to socialism in the name of which Stalin, this empirical individual, is acting - the perspective from which he is observing himself and judging his activity. We could say, then, that 'Stalin' is the ideal point from which 'IosifVissarionovich', this empirical individual, this person of flesh and blood, is observing himself so that he appears likeable.
We find the same split in a late writing of Rousseau, from the time of his psychotic delirium, entitled 'jean-jacques ju,geparRolisu' Oean-Jacques judged by Rousseau). It would be possible to conceive this as a. draft of the Lacanian theory of forename and family name: the first name designates the ideal ego, the point of imaginary identification, while the family name comes from the father - it designates, as the Name-of-the Father, the point of symbolic identification, the agency through which we observe and judge ourselves. The fact that should not be overlooked in this distinction is that ItO) is always already subordinated to I(O): it is the symbolic identification (the point fr

tionary force of a given utterance.) And it is at this exact place of the question arising above the utterance, at the place of , Why are you telling me this?', that we have to locate derire (small d in the graph) in its difference to demand: you demand something of me, but what do you really want, what are you aiming at through this demand? This split between demand and desire is what defines the position of the hysterical subject: according to the classic lacanian formula, the logic of the hysterical demand is 'I'm demanding this of you, but what I'm really demanding of you is to refute my demand because this is not it!'

It is this intuition which is behind the ill-famed male chauvinist wisdom that 'woman is a whore': woman is a whore because we never really know what she means - for example, she says 'No!' to our advances, but we can never be sure that this 'No!' does not really mean a double 'Yes!' - an appeal to an even more aggressive approach; in this case, her real desire is the very opposite of her demand. In other words, 'woman is a whore' is a vulgar version of the unanswerable Freudian question 'Was will das Weibl [What does the woman want?'].

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'CHE vuo/r

The same intuition is probably at wotk behind another common wisdom, which tells us that politics is also a whore: it is not simply that the domain of politics is corrupted, treacherous, and so on; the point is rather that every political demand is always caught in a dialectics in which it aims at something other than its literal meaning: for example, it can function as a provocation intending to be refused (in which case the best way to frustrate it is to comply with it, to consent to it without reservation). As is well known, this was Lacan's reproach to the students' revolt of 1968: that is was basically a hysterical rebellion asking for a new Master.

This ' Che vuoi?' is perhaps best illustrated by the starting point of Hitchcock's film North by Northwest. To lead the Russian agents off the right track, the CIA invents a non-existent agent named George Kaplan. Rooms are reserved for him in hotels, phone calls are made in his name, plane tickets purchased, and so on -all this to convince the Russian agents that Kaplan really exists, when in reality it is just a void, a name without a bearer. At the beginning of the film the hero, an ordinary American named Roger O. Thornhill, finds himself in the lounge of a hotel under observation by the Russians because the mysterious Kaplan is supposed to be staying there. A hotel clerk enters the lounge saying: 'phone call for Mr Kaplan. Is Mr Kaplan here?' Exactly at that same moment, by pure coincidence, Thornhill makes a sign to this clerk, wanting to send a telegram to his mother. The Russians who are overseeing the scene mistake him for Kaplan. When he wants to leave the hotel they kidnap him, take him to a lonely villa, and ask him to tell them all about his espionage work. of course, Thornhill knows nothing about it, but his professions of innocence pass for a double game.

Where lies the - one might call it - psychologically convincing nature of this scene, based nevertheless on an almost unbelievable coincidence? Thornhill's situation corresponds to a fundamental situation of a human being as a being-of-language (parletre, to use Lacan's condensed writing). The subject is always fastened, pinned, to a signifier which represents him for the other,

and through this pinning he is loaded with a symbolic
mandate, he is given a place in the intersubjective network of symbolic

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relations. The point is that this mandate is ultimately always arbitrary:
since its nature is performative, it cannot be accounted for by reference
to the 'real' properties and capacities of the subject. So, loaded with this
mandate, the subject is automatically confronted with a certain' Che vuoi?',
with a question of the Other. The Other is addressing him as ifhe himself
possesses the answer to the question of why he has this mandate, but the
question is, of course, unanswerable. The subject does not know why he
is occupying this place in the symbolic network. His own answer to this
'che vuoi! of the Other can only be the hysterical question: 'Why am I
what I'm supposed to be, why have I this mandate? Why am I [a teacher,
a master, a king . . . or George KaplanJ?' Briefly: 'Wly! am I what you [the big
Other] are sqyins that I am?'
And the final moment of the psychoanalytic process is, for the
analysand, precisely when he gets rid of this question - that is, when he
accepts his being as nOllj'ustified by the big Other. This is why psychoanalysis
began with the interpretation of hysterical symptoms, why its 'native soil'
was the experience of female hysteria: in the last resort, what is hysteria
if not precisely the effect and testimony of a failed interpellation; what is
the hysterical question if not an articulation of the incapacity of the subject
to fulfil the symbolic identification, to assume fully and without restraint
the symbolic mandate? Lacan formulates the hysterical question as a
certain 'Why am I what you're telling me that I am?' - that is, which is
that surplus-object in me that caused the Other to interpellate me, to
'hail' me as . . . [king, master, wife . . . J?'10 The hysterical question opens
the gap of what is 'in the subject more than the subject', of the object in
subject which resists interpellation - subordination of the subject, its
inclusion in the symbolic network.
Perhaps the strongest artistic depiction of this moment ofhystericiza-
tion is Rossetti's famous painting 'Ecce Ancilla Domini', showing Mary at
the very moment of interpellation - when the Archangel Gabriel reveals
to her her mission: to conceive immaculately and to give birth to the son
10 Jacques Lacan, Le Semillaire 1Il Les p!),choses, Paris: Seuil, 1981, p. 315.

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of God. How does Mary react to this astonishing message, to this original
'Hail Mary'? The painting shows her frightened, with a bad conscience,
withdrawing from the archangel into a comer, as if asking herself Why
was I selected for this stupid mission? Why me? What does this repulsive
ghost really want of me?' The exhausted, pale face and the dark eyeteeth
are telltale enough: we have before us a woman with a turbulent sex life,
a licentious sinner - in short, an Eve-like figure; and the painting depicts
'Eve interpellated into Mary', her hysterical reaction to it.
Martin Scorsese's film The Last Temptation 0/ Christ goes a step further
in this direction: its theme is simply the /yJstendzation ojjesus christ
himself, it shows us an ordinary, carnal, passionate man discovering
gradually, with fascination and horror, that he is the son of God, bearer
of the dreadful but magnificent mission to redeem human

ity through his
sacrifice. The problem is that he cannot come to terms with this inter-
pellation: the meaning of his 'temptations' lies precisely in the hysterical
resistance to his mandate, in his doubts about it, in his attempts to evade
it even when he is already nailed to the cross."

The Jew and Antigone

We come across this 'che vuoi?' everywhere in the political domain,
including the 1988 American election struggle in which, after Jesse Jackson's
first successes, the press started to ask 'What does Jackson really want?'

11 The other achievement of the film is the final rehabilitation ofJudas as the real
tragic hero of this story: he was the one whose love for Christ was the greatest, and it was
for this reason that Christ considered him strong enough to fulfil the horrible mission of
betraying him, thus assuring the accomplishment of Christ's destiny (the Crucifixion). The
tragedy of Judas was that in the name of his dedication to the Cause, he was prepared to risk
not only his life but even his 'second life', his posthumous good name: he knows very well
that he will enter history as the one who betrayed our Saviour, and he is prepared to endure
even that for the fulfilment of God's mission. Jesus used Judas as a means to attain his goal,
knowing very well that his own suffering would be transformed into a model imitated by
millions (imitatio Christl), while Judas's sacrifice is a pure loss without any narcissistic benefit.
Perhaps he is a little like the faithful victims of the Stalinist monster trials who confessed
their guilt, proclaimed themselves misetable scum, knowing that by so doing they were
accomplishing the last and highest service to the Cause of the Revolution.

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Overtones of racism were easy to detect in this question, because it was
never raised about other candidates. The conclusion that we are here deal-
ing with racism is further confirmed by the fact that this ' Che vuoi?' erupts
most violently in the purest, so to say distilled, form of racism, in anti-
Semitism: in the anti-Semitic perspective, the Jew is precisely a person
about whom it is never clear 'what he really wants' - that is, his actions
are always suspected of being guided by some hidden motives (the Jewish
conspiracy, world domination and the moral corruption of Gentiles, and
so on). The case of anti-Semitism also illustrates perfectly why Lacan put,
at the end of the curve designating the question ' Che vuoi?' the formula
of fantasy ($ 00): fantasy is an allfwerto this ' che vuoi?'; it is an attempt to
fill out the gap of the question with an answer. In the case of anti-Semitism,
the answer to 'What does the Jew want?' is a fantasy of'Jewish conspiracy':
a mysterious power of Jews to manipulate events, to pull the strings
behind the scenes. The crucial point that must be made here on a theo-
retical level is that fantasy functions as a construction, as an imaginary
scenario filling out the void, the opening of the desire of the Other. by
giving us a definite answer to the question 'What does the Other want?',
it enables us to evade the unbearable deadlock in which the Other wants
something from us, but we are at the same time incapable of translating
this desire of the Other into a positive interpellation, into a mandate
with which to identify.

Now we can also understand why it has been the Jews who have been
chosen as the object of racism par

own lack by offering himself to the other as the object
filling out the lack in the Other - love's deception is that this overlapping
of two lacks annuls lack as such in a mutual completion.
Christianity is therefore to be conceived as an attempt to 'gentri£Y' the
Jewish ' Che VUOl?' through the act oflove and sacrifice. The greatest possible
sacrifice, the Crucifixion, the death of the son of God, is precisely the final
proof that God-Father loves us with an all-embracing, infinite love, thereby
delivering us from the anxiety of'che VUOl?'. The Passion of Christ, this
fascinating image which cancels all other images, this fantasy-scenario
which condenses all the libidinal economy of the Christian religion,
acquires its meaning only against the background of the unbearable
enigma of the desire of the Other (God).
We are, of course, far from implying that Christianity entails a kind of
return to the pagan relationship of man to god: that this is not so is already
attested by the fact that, contrary to superficial appearance, Christianity
follows the Jewish religion in occluding the dimension of the Holy. What
we do find in Christianity is something of quite another order: the idea
of the saint, which is the exact opposite of the priest in service of the Holy.
The priest is a 'functionary of the Holy'; there is no Holy without its offi-
cials, without the bureaucratic machinery supporting it, organizing its
ritual, from the Aztecs' official of human sacrifice to the modern sacred
state or army rituals. The saint, on the contrary, occupies the place of ol?jet
petit a, of pure object, of somebody undergoing radical subjective destitu-
tion. He enacts no ritual, he conjures nothing, he just persists in his inert
presence.
We can now understand why Lacan saw in Antigone a forerunner of
Christ's sacrifice: in her persistence, Antigone is a saint, definitely not
priestess. This is why we must oppose all attempts to domesticate her, to
tame her by concealing the frightening strangeness, 'inhumanity', a-
pathetic character of her figure, making of her a gentle protectress offamily

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and household who evokes our compassion and offers herself as a point
of identification. In Sophocles' Antigone, the figure with which we can
identifY is her sister Ismene - kind, considerate, sensitive, prepared to give
way and compromise, pathetic, 'human', in contrast to Antigone, who
goes to the limit, who ' doesn't give way on her desire' (Lacan) and becomes,
in this persistence in the 'death drive', in the being-to wards-death, fright-
eningly ruthless, exempted from the circle of everyday feelings and consid-
erations, passions and fears. In other words, it is Antigone herself who
necessarily evokes in us, pathetic everyday compassionate creatures, the
question 'What does she really want?', the question which precludes any
identification with her.
In European literature, the couple Antigone-Ismene repeats itself in
de Sade's work, in the shape of the couple Juliette-Justine: here, Justine
is likewise a pathetic victim, as opposed to Juliette, this a-pathetic rake
who also 'doesn't give way on her desire'. Finally, why should we not
locate a third version of the couple Antigone-Ismene in Margaretha von
Trotta's film The Times ifPlumb, in the couple of the RAF (Red Army
Fraction)-terrorist (based on the model of Gudrun Ensslin) and her
pathetic-compassionate sister who 'tries

concerned in psychoanalysis; this cause appears precisely where 'normal' causality fails, breaks down. For example, when we make a slip of the tongue, when we say something other than what we intended to say - that is, when the causal chain regulating our 'normal' speech activity breaks down - at this point that question of the cause is imposed upon us: 'Why did it happen?')

The way fantasy functions can be explained through reference to Kant's Critique of Pure Reason: the role offantasy in the economy of desire is homologous to that of transcendental schematism in the process of knowledge.[12]

In Kant, transcendental schematism i? a mediator, an intermediary agency between empirical content (contingent, inner-worldly, empirical objects of experience) and the network of transcendental categories: it is the name of the mechanism through which empirical objects are included in the network of transcendental categories which determines the way we perceive and conceive them (as substances with properties, submitted to causal links, and so on). A homologous mechanism is at work with fantasy: how does an empirical, positively given object become an object of desire; how does it begin to contain some X, some unknown quality, something which is 'in it more than it' and makes it worthy of our desire? By entering the frameworkoffantasy, by being included in a fantasy-scene which gives consistency to the subject's desire.

Let us take Hitchcock's Rear Window: the window through which] ames Stewart, disabled and confined to a wheelchair, gazes continually is clearly a fantasy-window - his desire is fascinated by what he can see through the window. And the problem of the unfortunate Grace Kelly is that by proposing to him she acts as an obstacle, a stain disturbing his view through the window, instead of fascinating him with her beauty. How does she succeed, finally, in becoming worthy of his desire? By literally entering the frame of his fantasy; by crossing the courtyard and appearing 'on the other side' where he can see her through the window. When Stewart sees her in the murderer's apartment his gaze is immediately fascinated,

[12] Bernard Baas, 'Les desir pur', Onzicar? 43, 1987.

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greedy, desirous of her: she has found her place in his fantasy-space. This would be Lacan's 'male chauvinist' lesson: man can relate to woman only in so far as she enters the frame of his fantasy.

At a certain naive level, this is not unknown to the psychoanalytic doxa which claims that every man seeks, in a woman he chooses as his sexual partner, his mother's substitute: a man falls in love with a woman when some feature of her reminds him of his mother. The only thing Lacan adds to this traditional view is to emphasize its usually overlooked negative dimension: in fantasy, mother is reduced to a limited set of (symbolic) features; as soon as an object too close to the Mother-Thing - an object which is not linked with the maternal Thing only through certain reduced features but is immediately attached to it - appears in the fantasy-frame, the desire is suffocated in incestuous claustrophobia. Here we again encounter the paradoxical intermediate role offantasy: it is a construction enabling us to seek maternal substitutes, but at the same time a screen shielding us from getting too close to the maternal Thing - keeping us at a distance from it. This is wh

nto two levels, which can be designated
as the level of meaning and the level of enjoyment. The problem of the first (lower) level is how the intersection of the signifying chain and of a mythical intention (A) produces the effect of meaning, with all its internal articulation: the retroactive character of meaning in so far as it is the function of the big Other - in so far, that is, as it is conditioned by the place of the Other, the signifier's battery (s (0)); the imaginary (i(o)) and the symbolic (1(0)) - identification of the subject based on this retroactive production of meaning, and so on. The problem of the second (upper) level is what happens when this very field of the signifier's order, of the big Other, is perforated, penetrated by a pre-symbolic (real) stream of enjoyment - what happens when the pre-symbolic 'substance', the body as materialized, incarnated enjoyment, becomes enmeshed in the signifier's network.
Its general result is clear: by being filtered through the sieve of the signifier, the body is submitted to castration, enjoyment is evacuated from it, the body survives as dismembered, mortified. In other words, the order of the signifier (the big Other) and that of enjoyment (the Thing as its embodiment) are radically heterogeneous, inconsistent; any accordance

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between them is structurally impossible. This is why we find on the left-hand side of the upper level of the graph - at the first point ofintersection between enjoyment and signifier, S(0) - the signifier of the lack in the Other, of the inconsistency of the Other: as soon as the field of the signifier is penetrated by enjoyment it becomes inconsistent, porous, perforated - the enjoyment is what cannot be symbolized, its presence in the field of the signifier can be detected only through the holes and inconsistencies of this field, so the only possible signifier of enjoyment is the signifier of the lack in the Other, the signifier of its inconsistency.
Today, it is a commonplace that the Lacanian subject is divided, crossed-out, identical to a lack in a signifying chain. However, the most radical dimension ofLacanian theory lies not in recognizing this fact but in realizing that the big Other, the symbolic order itself, is also bam!, crossed-out, by a fundamental impossibility, structured around an impossible/traumatic kernel, around a central lack. Without this lack in the Other, the Other would be a closed structure and the only possibility open to the subject would be his radical alienation in the Other. So it is precisely this lack in the Other which enables the subject to achieve a kind of ' de-alienation' caned by Lacan separation: not in the sense that the subject experiences that now he is separated for ever from the object by the barrier of language, but that the ol?ject is separated .from the Other itself, that the Other itself 'hasn't got it', hasn't got the final answer - that is to say, is in itself blocked, desiring; that there is also a desire of the Other. This lack in the Other gives the subject - so to speak - a breathing space, it enables him to avoid the total alienation in the signifier not by filling out his lack but by allowing him to identify himself, his own lack, with the lack in the Other.
The three levels of the descending vector on the left side of the graph can thus be conceived in view of the logic that regulates their succession.

y remainder, there is always a leftover which opens the space for desire and makes the Other (the symbolic order) inconsistent, with fantasy as an attempt to overcome, to conceal this inconsistency, this gap in the Other. And now we can finally return to the problematics of ideology: the crucial weakness of hitherto '(post-)structuralist' essays in the theory of ideology descending from the Althusserian theory of interpellation was to limit themselves to the lower level, to the lower square ofLacan's graph of desire - to aim at grasping the efficiency of an ideology exclusively through the mechanisms of imaginary and symbolic identification. The dimension 'beyond interpellation' which was thus left out has nothing to do with some kind of irreducible dispersion and plurality of the signifYing process - with the fact that the metonymic sliding always subverts every fixation of meaning, every 'quilting' of the floating signifiers (as it would appear in a 'post-structuralist' perspective). 'Beyond interpellation' is the square of desire, fantasy, lack in the Other and drive pulsating around some unbearable surplus-enjoyment.

What does this mean for the theory of ideology? At first sight it could seem that what is pertinent in an analysis of ideology is only the way it functions as a discourse, the way the series offloating signifiers is totalized, transformed into a unified field through the intervention of certain 'nodal points'. Briefly: the way the discursive mechanisms constitute the

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field of ideological meaning; in this perspective the enjoyment-in-signifier would be simply pre-ideological, irrelevant for ideology as a social bond. But the case of so-called 'totalitarianism' demonstrates what applies to every ideology, to ideology as such: the last support of the ideological effect (of the way an ideological network of signifiers 'holds' us) is the nonsensical, pre-ideological kernel of enjoyment. In ideology 'all is not ideology (that is, ideological meaning)', but it is this very surplus which is the last support of ideology. That is why we could say that there are also two complementary procedures of the 'criticism ofideology':

? one is discursive, the 'symptomal reading' of the ideological text bringing about the 'deconstruction' of the spontaneous experience of its meaning - that is, demonstrating how a given ideological field is a result of a montage of heterogeneous 'floating signifiers', of their totalization through the intervention of certain 'nodal points';

? the other aims at extracting the kernel of e,yo/ment, at articulating the way in which - beyond the field of meaning but at the same time internal to it - an ideology implies, manipulates, produces a pre-ideological enjoyment structured in fantasy.

To exemplifY this necessity of supplementing the analysis of discourse with the logic of enjoyment we have only to look again at the special case of ideology, which is perhaps the purest incarnation of ideology as such: anti-Semitism. To put it bluntly: 'Society doesn't exist', and the Jew is its symptom.

On the level of discourse analysis, it is not difficult to articulate the network of symbolic overdetermination invested in the figure of the Jew. First, there is displacement: the basic trick of anti-Semitism is to displace social antagonism into antagonism between the sound social texture, social body, and t

ng corruption into the sound social
fabric. In short, 'Jew' is a fetish which simultaneously denies and embodies
the structural impossibility of ' Society': it is as if in the figure of the Jew
this impossibility had acquired a positive, palpable existence - and that
is why it marks the eruption of enjoyment in the social field.
The notion of social fantasy is therefore a necessary counterpart to the
concept of antagonism: fantasy is precisely the way the antagonistic fissure
is masked. In other words, flntasy is a means for an ideology to take its own
failure into account in advance. The thesis ofLaclau and Mouffe that 'Society
doesn't exist', that the Social is always an inconsistent field structured
around a constitutive impossibility, traversed by a central 'antagonism' -
this thesis implies that every process of identification conferring on us a
fixed socio-symbolic identity is ultimately doomed to faiL The function
of ideological fantasy is to mask this inconsistency, the fact that 'Society
doesn't exist', and thus to compensate us for the failed identification.
The 'Jew' is the means, for Fascism, of taking into account, of repre-
senting its own impossibility: in its positive presence, it is only the embod-
iment of the ultimate impossibility of the totalitarian project - of its
immanent limit. This is why it is insufficient to designate the totalitarian
project as impossible, utopian, wanting to establish a totally transparent
and homogeneous society - the problem is that in a way, totalitarian
ideology knows it, recognizes it in advance: in the figure of the 'Jew' it
includes this knowledge in its edifice. The whole Fascist ideology is

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structured as a struggle against the element which holds the place of the
immanent impossibility of the very Fascist project: the 'Jew' is nothing
but a fetishistic embodiment of a certain fundamental blockage.
The ' criticism of ideology' must therefore invert the linking of causality
as perceived by the totalitarian gaze: far from being the positive cause of
social antagonism, the 'Jew' is just the embodiment of a certain blockage
- of the impossibility which prevents the society from achieving its full
identity as a dosed, homogeneous totality. Far from being the positive
cause of social negativity, the Jew' is a point at which social negativi!JI as such
assumes positive existence. In this way we can articulate another formula of
the basic procedure of the 'criticism of ideology', supplementing the one
given above: to detect, in a given ideological edifice, the element which
represents within it its own impossibility. Society is not prevented from
achieving its full identity because of Jews: it is prevented by its own antag-
onistic nature, by its own immanent blockage, and it 'projects' this internal
negativity into the figure of the 'Jew'. In other words, what is excluded
from the Symbolic (from the frame of the corporatist socio-symbolic order)
returns in the Real as a paranoid construction of the 'Jew'.ll
We can also see now how 'going through' the social fantasy is likewise
correlative to identification with a symptom. Jews are dearly a social symp-
tom: the point at which the immanent social antagonism assumes a posi-
tive form, erupts on to the social surface, the point at which it becomes
obvious that society 'doesn't work', that the social mechanism 'creaks'. If
we look at it through the frame of (co

definite consequences for the
determination of the final moment of the psychoanalytic cure:
? In the first period, in which the emphasis is on the word as a medium
of the intersubjective recognition of desire, the symptoms are
conceived as white spots, non-symbolized imaginary elements of
the history of the subject, and the process of analysis is that of their
symbolization - of their integration into the symbolic universe of
the subject: the analysis gives meaning, retroactively, to what was
in the beginning a meaningless trace. So the final moment of the
analysis is reached when the subject is able to narrate to the Other
his own history in its continuity; when his desire is integrated,
recognized in 'full speech [parcle pleine]'.
? In the second period, in which the symbolic order is conceived as
having a mortifYing effect on the subject, as imposing on him a
traumatic loss - and the name of this loss, of this lack, is of course
symbolic castration - the final moment of analysis is reached when
the subject is ready to accept this fundamental loss, to consent to
symbolic castration as a price to be paid for access to his desire.

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? In the third period we have the big Other, the symbolic order, with
a traumatic element at its very heart; and in Lacanian theory the
fantasy is conceived as a construction allowing the subject to come
to terms with this traumatic kerneL At this level, the final moment
of the analysis is defined as 'going through the fantasy [la traversee
du fontasme],: not its symbolic interpretation but the experience of
the fact that the fantasy-object, by its fascinating presence, is merely
filling out a lack, a void in the Other. There is nothing 'behind' the
fantasy; the fantasy is a construction whose function is to hide this
void, this 'nothing' - that is, the lack in the Other.
The crucial element of this third period of Lac an's teaching is therefore
the shift of emphasis from the symbolic to the ReaL To exemplify it, let
us take the notion of the 'knowledge in the Real': the idea that nature
knows its own laws and behaves accordingly. We all know the classical,
archetypal cartoon scene: a cat approaches the edge of the precipice but
she does not stop, she proceeds calmly, and although she is already hanging
in the air, without ground under her feet, she does not fall - when does
she fall? The moment she looks down and becomes aware of the fact that
she is hanging in the air. The point of this nonsense accident is that when
the cat is walking slowly in the air, it is as if the Real has for a moment
forgotten its knowledge: when the cat finally looks down, she remembers
that she must follow the laws of nature and falls. This is basically the
same logic as in the already mentioned dream, reported in Freud's Inter-
pretation ojDreams, of a father who does not know that he is dead: the
point is again that because he does not know that he is dead, he continues
to live - he must be reminded of his death or, to give this situation a
comical twist, he is still living because he has forgotten to die. That is how
the phrase memento mori should be read: don't forget to die!
This brings us back to the distinction between the two deaths: because
oflack of knowledge, the father in Freud's dream is still living, although
he is already dead. In a way, everybody must die twice. That is the Hegelian
theory of repetition i

led
'historical materialism' is to win all the time. It can easily be a match
for anyone ifit enlists the service of theology, which today, as we know,
is wizened and has to keep out of sight.2
What strikes the eye in this fragment is the contradiction between the
allegory forming the first part of the thesis and its interpretation in the
second part. In the interpretation, it is historical materialism which' enlists
the services of theology'; whereas in the allegory itself theology ('a little
hunchback') guides the puppet - 'historical materialism' - by means of
strings from within. This contradiction is of course the very contradiction
between allegory and its meaning, ultimately between signifier and the
signified, which pretends to 'enlist the services' of the signifier as its
instrument but finds itself quickly entangled in its network The two
different levels thus traverse one another: the formal structure of
Benjamin's allegory functions in exactly the same way as its 'content',
theology in its relationship to historical materialism, which pretends
simply to enlist its services but becomes more and more entangled in its
strings because - if we may permit ourselves this vorlust, this forepleasure
- 'theology' designates here the agency of the signifier.
But let us proceed step by step: how should we conceive the theological
dimension referred to by Benjamin? 'Theology' announces here a unique
experience, alluded to in the following fragment published after
Benjamin's death: 'In Eingedenken, we make an experience which forbids
us to conceive history in a fundamentally atheological way.' We cannot
translate this Eil1gedenken simply by 'remembrance' or 'reminiscence'; the
more literal translation, 'to transpose oneselfin thoughts/into something',
is also inadequate.
Although it is really a kind of ' appropriation of the past' which is at
stake here, we cannot conceive Eingedenken in an adequate way as long as
we stay within the field of hermeneutics - Benjamin's aim is quite the
2
Walter Benjamin, IllumilZations, New York: Schocken, 1969, p. 253.

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opposite of the fundamental guidance of hermeneutical understanding
('to locate the interpreted text into the totality of its epoch'). What Benjamin
has in mind is, on the contrary, the isolation of a piece of the past from
the continuity of history (' . . . blasting a specific life out of the era or a
specific work out of the lifework' - Thesis XVII): an interpretative procedure
whose opposition to hermeneutics recalls immediately the Freudian
opposition between interpretation en detail and interpretation en masse.
'What we must take as the object of our attention is not the dream as a
whole but the separate portions of its content'.J
This refusal of the hermeneutical approach has, to be sure, nothing
whatsoever to do with a simple 'regression' to pre-hermeneutical naivete:
the point is not for us to 'accustom ourselves to the past' by abstracting
our actual historical position, the place from which we are speaking.
Eingedenken certainly is an appropriation of the past which is 'interested',
biased towards the oppressed class: 'To articulate the past historically does
not mean to recognize it "the way it really was"' (Thesis VI) .
. . 'Not man
or men but the struggling, oppressed class itselfis the depository of his tor
ical knowledge' (Thesis XIII).
We would none the less falsify the mean

s that configuration a shock, by which it crystallizes
into a monad. A historical materialist approaches a historical subject
only where he encounters it as a monad. In this structure he recognizes
the sign of a Messianic cessation of happening, or, put differently, a
revolutionary chance in the fight for the oppressed past. (Thesis XVII)
Here we have the first surprise: what specifies historical materialism - in
contrast to the Marxist doxa according to which we must grasp events in
the totality of their interconnection and in their dialectical movement -
is its capacity to arrest, to immobilize historical movement and to isolate the
detail from its historical totality.
It is this very crystallization, this 'congelation' of the movement in a
monad, which announces the moment of the appropriation of the past:
the monad is an actual moment to which is attached directly - bypassing
the continuous line of evolution - the past: the contemporary revolurionary
situation which conceives itself as a repetition of past failed situations, as
their retroactive 'redemption' through the success of its own exploit. The past
itselfis here 'filled out with the present', the moment of the revolutionary
chance decides not only the lot of the actual revolution but also the lot of
all past failed revolutionary attempts:
Historical materialism wishes to retain the image of the past which
unexpectedly appears to man singled out by history at a moment of
danger. The danger affects both the content of the tradition and its
receivers. (Thesis VI)

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I S6
THE SUBLIM E OBJ ECT OF IDEOLOGY
The risk of defeat of the actual revolution endangers the past itself
because the actual revolutionary conjunction functions as a condensation
of past missed revolutionary chances repeating themselves in the actual
revolution:
History is the subject of a structure whose site is not homogeneous,
empty time, but time filled by the presence of the now [JelZlZeiq. Thus,
to Robespierre ancient Rome was a past charged with the time of the
now which he blasted out of the continuum of history. The French
Revolution viewed itself as Rome reincarnate. It evoked ancient Rome
the way fashion evokes costumes of the past. (Thesis XIV)
For those acquainted with the Freudian proposition that 'the unconscious
is located outside time', all is actually said here: this 'filled-out time', this
'tiger's leap into the past' with which the revolutionary present is charged,
announces the compulsion to repeat The arrest of historical movement, the
suspension of the temporal continuity mentioned by Benjamin, correspond
precisely to the 'short-circuit' between present and past speech which
characterizes the transferential situation:
Why does the analysis become transformed the moment the transfer-
ential situation is analysed through evoking the old situation, when
the subject found himself with an entirely different object, one that
cannot be assimilated to the present object? Because present speech,
like the old speech, is placed within a parenthesis of time, within a
form of time, if! can put it that way. The modulation of time being
identical, the speech of the analyst [in Benjamin: of the historical mate-
rialist] happens to have the same value as the old speech.4
In the monad, 'time stops' in so far as the actual constellation is directly
charged with the past constellation - in other words, in so far as we
4
Jacques Lacan, The

proximity only confirms
that Benjamin has touched the real nerve of the Stalinist symbolic edifice - he was the only one to question radically the very idea of 'progress' implied by the accountancy of the big Other of history and - precursor, in this respect, of the famous Lacanian formula that development 'is nothing but a hypothesis of domination'7 - to demonstrate the uninterrupted connection between progress and domination: 'The concept of the historical progress of mankind cannot be sundered from the concept of its progression through a homogeneous, empty time' Thesis XIII) - that is, from the temporality of the ruling class.
The Stalinist perspective is that of a victor whose final triumph is guaranteed in advance by the ' objective necessity of history'; which is why, in spite of the accent on ruptures, leaps, revolutions, his view on past history is evolutional)' throughout. History is conceived as the continuous process of replacing old masters with new: each victor played a 'progressive role' in his time, then lost his purpose because of unavoidable development: yesterday, it was the capitalist who acted in accordance with the necessity of progress; today, it's our turn . . . In Stalinist accountancy, 'objective guilt' (or contribution) is measqred by reference to the laws of historical development - of continuous evolution towards the Supreme Good (Communism). With Benjamin, in contrast, the 'perspective of the Last Judgement' is the perspective of those who have paid the price for a series of great historical triumphs; the perspective of those who had to fail, to miss their aim, so that the series of great historical deeds could be accomplished; the perspective of hopes deceived, of all that have left in the text of history nothing but scattered, anonymous, meaningless traces on the
7 Jacques Lacan, Ie Semlilaire XX Encore, Paris: Seuii, 1975, p. 52.

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margin of deeds whose 'historical greatness ' was attested to by the 'objective' gaze of official historiography.
This is why, for Benjamin, revolution is not part of continuous historical evolution but, on the contrary, a moment of'stasis' when the continuity is broken, when the texture of previous history, that of the winners, is annihilated, and when, retroactively, through the success of the revolution, each abortive act, each slip, each past failed attempt which functioned in the reigning Text as an empty and meaningless trace, will be 'redeemed', will receive its signification. In this sense, revolution is strictly a creationist act, a radical intrusion of the 'dea?h drive': erasure of the reigning Text, creation anihilo of a new Text by means of which the stifled past 'will have been'.
To refer to the Lacanian reading of Antigone: if the Stalinist perspective is that of Creon, the perspective of the Supreme Good assuming the shape of the Common Good of the State, the perspective of Benjamin is that of Antigone - for Benjamin, revolution is an affair of life and death; more precisely: of the second, symbolic death. The alternative opened by the revolution is that between redemption, which will retroactively confer meaning on the 'scum of history' (to use this Stalinist expression) - on what was excluded from the continuity of Progress - and the apocafypse (its defeat), where even the dead will again be lost and will suffer a second death: 'even the dead will not be sa

fe from the enemy ifhe wins' (Thesis VI).
We can thus conceive the opposition between Stalinism and Benjamin as that between evolutionalJ' idealism and creationist materialism. In his Seminar o? The Ethic q{Psychoallafysis, Lacan pointed out how the ideology of evolutionism always implies a belief in a Supreme Good, in a final Goal of evolution which guides its course from the very beginning. In other words, it always implies a hidden, disavowed teleology, whereas materialism is always creationist - it always includes a retroactive movement: the final Goal is not inscribed in the beginning; things receive their meaning afterwards; the sudden creation of an Order confers backward signification on to the preceding Chaos.
At first sight, Benjamin's position is radically anti-Hegelian: is not dialectics the most refined and perfidious version of evolutionism, in

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which the very ruptures are included in the continuity ofprogress, in its unavoidable logic? This was probably how Benjamin himself conceived his own position: he designated the point of rupture which cuts into historical continuity as the point of'suspended dialectics', as the intrusion of a pure repetition putting in parentheses the progressive movement of Atif/zebung. But it is at this exact juncture that we must stress Hegel's radical anti-evolutionism: the absolute negativity which 'sets in motion' dialectical movement is nothing but the intervention of the 'death drive' as radically non-historical, as the 'zero degree' of history - historical movement includes in its very heart the non-historical dimension of ' absolute negativity'. In other words, the suspension of movement is a key moment of the dialectical process: so-called 'dialectical development' consists in the incessant repetition of a beginning IX nihilo, in the annihilation and retroactive restructuring of the presupposed contents. The vulgar idea of 'dialectical development' as a continuous course of transformations by which the old dies and the new is born, in which all beckons in incessant movement - this idea of nature as a dynamic process of transformation, of generation and corruption, found everywhere from de Sade to Stalin - has nothing whatsoever to do with the Hegelian 'dialectical process'.
This quasi-'dialectical' vision of nature as an eternal circuit of transformations does not, however, exhaust the whole of Stalinism: what escapes it is precisely the subjective position of the Communist himsel£ And, to put it briefly, the place of the Stalinist Communist is exactly between the two deaths. The somewhat poetic definitions of the figure of a Communist that we find in Stalin's work are to be taken literally. When, for example, in his speech at Lenin's funeral, Stalin proclaims, 'We, the Communists, are people of a special mould. We are made of special stuff,' it is quite easy to recognize the Lacanian name for this special stuff: objet petit a, the sublime object placed in the interspace between the two deaths.
In the Stalinist vision, the Communists are 'men of iron will', somehow excluded from the everyday cycle of ordinary human passions and weakness. It is as if they are in a way 'the living dead', still alive but already excluded from the ordinary cycle of natural forces - as if, that is, they

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possess another body, the sublime body be

yond their ordinary physical
body. (Is the fact that in Lubitsch's Ninotclzka, the role of the high Party apparatchik is played by Bela Lugosi, identified with the figure of Dracula, another 'living dead', expressing a presentiment of the described state of things, or is it just a happy coincidence?) The fantasy which serves as a support for the figure of the Stalinist Communist is therefore exacdy the same as the fantasy which is at work in the Tom and Jerry cartoons: behind the figure of the indestructibility and invincibility of the Communist who can endure even the most terrible ordeal and survive it intact, reinforced with new strength, there is the same fantasy-logic as that of a cat whose head is blown up by dynamite and who, in the next scene, proceeds intact his pursuit of his class enemy, the mouse.

From the Master to the Leader

The problem is that we already find this notion of a sublime body located between the two deaths with the classical, pre-bourgeois Master: for example, the King - it is as if he possesses, beyond his ordinary body, a sublime, ethereal mystical body personi£Ying the State.8 Where, then, lies the difference between the classical Master and the totalitarian Leader? The transubstantiated body of the classical Master is an effect of the performative mechanism already described by La Boetie, Pascal and Marx: we, the subjects, think that we treat the king as a king because he is in himself a king, but in reality a king is a king because we treat him like one. And this fact that the charismatic power of a king is an effect of the symbolic ritual performed by his subjects must remain hidden: as subjects, we are necessarily victims of the illusion that the king is already in himself a king. That is why the classical" Master must legitimize his rule with a reference to some non-social, external authority (God, nature, some mythical past event . . .) - as soon as the performative mechanism which gives him his charismatic authority is demasked, the Master loses his power.

8

Ernst Kantorowicz, The King's Two Bodies, Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1959; Rado Riha, 'Das Dinghafte der Geldware', Wo es war 1, Ljubljana Vienna, 1986.

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But the problem with the totalitarian Leader is that he no longer needs this external point of reference to legitimize his rule. He is not saying to his subjects: 'You must follow me because I'm your Leader', but quite the opposite: 'In myself, I'm nothing, I am what I am only as an expression, an embodiment, an executor of your will, my strength is your strength . . .' To put it briefly, it is as if the totalitarian Leader is addressing his subjects and legitimizing his power precisely by referring to the above-mentioned Pascalian-Marxian argument - that is, revealing to them, the secret of the classical Master; basically, he is saying to them: 'I'm your Master because you treat me as your Master; it is you, with your activity, who make me your Master!'

How, then, can we subvert the position of the totalitarian Leader, if the classical Pascalian-Marxian argument no longer works? Here the basic deception consists in the fact that the Leader's point of reference, the instance to which he is referring to legitimize his rule (the People, the Class, the Nation), does not exist - or, more precisely, exists only through and in its fetishistic representative, the Party

and its Leader. The misrecog-
nition of the performative dimension runs here in the opposite direction:
the classical Master is Master only in so far as his subjects treat him as
Master, but here, the People are the 'real People' only in so far as they are
embodied in their representative, the Party and its Leader.
The formula of the totalitarian misrecognition of the performative
dimension would then be as follows: the Party thinks that it is the Party
because it represents the People's real interests, because it is rooted in the
People, expressing their will; but in reality the People are the People because
- or, more precisely, in so far as - they are embodied in the Party. And by
saying that the People do not exist as a support of the Party, we do not
mean the obvious fact that the majority of the people do not really support
Party rule; the mechanism is a little more complicated. The paradoxical
functioning of the 'People' in the totalitarian universe can be most easily
detected through analysis of phrases like 'the whole People supports the
Party'. This proposition cannot be falsified because behind the form of an
observation of a fact, we have a circular definition of the People: in the

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Stalinist universe, 'supporting the rule of the Party' is 'rigidly designated'
by the term 'People' - it is, in the last analysis, the onfy feature which in all
possible worlds difines the People. That is why the real member of the People
is only he who supports the rule of the Party: those who work against its
rule are automatically excluded from the People; they became the ' enemies
of the People'. What we have here is a somewhat crueller version of a well-
known joke: 'My fiancee never misses an appointment with me because
the moment she misses one, she is no longer my fiancee' - the People
always support the Party because any member of the People who opposes
Party rule automatically excludes himself from the People.
The Lacanian definition of democracy would then be: a sociopolitical
order in which the People do not exist - do not exist as a unity, embodied
in their unique representative. That is why the basic feature of the demo-
cratic order is that the place ofpower is, by the necessity of its structure,
an empty place.9 In a democratic order, sovereignty lies in the People -
but what is the People if not, precisely, the collection of the su,?jects of
power? Here we have the same paradox as that of a natural language which
is at the same time the ultimate, the highest metalanguage. Because the
People cannot immediately govern themselves, the place of Power must
always remain an empty place; any person occupying it can do so only
temporarily, as a kind of surrogare, a substitute for the real-impossible
sovereign - 'nobody can rule innocently', as Saint-Just puts it. And in total-
itarianism, the Party becomes again the very subject who, being the imme-
diate embodiment of the People, can rule innocently. It is not by accident
that the real-socialist countries call themselves 'people's democracies' -
here, finally, 'the People' exist again.
It is against the background of this emptying of the place of power
that we can measure the break introduced by the 'democratic invention'
(Lefort) in the history of institutions: 'democratic society' could be
determined as a society whose institutional structure includes, as a part
of its 'normal', 'regular' reprod

pear that the post-
structuralist poetic style itself - the style of continuous ironic self-commentary and self-distance, the way of constantly subverting what one was supposed to say literally - exists only to embellish some basic theoretical propositions. That is why post-structuralist commentaries often produce an effect of 'bad infinity' in the Hegelian sense: an endless quasi-poetical variation on the same theoretical assumption, a variation which does not produce anything new. The problem with deconstruction, then, is not that it renounces a strict theoretical formulation and yields to a flabby poeticism. On the contrary, it is that its position is too 'theoretical' (in the sense of a theory which excludes the truth-dimension; that is, which does not affect the place from which we speak).

The phallic signifier

How, then, can we elude this deadlock? It is here that Lacan differs radically from post-structuralists. In Seminar XI he begins one of his sentences: 'But this is precisely what I want to say and what I am saying - because what I want to say is . what I am saying . . . ' In a post-structuralist reading, such phrases prove that Lacan still wants to retain the position of Master: 'saying what I wanted to say' lays claim to a coincidence between what we intend to say and what we are effectively saying - is not this coincidence what defines the illusion of the Master? Is Lacan not proceeding as ifhis own text is exempt from the gap between what is said and what he intends to say? Is he not claiming that he can dominate the signifying effects of this text? In the Lacanian perspective it is, on the contrary, precisely such 'impossible' utterances - utterances following the logic of the paradox 'I am lying' - which keep the

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fundamental gap of the signifying process open and in this way prevent us from assuming a metalanguage position.

Lacan is close to Brecht here. One has only to remember the basic procedure of Brecht's 'learning plays' of the early 1930S in which the dramatis personae pronounce an 'impossible' commentary on their own acts. An actor enters the stage and says: 'I am a capitalist whose aim is to exploit workers. Now I will try to convince one of my workers of the truth of the bourgeois ideology which legitimizes the exploitation . . . ' He then approaches the worker and does exactly what he has announced he would do. Does such a procedure - an actor commenting on his deeds from an 'objective' position of pure metalanguage - not make it dear, in an almost palpable way, the utter impossibility of occupying this position; is it not, in its very absurdity, infinitely more subversive than the poeticism which prohibits every direct, simple utterance and feels obliged always to add new comments, retreats, digressions, brackets, quotation marks . . . - so many assurances that what we are saying is not to be taken directly or literally, as identical to itself?

Metalanguage is not just an Imaginary entity. It is Real in the strict Lacanian sense - that is, it is impossible to occupy its position. Bur, Lacan adds, it is even more difficult simply to avoid it. One cannot attain it, but one also cannot escape it. That is why the only way to avoid the Real is to produce an utterance of pure metalanguage which, by its patent absurdity, materializes its own impossibility: that is, a paradoxical element which, in its v

potent. You cannot
reallY hurtmefIn this way, the power structure is caught in the same trap. The more violent its reaction, the more it confirms its fundamental Impotence.

'Lenin in Warsaw' as of?ject

To articulate more precisely the way in which the Lacanian phallic signifier entails the impossibility of metalanguage, let us return to the post-structuralist understanding of the idea that 'there is no metalanguage'. Its starting point is the fact that the zero level of all metalanguages - natural, ordinary language - is simultaneously the last interpretative framework of all of them: it is the ultimate metalanguage. Ordinary language is its own metalanguage. It is self-referential; the place of an incessant auto-reflexive movement. In this conceptualization one does not mention the object too much. Usually, one gets rid of it simply by pointing out how 'reality' is already structured through the medium of language. In this way post-structuralists can calmly abandon themselves to the infinite self-interpretative play oflanguage. 'There is no metalanguange' is actually taken to mean its exact opposite: that there is no pure olject-la11!fua8e, any language that would function as a purely transparent medium for the designation of pre-given reality. Every 'objective' statement about things includes some kind of self-distance, a rebounding of the signifier from its 'literal meaning'. In short, language is always saying, more or less, somethi11!f other than what it means to say.

In Lacan' s teaching, however, the proposition 'there is no metalanguage' is to be taken literally. It means that all language is in a way an object-language: there is 110 la11!fuage without olject Even when the language is apparently caught in a web of self-referential movement, even when it is apparently speaking only about itself, there is an objective, non-signifying 'reference' to this movement. The Lacanian mark of it is, of course, the

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objet petit a. The self-referential movement of the signifier is not that of a closed circle, but an elliptical movement around a certain void. And the objet petit a, as the original lost object which in a way coincides with its own loss, is precisely the embodiment of this void.

This 'internal exclusion' of the object from the Other of the symbolic network also allows us to expose the confusion upon which the Derridean assumption of the 'title-address of the letter' [le titre de la lettre] rests: that is, the criticism of Lacanian theory in which, according to Derrida, the letter always possesses its title-address, always reaches its destination. This is supposed to attest to the 'closed economy' of the Lacanian concept of the Symbolic: the central point of reference (the signifier oflack) allegedly precludes the possibility that a letter could go astray, lose its circular-teleological path and miss its address.5

Where does the misunderstanding in this criticism lie? It is true that in Lacanian theory ' every letter has its title', but this title is definitely not some kind of telosofits trajectory. The Lacanian 'title of the letter' is closer to the title of a picture; for example, that described in a well-known joke about 'Lenin in Warsaw'. At an art exhibition in Moscow, there is a picture showing Nadezhda Krupskaya, Lenin's wife, in bed with a young member of the Komsomol. The title of the picture is 'Lenin in

oon as the vorstellungsrepriisentanz is no longer connected to this hole in the Other, to the falling out of the object, it begins to function as a 'title': as a metalanguage designation, as an incision that limits, totalizes, canalizes the original dispersion of the signifying texture . . . in short, we find ourselves in a 'post-structuralist' mess.

If the joke about Lenin in Warsaw exemplifies the logic of the master-signifier, there is another joke - in a way its symmetrical inversion - which exemplifies the logic of the object: the joke about the conscript who tries to evade military service by pretending to be mad. His symptom is that he compulsively checks all the pieces of paper he can lay his hands on, constantly repeating: 'That is not itl' He is sent to the military psychiatrist, in whose office he also examines all the papers lying around, including those in the wastepaper basket, repeating all the time: 'That is not itl' The psychiatrist, finally convinced that he really is mad, gives him a written warrant releasing him from military service. The conscript casts a look at it and says cheerfully: 'That is it!'

We can say that this little piece of paper finally found - a warrant of release - has the status of an object in the Lacanian sense. Why? Because it is an object produced by the signifying texture itself It is a kind of object that came to exist as a result of all the fuss about it. The 'mad' conscript pretends to look for something, and through his very search, through its repeated failure ('That is not itl'), he produces what he is looking for. The paradox, then, is that the process of searching itself produces the object which calLfesit: an exact parallel to Lacanian desire which produces its own object-cause. The error of all the people around the conscript, the psychiatrist included, is that they overlook the way they are already part of the 'mad' conscript's game. They think they are examining him from an objective, metalanguage distance, like the bewildered spectator of the picture 'Lenin in Warsaw' who mistook the picture's tide for a metalanguage description of its content.

Their error is therefore symmetrical. In the case of ' Lenin in Warsaw' the tide is on the same level as the depicted content of the picture and is

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not a metalanguage designation of it. In the second example, the paper as an object is part of the actual signifying process; its product and not its external reference. First we have the paradox of a signifier which is a part of the representation ofreality (filling out a void, a hole in it). Then we have the inverse paradox of an oiject which must be included in the signifjing texture. Perhaps this double paradox offers us the final due to the Lacanian propositon: 'There is no metalanguage'.

AntU[Jollism as Real

To grasp this logic of an object included in the signifying texture, we must bear in mind the paradoxical character of the Lacanian Real. It is usually conceived as a hard kernel resisting symbolization, dialecticization, persisting in its place, always returning to it. There is a well-known science-fiction story ('Experiment' by Fredric Brown) that illustrates this' point perfectly: Professor Johnson has developed a small-scale experimental model of a time machine. Small articles placed on it can be sent into the past or the future. He first demonstrates to his two colleag

fight to death
between the (future) master and servant in Hegel's Phenomenology of Spirit: it is senseless trying to determine when this event could have taken place; the point is just that it must be presupposed, that it constitutes a fantasy-scenario implied by the very fact that people work - it is the intersubjective condition, of the so-called 'instrumental relation to the world of objects'.
The paradox of the Lacanian Real, then, is that it is an entity which, although it does not exist (in the sense of'really existing', taking place in reality), has a series of properties - it exercises a certain structural causality, it can produce a series of effects in the symbolic reality of subjects. That is why it can be illustrated by a multitude of well-known jokes based on the same matrix: 'Is this the place where the Duke of Wellington spoke his famous words?' - 'Yes, this is the place, but he never spoke those words' - these never-spoken words are a Lacanian ReaL One can quote examples ad irifinitum: 'Smith not only doesn't believe in ghosts; he isn't even afraid of them!' . . . up to God himself who, according to Lacan, belongs to the Real: 'God has all perfections except one - he doesn't exist!' In this sense, the Lacanian subjet suppose saJloir (the subject presumed to know) is also such a real entity: it does not exist, but it produces a decisive shift in the development of the psychoanalytic cure.
To mention the final example: the famous MacGuffin, the Hitch-cockian object, the pure pretext whose sole role is to set the story in motion but which is in itself' nothing at all' - the only significance of the MacGuffin lies in the fact that it has some significance for the characters - that it must seem to be of vital importance to them. The original anecdote is well known: two men are sitting in a train; one of them asks: 'What's that package up there in the luggage rack?' 'Oh, that's a MacGuffin.' 'What's a MacGuffin?' 'Well, it's an apparatus for trapping lions in the Scottish Highlands.' 'But there are no lions in the Scottish Highlands.' 'Well, then, that's not a MacGuffin.' There is another version which is much more to the point: it is the same as the other, with the exception of the last answer: 'Well, you see how efficient it is!' - that's a MacGuffin, a pure nothing which is none the less efficient. Needless to add, the MacGuffin is the purest case

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of what Lacan calls objet petit a: a pure void which functions as the object-cause of desire.
That would be, then, the precise definition of the real object: a cause which in itself does not exist - which is present only in a series of effects, but always in a distorted, displaced way. If the Real is the impossible, it is precisely this impossibility which is to be grasped through its effects. Laclau and Mouffe were the first to develop this logic of the Real in its relevance for the social-ideological field in their concept of antagonism: antagonism is precisely such an impossible kernel, a certain limit which is in itself nothing; it is only to be constructed retroactively, from a series of its effects, as the traumatic point which escapes them; it prevents a closure of the social field. In this way we might reread even the classic notion of the 'class struggle': it is not the last signifier giving meaning to all social phenomena ('all social processes are in the fi

nal analysis
expressions of the class struggle'), but - quite the contrary - a certain limit, a pure negativity, a traumatic limit which prevents the final totalization of the social-ideological field. The 'class struggle' is present only in its effects, in the fact that every attempt to totalize the social field, to assign to social phenomena a definite place in the social structure, is always doomed to failure.
If we define the Real as such a paradoxical, chimerical entity which, although it does not exist, has a series of properties and can produce a series of effects, it becomes clear that the Real par excellence is jouissance: jouissance does not exist, it is impossible, but it produces a number of traumatic effects. This paradoxical nature ofjouissallce also offers us a clue to explaining the fundamental paradox which unfailingly attests the presence of the Real: the fact of the prohibition of something which is already in itself impossible. The elementary model is, of course, the prohibition of incest; but there are many other examples - let us cite only the usual conservative attitude towards child sexuality: it does not exist, children are innocent beings, that is why we must control them strictly and fight child sexuality - not to mention the obvious fact that the most famous phrase of all analytical philosophy - the last proposition of

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Wittgenstein's Tractatus - implies the same paradox: 'Whereof one cannot speak, thereof one must be silent: Immediately, the stupid question arises: ifit is already stated that it is impossible to say anything about the unspeakable, why add that we must /lot speak about it? We find the same paradox in Kant: when treating the question of the origins oflegitimate state power, he says directly that we cannot penetrate, the obscure origins of power because we should not do so (because by doing so, we put ourselves outside its domain and so automatically subvert its legitimacy) - a curious variation on his basic ethical imperative Du kannst, denn du sollst!-You can, because you must!
The solution to this paradox - why forbid something which is already in itself impossible? - lies in the fact that the impossibility relates to the level of existence (it is impossible; that is, it doesn't exist), while the prohibition relates to the properties it predicates (jouissance is forbidden because of its properties).
Theforced choice iffteedom
In this sense, we may say that the status offreedom itselfis real. The usual '(post-)structuralist' approach would be to denounce 'freedom' as an imaginary experience resting on misrecognition, on a blindness to the structural causality which determines the activity of subjects. Bur on the basis of Lacan's teaching in the 1970s, we can approach freedom from another perspective: freedom, 'free choice', as the real-impossible.
A few months ago, a Yugoslav student was called to regular military service. In Yugoslavia, at the beginning of military service, there is a certain ritual: every new soldier must solemnly swear that he is willing to serve his country and to defend it even if that means losing his life, and so on -the usual patriotic stuff. After the public ceremony, everybody must sign the solemn document. The young soldier simply refused to sign, saying that an oath depends upon free choice, that it is a matter offree decision, and he, from his free choi

impression is that his wickedness does not simply depend upon circumstances (which are by definition extenuating) but is an integral part of his eternal nature. In other words, 'wickedness' appears to be something which is irrevocably given: the person in question can never change it, outgrow it via his ultimate moral development.

On the other hand, however, we have a contradictory sentiment according to which the evil person is wholly responsible for his wickedness, although it is integral to his nature - that is, although 'he was born like that': 'to be evil' is not the same as to be stupid, irascible, and other similar features pertaining to our psychic nature. Evil is always experienced as something pertaining to a free choice, to a decision for which the subject has to assume all responsibility. How can we resolve this contradiction between the 'natural', given character of human Evil and that same Evil as pertaining to a free choice? Kant's solution consists in conceiving the choice of Evil, the decision of Evil, as an atemporal, a priori, transcendental act: as an act which never took place in temporal reality but none the less constitutes the very frame of the subject's development, of his practical activity.

Lacan was thus quite justified in locating the starting point of the 'movement of ideas' which culminated in the Freudian discovery in Kant's

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philosophy, more specifically in his Critique oJPractical Reason.7 One of the consequ?nces of the Kantian revolution in the domain of'practical reason' usually passed over in silence was that with Kant, for the first time, Evil as such acquired a proper ethical status. That is to say, with his idea of an 'original Evil' inscribed into the atemporal character of a person, Evil becomes an affair of principle, an ethical attitude - 'ethical' in the exact sense of an impetus of the will beyond the pleasure principle (and its prolongation, the reality principle). 'Evil' is no longer a simple opportunist activity taking into account only 'pathological' motives (pleasure, profit, utility . . .), it is, on the contrary, an affair of the eternal and autonomous character of a person pertaining to his original, atemporal choice. This again confirms the paradoxical Lacanian conjunction 'Kant avec Sade', as well as the fact that in the epoch of Kant, we witness the resurgence of a series ?f musical and literary figures embodying Evil qua ethical attitude (from Mozart's Don Giovanni to the Byronesque Romantic hero).

In his Treatise on Human Freedom (1809), Schelling, the ' acme of German idealism' (Heidegger), radicalized the Kantian theory by introducing a crucial distinction between freedom (free choice) and consciousness: the atemporal choice by means of which the subject chooses himself as 'good' or 'evil' is an unconscious choice (how can we not recall, apropos of this Schellingian distinction, the Freudian thesis concerning the atemporal character of the unconscious?). Let us resume Schelling's line of reasoning. Freedom is posited as the cause of Evil - that is, Evil results from a free choice of the subject, from his decision for it. If, however, freedom is the cause of Evil, how do we account for the innumerable evils, moral and physical, which seem notto depend on our conscious will? The only possible solution is to presuppose some fundamental choice precedil18 our conscious

product, a leftover
of symbolization, it is, in contrast, the void, the emptiness created, encircled by the symbolic structure. We might also approach the same pair of opposites from the perspective of negativity: the Real is something that cannot be negated, a positive inert datum which is insensitive to negation, cannot be caught in the dialectics of negativity; but we must add at once that it is so because the Real itself, in its positivity, is nothing but an embodiment of a cettain void, lack, radical negativity. It cannot be negated because it is alreacfy in itself, in its positivi9', nothing but an embodiment ofa pure negativi9', emptiness. That is why the real object is a sublime object in a strict Lacanian sense - an object which is just an embodiment of the lack in the Other, in the symbolic order. The sublime object is an object which cannot be approached too closely: if we get too near it, it loses its sublime features and becomes an ordinary vulgar object - it can persist only in an interspace, in an intermediate state, viewed from a certain perspective, half-seen. If we want to see it in the light of day, it changes into an everyday object, it dissipates itself, precisely because in itself it is nothing at all. Let us take a well-known scene from Fellini's Roma: the workers digging tunnels for a subway find the remnants of some old Roman buildings; they call the archaeologists, and when they enter the buildings together, a marvellous view awaits them: walls full of beautiful frescos of immobile, melancholic figures - but the paintings are too fragile, they cannot withstand the open air and immediately begin to dissolve, leaving the spectators alone with the blank walls . . .
? As Jacques-Alain Miller has already pointed out (in his unpublished seminar), the status of the Real is at the same time that of corporeal contingency and that oflogical consistency. In a first approach, the Real is a shock of a contingent encounter which disrupts the automatic circulation of the symbolic mechanism; a grain of sand preventing its smooth functioning; a traumatic encounter which ruins the balance of the symbolic universe of the subject. But, as we

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have seen with regard to trauma, precisely as an irruption of a total contingency, the traumatic event is nowhere given in its positivity, only afterwards can it be logicalfy constructed as a point which escapes symbolization.
? If we try to seize the Real from the perspective of the distinction between quid and quod, between the properties of a symbolic-universal nature attributed to an object and this object itself in its givenness, a surplus of an X escaping, in its positivity, the network of universal-symbolic determinations - that is, if we try to approach the Real through the field opened by the Kripkean criticism of the theory of descriptions - we should say, first, that the Real is the surplus of quod over quid, a pure positivity beyond the series of properties, beyond a set of descriptions; bur at the same time, the example of trauma proves that the Real is also the exact opposite: an entity which docs not exist but has nevertheless a series of properties.
? Finally, if we try to define the Real in its relation to the function of writing (em't, not the post-structuralist ecriture), we must, of course, in a first approach state that the Real cannot be inscribed, that it
e

ourse,
in a first approach, that which cannot be inscribed, which 'doesn't cease not to inscribe itself [ne cesse pas de ne pas s'ecrireJ' - the rock upon which every formalization stumbles. But it is precisely through this failure that we can in a way encircle, locate the empty place of the Real. In oth\![words, the Real cannot be inscribed, but we can inscribe this impossibility itself, we can locate its place: a traumatic place which causes a series offailures. And Lacan's whole point is that the Real is nothil18 but this impossibility of its inscription: the Real is not a transcendent positive entity, persisting somewhere beyond the symbolic order like a hard kernel inaccessible to it, some kind of Kantian 'Thing-in-itself - in itself it is nothing at all, just a void, an emptiness in a symbolic structure marking some central impossibility. It is in this sense that the enigmatic Lacanian phrase defining the subject as an 'answer of the Rear is to be understood: we can inscribe, encircle the void place of the subject through the failure of his symbolization, because the subject is nothing but the failure point of the process of his symbolic representation.
In the Lacanian perspective, the object as real is then, in the final analysis, just a certain limit: we can overtake it, leave it behind us, but we cannot reach it. That is the Lacanian reading of the classic paradox of Achilles and the tortoise: Achilles can of course overtake her, but he cannot reach her, catch up with her. It is like the old Brechtian paradox of happiness from the Threepen'!J' Opera: you must not run too desperately after happiness, because if you do you might overtake it and happiness will remain behind you . . . That is the Lacanian Real: a certain limit which is always missed - we always come too early or too late. And, as the late Michel Silvestre pointed out, the same thing also goes for so-called 'free association' in psychoanalysis: on the one hand it is impossible to reach it, we cannot really spontaneously give ourselves to it, we always manipulate, have a certain intention, and so on; but on the other hand wecannotescape it; whatever we say during analysis already has the status
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Lacan, Le sfminaire xx Encore, p. 85.

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of free association.'o For example, I cannot, in the middle of the analysis, turn to the analyst and say: 'Now wait a minute, I want to speak to you really seriously, as person to person . . .' - even if we do this, its performative force is already suspended - that is, it already has the status of 'free association', of something that is to be interpreted, not taken at its face value.
Another Hegelian joke
What notion of the subject is compatible with this paradoxical character of the Real? The basic feature of the Lacanian subject is, of course, its alienation in the signifier: as soon as the subject is caught in the radically external signifying network he is mortified, dismembered, divided. To get an idea of what is meant by the Lacanian division of the subject, one has only to remember Lewis Carroll's well-known paradox: 'I'm so glad I don't like asparagus: said the small girl to a sympathetic friend, 'because, ifI did, I should have to eat it - and I can't bear it!' Here we have the whole Lacanian problem of the reflexivity of desire: desire is always a desire of a desire - the question is not immediately 'What s

hould I desire?' but 'There are a
lot of things that I desire, I have a lot of desires - which of them is worth
being the object of my desire? Which desire should I desire?'
This paradox is literally reproduced in the basic situation of the classic
Stalinist political processes, in which the accused victim is at the same
time supposed to confess his love for asparagus (the bourgeoisie, the
counter-revolution) and express an attitude of disgust towards his own
activity, to the point of demanding for himself the death penalty. That is
why the Stalinist victim is the perfect example of the difference between
the szget d'enonce(subject of the statement) and the sujet d'enonciation
(subject of the enunciation). The demand that the Party is addressing to
him is: 'At this moment, the Parry needs the process to consolidate the
revolutionary gains, so be a good Communist, do a last service to the Party
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Michel Silvestre, Demaill la p!ychallafyse, Paris: Navarin, 1988.

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and confess.' Here we have the division of the subject in its purest form:
the only way for the accused to confirm himself as a good Communist at the
level of the sl!Jet d'enonaation is to confess - to determine himself, at the level
of the sl!Jet d'enonce, as a traitor. Ernesto Laclau was perhaps right when
he once remarked (in a private conversation) that it is not only Stalinism
which is a linguistic phenomenon, but language itself which is a Stalinist
phenomenon.
Here, however, we must distinguish carefully between this Lacanian
notion of the divided subject and the 'post-structuralist' notion of the
subject-positions. In 'post-structuralism', the subject is usually reduced
to so-called subjectivation, he is conceived as an effect of a fundamentally
non-subjective process: the subject is always caught in, traversed by the
pre-subjective process (of'writing', of'desire' and so on], and the emphasis
is on the individuals' different modes of 'experiencing', 'living' their
positions as 'subjects', 'actors', 'agents' of the historical process. For
example, only at a certain point in European history did the author of
works of art, a painter or a writer, begin to see himself as a creative indi-
vidual who, in his work, gives expression to his interior subjective richness.
The great master of such analysis was, of course, Foucault: one might say
that the main point of his late work was to articulate the different modes
by which individuals assume their subject-positions.
But with Lacan, we have quite another notion of the subject. To put it
simply: if we make an abstraction, if we subtract all the richness of the
different modes of subjectivation, all the fullness of experience present in
the way the individuals are 'living' their subject-positions, what remains
is an empty place which was filled out with this richness; this original
void, this lack of symbolic structure, is the subject, the subject of the
signifier. The subject is therefore to be strictly opposed to the effect of
subjectivatiolt. what the subjectivation masks is not a pre-or trans-subjective
process of writing but a lack in the structure, a lack which is the subject.
Our predominant idea of the subject is, in Lacanian terms, that of the
'subject of the signified', the active agent, the bearer of some signification
who is trying to express himself in language. Lacan's starting point is, of

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course, that symbolic representation always distorts the subject, that it is always a displacement, a failure - that the subject cannot find a signifier which would be 'his own', that he is always saying too little or too much: in short, something other than what he wanted or intended to say.
The usual conclusion from this would be that the subject is some kind of interior richness of meaning which always exceeds its symbolic articulation: 'language cannot express fully what I'm trying to say . . :
The Lacanian thesis is the opposite: this surplus of signification masks a fundamental lack. The subject of the signifier·is precisely this lack, this impossibility of finding a signifier which would be 'its own': the foilure if its representation is its positive condition. The subject tries to articulate itself in a signifying representation; the representation fails; instead of a richness we have a lack, and this void opened by the failure is the subject of the signifier. To put it paradoxically: the subject of the signifier is a retroactive effect of.the failure of its own representation; that is why the failure of representation is the only way to represent it adequately.
Here we have a kind of dialogic economy: we articulate a proposition defining the subject, our attempt fails, we experience the absolute contradiction, the extreme negative relationship between the subject and the predicate - and this absolute discordance is the subject as absolute negativity. It is like a well-known Soviet joke about Rabinovitch, a Jew who wants to emigrate. The bureaucrat at the emigration office asks him why; Rabinovitch answers: 'There are two reasons why. The .first is that I'm afraid that in the Soviet Union the Communists will lose power, there will be a counter-revolution and the new power will put all the blame for the Communist crimes on us, Jews - there will again be anti-Jewish pogroms . . . ' 'But', interrupts the bureaucrat, 'this is pure nonsense, nothing can change in the Soviet Union, the power of the Communists will last for ever!' 'Well: responds Rabinovitch calmly, 'that's my second reason: The logic is the same here as in the Hegelian proposition 'the spirit is a bone': the very failure of the first reading gives us the true meaning.

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The Rabinovitch joke also exemplifies the logic of the ill-famed Hegelian triad: if the first reason for emigrating is the 'thesis' and the bureaucrat's objection the 'anti-thesis', then the 'synthesis' is not any kind of return to the thesis, some kind of healing of the wound made by the anti-thesis - the '!Jnthesis'is exactfy thesame as the anti-thesis, the only difference lies in a certain change of perspective, in a certain turn through which what was a moment ago experienced as an obstacle, as an impediment, proves itself to be a positive condition: the fact that Soviet power is eternal, which was proposed as an argument qqainrtemigrating, reveals itself as the real reason JOremigrating.
This is also, in a nutshell, the logic of the 'negation of the negation': this double, self-referential negation does not entail any kind of return to positive identity, any kind of abolition, of cancellation of the disruptive force of negativity, of reducing it to a passing moment in the self-mediating process of identity; in the 'negation of the negation', the neg

ativity
preserves all its disruptive power; the whole point is just that we come to experience how this negative, disruptive power, menacing our identity, is simultaneously a positive condition of it. The 'negation of the negation' does not in any way abolish the antagonism, it consists only in the experience of the fact that this immanent limit which is preventing me from achieving my full identity with myself simultaneously enables me to achieve a minimum of positive consistency, however mutilated it is. To give a most elementary example: in the anti-Semitic vision, the Jew is experienced as the embodiment of negativity, as the force disrupting stable social identity - but the 'truth' of anti-Semitism is, of course, that the very identity of our position is structured through a negative relationship to this traumatic figure of the Jew. Without the reference to the Jew who is cotroding the social fabric, the social fabric itself would be dissolved. In other words, all my positive consistency is a kind of'reaction-formation' to a certain traumatic, antagonistic kernel: ifI lose this 'impossible' point of reference, my very identity dissolves.
This, then, is the 'negation of the negation': not a kind of'superseding' of negativity but the experience of the fact that the negativi9' as such has a positivefunction, enables and structures our positive consistency. In simple

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negation, there is still the pre-given positive identity which is being negated, the movement of negativity is still conceived as the limitation of some pre-given positivity; while in the 'negation of the negation', negativity is in a way prior to what is being negated, it is a negative movement which opens the very place where every positive identity can be situated.
If, then, antagonism is always a kind of opening, a hole in the field of the symbolic Other, a void of an unanswered, unresolved question, the 'negation of the negation' does not bring us the final answer filling out the void of all questions: it is to be conceived more like a paradoxical twist whereby the question itseffbegins to JUnction as its own answer. what we mistook for a question was already an answer. To explain this, let us take an example from Adorno concerning the antagonistic character of society."
Adorno starts from the fact that today it is not possible to formulate one appropriate definition of Society: as soon as we set to work, a number of opposing, mutually excluding determinations present themselves: on the one hand those which lay stress upon Society as an organic whole encompassing individuals; on the other those which conceive Society as a bond, a kind of contract between atomized individuals - in short, we find ourselves caught in the opposition between 'organicism' and 'individualism'.
In a first approach, this opposition presents itself as an epistemological obstacle, as a hindrance preventing us from grasping Society as it is in itself - making out of Society a kind of Kantian Thing-in-itself which can be approached only through partial, distorted insights: its real nature escapes us for ever. But in a dialectical approach, this contradiction which appears at first as an unresolved question is already in itself a solution: far from barting our access to the real essence of Society, the opposition between 'organicism' and 'individualism' is not only epistemological but is

question, it is as an al15Wer, the
answer of the Real to the question asked by the big Other, the symbolic order.l) It is not the subject which is asking the question; the subject is the void of the impossibility of answering the question of the Other.
To explain this, let us refer to an interesting book by Aron Bodenheimer: w1!Y? On the obsceni9' of Qy.estioning. Its fundamental thesis is that there is something obscene in the very act of asking a question, without regard to its content. It is the form of the question as such which is obscene: the question lays open, exposes, denudes its addressee, it invades his sphere of intimacy; this is why the basic, elementary reaction to a question is shame on the bodily level, blushing and lowering our eyes, like a child of whom we ask 'What were you doing?' It is clear in our everyday experience that such a questioning of children is a priori incriminating, provoking a sensation of guilt: What were you doing? Where were you? What does this white spot mean?' Even ifI can offer an answer which is objectively true and at the same time delivers me from guilt ('I was studying with my friend', for example), the guilt is already admitted on the level of desire; every answer is an excuse. With a prompt answer like 'I was studying with my friend' I am confirming precisely that I did not really want to do so, that my desire was to stroll about, or something of that nature . . .
13
Jacques Alain Miller, 'Les Reponses du reel', in Aspects du malaise dallS la civilisadon, Paris: Navarin, 1987.

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Qgestioning is the basic procedure of the totalitarian intersubjective relationship: one need not refer to such exemplary cases as police interrogation or religious confession; it is quite sufficient to recall the usual abuse of the enemy in the real-socialist press: how much more threatening is the question 'Who is really hiding behind . . . [the demands for the freedom of the press, for democracy]? who is really pulling the strings of the so-called new social movements? Who is really speaking through them?' than the vulgar, direct positive affirmation: 'Those who demand the freedom of the press really want to open the space for the activity of counter-socialist powers and in this way diminish the hegemony of the working class . . .' Totalitarian power is not a dogmatism which has all the answers; it is, on the contrary, the instance which has all the questions.
The basic indecency of the question consists in its drive to put into words what should be left unspoken, as in the well-known dialogue: 'What were you doing?' 'You know whatl' 'Yes, but I want you to tell me!' which is the instance in the other, in its addressee, that the question is aiming at? It aims at a point at which the answer is not possible, where the word is lacking, where the subject is exposed in his impotence. We can illustrate this by the inverse type of question, not the question of the authority to its subjects but the question of the subject-child to his father: the stake of such a question is always to catch the other who embodies authority in his impotence, in his inability, in his lack.
Bodenheimer articulates this dimension apropos of the child's question, to the father: 'Father, why is the sky blue?' - the child is not really interested in the sky as such; the real stake of the question is to expose father's impotence, his h

elplessness in the face of the hard fact that the sky is blue, his incapacity to substantiate this fact, to present the whole chain of reasons leading to it. The blue of the sky thus becomes not only the father's problem, but in a way even his fault: 'The sky is blue, and you're just staring at it like an idiot, incapable of doing anything about it!' A question, even ifit refers only to a given state of things, always makes the subject formally responsible for it, although only in a negative way - responsible, that is, for his impotence in the face of this fact.

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What, then, is this point in the other at which the word fails, this point of impotence at which the question as such is aiming? The question as such creates shame because it aims at my innermost, intimate kernel called by Freud Kern U/lSeres Wesens and by Lacan das Ding: at that strange body in my interior which is 'in me more than me', which is radically interior and at the same time already exterior and for which Lacan coined a new word, extime. The real object of the question is what plato, in the ?mposium, called -through the mouth of Akibiades - agalma, the hidden treasure, the essential object in me which cannot be objectivated, dominated. (Lacan develops this concept in his unpublished Seminar VIII on Transference.) The Lacanian formula for this object is of course oijet petit a, this point of Real in the very heart of the subject which cannot be symbolized, which is produced as a residue, a remnant, a leftover of every signifYing operation, a hard core embodying horrifjringjouiITance, enjoyment, and as such an object which simultaneously atrracts and repels us - which divides our desire and thus provokes shame. Our thesis is that it is precisely the question in its obscene dimension, in so far as it aims at the ex-timate kernel, at what is in the subject more than subject, at the oiject in suijea which is constitutive for the subject. In other words there is no subject without guilt, the subject exists only in so far as he is ashamed becatise of the object in himself, in its interior. This is the meaning ofLacan's thesis that the subject is originally split, divided: he is divided as to the object himself, as to the Thing, which at the same time attracts and repels him: ?Oa.

Let us resume: the subject is an answer of the Real (of the object, of the traumatic kernel) to the question of the Other. The question as such produces in its addressee an effect of shame and guilt, it divides, it hysteri-cizes him, and this hystericization is the constitution of the subject: the status of the subject as such is hysterical. The subject is constituted through his own division, splitting, as to the object in him; this object, this traumatic kernel, is the dimension that we have already named as that of a 'death drive', of a traumatic imbalance, a rooting out. Man as such is 'nature sick unto death', derailed, run off the rails through a fascination with a lethal Thing.

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The process ofinterpellation-subjectivation is precisely an attempt to elude, to avoid this traumatic kernel through identification: in assuming a symbolic mandate, in recognizing himself in the interpellation, the subject evades the dimension of the Thing. (There are, of course, other possibilities of avoiding this hysterical deadlock: the perverse po

sition, for
example, in which the subject identifies himself immediately with the object and thus relieves himself of the burden of the question. Psychoanalysis itself also de-hystericizes the subject, but in another way: at the end of the psychoanalysis the question is, so to speak, returned to the Other, the impotence of the subject displaces itself into the impossibility proper to the Other: the subject experiences the Other as blocked, failed, marked with a central impossibility - in brief, as 'antagonistic'.)
The subject, then, as an impossible answer, consubstantive with a certain guilt - the first literary association which comes to our mind is of course the work of Franz Kafka. Indeed, we might say that Kafka's achievement is to articulate this paradoxical status of the subject before subjectivation - we were speaking of shame, and the last words of The Trial are 'it was as ifhe meant the shame of it to outlive him." 4
This is why we find in Kafka's work the reverse, disquieting side of the comical aspect of the interpellation: the illusion proper to interpellation, the illusion of , already-there', shows its negative face. The procedure of incrimination is to put the subject into the position of somebody who is alrearfy presumed to know (to use this Lacanian term in another context). For example, in The TnalJosefK. is summoned to appear before the Court on Sunday morning: the exact time of interrogation is not specified. When he finally finds the courtroom, the judge reproaches him: 'You should have been here an hour and five minutes ago.'15 Some of us probably remember the same situation from army service: the corporal incriminates us from the very beginning with the cry: 'What are you staring at like idiots? Don't you know what to do? One really has to explain things to
14 Franz Kafka, The Tna/, Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1985, p. 251.
15 Ibid., p. 47.

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you again and again!' - and he then proceeds to give us instructions as if they were superfluous, as if we should already know them. This, therefore, is the reverse side of the ideological 'already-there' illusion: the subject is incriminated by suddenly being thrown into a situation in which he is presumed to know what is expected of him.
S(I), a, ifJ
How do we specify the dimension of this 'object in subject' which causes the presumption of knowledge? That is to say, there are objects and objects - in Lacan's teaching, we have to distinguish at least three types of object. To articulate these distinctions, let us return to the MacGuffin - we must not forget that in Hitchcock's films, too, the MacGuffin is just one of three types of object:
? First, then, the MacGuffin itself, 'nothing at all', an empty place, a pure pretext for setting the action in motion: the formula of the aircraft engines in The Thir9'-Nine Steps, the secret clause of the naval treaty in The Foreign Correspondent, the coded melody in The Latfy Vanishes, the uranium bottles in Notorious, and so on. It is a pure semblance: in itself it is totally indifferent and, by structural necessity, absent; its signification is purely auto-reflexive, it consists in the fact that it has some signification for others, for the principal characters of the story.
? But in a series of Hitchcock's films, we find another type of object which is decidedly not indifferent, not pure absence: what matters here is prec

ence in the
other. That is the logic of the 'subject presumed to know' which Lacan isolated as the central axis, anchor, of the phenomenon of transference: the analyst is presumed to know in advance - what? - the meaning of the analysand's symptoms. This knowledge is of course an illusion, but it is a necessary one: in the end only through this supposition of knowledge can some real knowledge be produced. In the scheme above we have three versions of the object around the central nauseous protuberance ofjouissance, the Thing in its inaccessibility; one is tempted to construct, on the same matrix, three other concepts around the subject presumed to know.
? Let us start with the subject presumed to believe.I8 Coming from Yugoslavia - that is, from a real-socialist country - the author of this book is tempted to take an example typical of , really existing socialism' where, as is well known, there is always something lacking in the shops. Our hypothetical starting point is that there is an abundance of toilet paper on the market. But, suddenly and unex-pectedly, a rumour starts to circulate that there is a shortage of toilet paper - because of this rumour, people frantically begin to buy it,
18
Rastko Mocnik, 'Ueber die Bedeutung der Chimaren fur die cOl1din"o humana', Wo es war 1, Ljubjana Vienna, 1986.

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and of course the result is that there is a real shortage of toilet paper. At first sight this seems to be a simple mechanism of what is called self-fulfilling prophecy, but the effective way in which it functions is a little more complicated. Each participant reasons as follows: 'I'm not naive and stupid, I know very well that there is more than enough toilet paper in the shops; but there are probably some naive and stupid people who believe these rumours, who take them seriously and will act accordingly - they will start frantically buying toilet paper and so in the end there will be a real shortage of it; so even if! know very well that there is enough, it would be a good idea to go and buy a 10tl'The crucial point is that this other presumed to believe naively does not have to exist effectively: to produce his effects in reality, it is enough that he is presumed by others to exist. In a definite, closed multitude of subjects, each person can play this role for all the others - the effect will be exactly the same: a real shortage of toilet paper. The one who will in the end remain without it will be precisely the one who persists in the truth: the one who says to himself, 'I know that this is only a rumour, there is enough toilet paper' and acts upon it . . .
This concept of the subject presumed to believe also has its clinical use: it serves to mark the difference between real Freudian analysis and the revisionist cure. While in Freudian analysis the analyst plays the role of the subject presumed to know, in the revisionist tradition his role is closer to that of the subject presumed to believe; that is to say, in this case the reasoning of the patient goes as follows: 'I have some psychic problems, I'm neurotic, so I need an analyst to cure me. The problem is that I don't believe in maternal phallus, symbolic castration and all that shit - to me this is plain nonsense. But happily for me, here is an analyst who believes in it and, why not, perhaps he can cure me with his belief!' No wonder various neo-Freudian schools try

try of the father
(who, despite his treason, remains a gentleman of the old school) prevents
him from simply flying into a temper after he hears the approaching car
and so unmasks the extortioner's bluff: he continues calmly with his job
and lets the extortioner know that he has seen through his cards ill the
ve'Y fonn of the corifession.
What is the libidinal charge of this gesture? The treacherous father
from Foreign Correspolldent is one in the series of Hitchcockian villains
gnawed by the knowledge of their own corruption: unconsciously, they
desire unmasking and self-destruction; this truth emerges, articulates
itself in the fonn of the confession, persisting even when the reasons for
it proved invalid. This is the 'unconscious' in the Lacanian sense: a desire
which articulates itselfin the very gap separating the form from its content,
in the autonomy of the form. Behind the ironic-gallant gesture of the
father addressed to the extortioner (meaning something like: 'Here you
have the confession you wanted! I'm giving you back your own cardsI')
there is a desperate eruption of the desire for self-purification, a desire

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which realizes itself towards the end of the film with the father's suicidal
act.
The word 'gallantry' was not used carelessly: it has to be conceived in
its precise Rococo-pre-Romantic, Mozartian meaning. That is to say, one
of the most subversive features of Mozart' s operas consists precisely in the
adroit manipulation of the gap between form and content, where it is the
form which articulates the 'repressed' truth of the content. Leaving aside
Don Giovanni, which is in its entirety the embodiment of this gap (on the
level of ' content', Don Giovanni runs from one fiasco to another, while
the musical form emphasizes more and more his triumphalism, his myth-
ical power), it is sufficient to recall a small detail from the finale of Le nom
di Figaro, the aria which follows the reconciliation between Figaro and
Susanna ('Pace, pace . .
.'). At first, form and content accord with each other:
the elucidation of the misunderstanding (Figaro knew that the woman
he was making a conquest of was not the Countess but his beloved Susanna
dressed up as the Countess) is confirmed by their harmonized duet which
attests to their reconcilation; this duet then changes into a trio: from the
background breaks in the angry voice of the Count looking for Susanna
in the park (to entrap him, she had promised him a rendezvous).
With this emergence of a third voice, form and content split, each goes
its own way: on the level of content, we have tension, disharmony, contrast-
ing with the former spirit of reconciliation (the Count angrily asking what
Susanna is up to), but what is crucial is the fact that the Count articulates
his anger ill the ve!y nzelotfy used by Figaro and Susanna to express their recondl-
iation - on the level ofform there is no discontinuity, no rupture, the same
melodic line simply goes on . . . In this way, all is actually said: the recon-
ciliation isalreatfy here, the Count's tension is already pacified, he has already
lost, he simply does not yet know it, or, more precisely - and this is the
crucial point - he does not know yet that he alreatfy knows it, because uncon-
sciously he does already know it, he is already pacified, resigned to the
loss of Susanna. His unconscious knowledge erupts again precise

na and of excluding
from it the 'Thing-in-itself apparendy expresses an aspiration to truth - the fear of falling into error by illegitimately taking phenomena for the Thing-in-itself However, as Hegel puts it, this fear of error, of a confusion between phenomena and the Thing-in-itself, conceals its opposite, the fear of Truth - it announces a desire to elude, at any price, an encounter with the Truth: if the fear of falling into error sets up a mistrust of Science, which in the absence of such scruples gets on with the work itself, and actually cognizes something, it is hard to see why we should not turn round and mistrust this very mistrust. Should we not be concerned as to whether this fear of error is not just the error itself?'o
The relation between appearance and Truth should thus be conceived in a dialectically reflexive way: the most radical illusion consists not in accepting as Truth, as the 'Thing-in-itself, what is effectively a mere deceptive illusion, but rather in a refusal to recognize the presence of the Truth - in pretending that we are still dealing with a fictitious appearance, when Truth is already here.
20
Hegel, phellOl1lello{ogy of Spirit, p. 47.

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Sydney Pollack's film Three Do/s tfthe Condor exemplifies perfectly this paradoxical, self-reflexive character of the illusion. A small branch of the CIA is occupied with reading all espionage and detective novels in search of ideas which could perhaps be applied in real espionage work. Suddenly, a special unit of liquidators kills all the members of this branch - why? Because one of them has noted. in some obscure novel, and. passed. over to his superiors, the idea of a secret 'organization-within-an-organization' whose existence should. be unknown and which controls the legal organization; however, such an organization alreatfy exists within the CIA. In other words, he proposed a fiction without knowing that he had. touched the truth. We can now see what Lacan is aiming at when he says that 'the Truth has the structure of a fiction'. This is clear from the Lacanian matrix of the four discourses: 'Truth' is an empty place, and the ' effect of Truth' is produced when, quite by chance, some piece of'fiction' (of symbolically structured knowledge) finds itself occupying this place, as in Pollack's movie when some unfortunate lower clerk unwittingly produced an explosive 'effect of Truth'.
The fear of error which conceals its opposite, the fear of Truth: this Hegelian formula encapsulates perfectly the subjective position of the obsessional neurotic: the incessant procrastination, the endless precautions, which characterize his approach. At the same time this reference to obsessional neurosis (not as a clinical entity, of course, but as a subjective position, as what Hegel would call 'the position of thought towards objectivity') enables us to locate properly the Lacanian observation that Hegel is 'the most sublime of all hysterics'. By determining the passage from Kant to Hegel as the hystericization of the obsessional's position, we are already in the midst of the properly Hegelian relation between genus and its species: hysteria and obsessional neurosis are not two species of neurosis as a neutral-universal genus; their relation is a dialectical one - it was Freud himself who noted that obsessional neurosis is a kind of'dialect of hysteria': hysteria as a fun

is an ordinary, everyday object
which, quite by chance, finds itself occupying the place of what he calls das Ding, the impossible-real object of desire. The sublime object is 'an object elevated to the level of das Ding'. It is its structural place - the fact that it occupies the sacred/forbidden place of jouissance - and not its intrinsic qualities that confers on it its sublimity.
This point is best illustrated by a whole series ofBunuel's films which are built around the same central motif of the - to use Bunuel's own words -'non-explainable impossibility of the fulfilment of a simple desire'. In L 'We d'orthe couple want to consummate their love, but they are again and again prevented by some stupid accident; in The Cnininal Lfft cfArchibaldo de la Cruz the hero wants to accomplish a simple murder, but all his attempts fail; in The Exterminating Angel, after a party, a group of rich people cannot cross the threshold and leave the house; in The Disaeet Charm cf tile Bourgeoisie two couples want to dine together, but unexpected complications always prevent the accomplishment of this simple wish; and finally, in That Obscure Ol!Ject ojDesire, we have the paradox of a woman who, through a series of tricks, postpones again and again the final moment of reunion with her old lover.
What is the common feature of these films? An ordinary, everyday act becomes impossible to accomplish as soon as it finds itself occupying the impossible place of das Ding and begins to embody the sublime object of desire. This object or act may be in itself extremely banal (a common dinner, passing the threshold after a party). It has only to occupy the sacred/forbidden, empty place in the Other, and a whole series of imrass-able obstacles will build up around it; the object or act, in its very vulgarity, cannot be reached or accomplished.
What the object is masking, dissimulating, by its massive, fascinating presence, is not some other positivity but its own place, the void, the lack

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that it is filling in by its presence - the lack in the Other. And what Lacan calls 'going-through the fantasy' consists precisely in the experience of such an inversion apropos of the fantasy-object: the subject must undergo the experience of how the ever-lacking object-cause of desire is in itself nothing but an objectivication, an embodiment of a certain lack; of how its fascinating presence is here just to mask the emptiness of the place it occupies, the emptiness which is exactly the lack in the Other - which makes the big Other (the symbolic order) perforated, inconsistent.
So 'we' (who have already 'gone through the fantasy') can see that there is nothing where the consciousness thought that it saw something, but our knowledge is already mediated by this 'illusion' in so far as it aims at the empty space which makes the illusion possible. In other words, if we subtract from the illusion the illusion itself (its positive content) what remains is not simply nothing but a determinate nothing, the void in the structure which opened the space for the 'illusion'. To 'unmask the illusion' does not mean that 'there is nothing to see behind it': what we must be able to see is precisely this nothing as such - beyond the phenomena, there is nothing but this nothing itself, 'nothing' which is the suiject To conceive the appearance as 'mere appearance' the subject effectively

level of the subject the appearance
deceives precisely by pretending to deceive - by feigning that there is something to be concealed. It conceals the fact that there is nothing to conceal: it does not feign to tell the truth when it is lying, it feigns to lie when it is actually telling the truth - that is, it deceives by pretending to deceive.

A phenomenon can thus tell the truth precisely by presenting itself as a lie, like the Jew in the Freudian joke often quoted by Lacan, who reproaches his friend: 'Why are you telling me that you are going to Cracow and not to Lemberg, when you're really going to Cracow?' (telling the truth represented a breach of the implicit code of deception which ruled their relationship: when one of them was going to Cracow, he was supposed to tell the lie that his destination was Lemberg, and vice versa). In his commentary on the tale ofZeuxis and Parrhasios, Lacan refers to Plato's protest against the illusion of painting:

It is here that this little story becomes useful in showing us why plato protests against the illusion of painting. The point is not that painting gives an illusory equivalance to the object, even if plato seems to be saying this. The point is that the trompe ['CEil of painting pretends to be something other than what it is . . . The picture does not compete with appearance, it competes with what plato designates for us beyond appearance as being the Idea. It is because the picture is the appearance that says it is that which gives the appearance that plato attacks painting, as ifit were an activity competing with his own.2S

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Lacan, The Four FUlldamelltal COllcepts ofpsycho Allafysis, p. 112.

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The real danger, for Plato, is this appearance which purports to be an appearance and for this reason is nothing but the Idea itself, as Hegel knows very well ('the supersensible [Idea] is the appearance qua appearance'). This is the secret philosophy has to conceal to retain its consistency - the secret that Hegel, at the culminating point of the metaphysical tradition, makes us see. This is why the fundamental Hegelian motif that 'appearance as such is essential' could not be grasped without the hypothesis of the bigOther -of the autonomous symbolic order rendering possible the deception in its properly human dimension.

To exemplify this connection let us refer to Stalinism - more specifically, to its obsessive insistence that whatever the cost we must maintain the appearance: we all know that behind the scenes there are wild factional struggles going on; neverthless we must keep at any price the appearance ofparty unity; nobody really believes in the ruling ideology, every individual preserves a cynical distance from it and everybody knows that nobody believes in it; but still, the appearance is to be maintained at any price that people are enthusiastically building socialism, supporting the Party, and so on.

This appearance is essential: if it were to be destroyed - if somebody were publicfy to pronounce the obvious truth that 'the emperor is naked' (that nobody takes the ruling ideology seriously . . .) - in a sense the whole system would fall apart: why? In other words: if everybody knows that 'the emperor is naked' and if everybody knows that all the oth.ers know it, what is the agency for the sake of which the appearance is to be kept at any price? There is, of course, only o

easure itself(the
exact definition - one of the Lacanian definitions - of enjoyment VGutSsanceJ).
This means at the same time that the relation of Beauty to Sublimity coincides with the relation of immediacy to mediation - further proof that
the Sublime must follow Beauty as a form of mediation of its immediacy.
On closer examination, in what does this mediation proper to the Sublime
consist? Let us quote the Kantian definition of the Sublime:
The Sublime may be described in this way: It is an object (of nature)
the representation {Vorstellungj if which determines the mind to regard
the elevation if nature byond our reach as equivalent to a presentation
{DarstellungJ ifideas.l
It is a definition which, so to speak, anticipates Lacan's determination of the
sublime object in his seminar on The EthicofP!Jchoanafysis. 'an object raised
to the level of the (impossible-real) Thing'. That is to say, with Kant the
Sublime designates the relation of an inner-worldly, empirical, sensuous
object to Dine an sich to the transcendent, trans-phenomenal, unattainable
Thing-in-itselE The paradox of the Sublime is as follows: in principle, the
gap separating phenomenal, empirical objects of experience from the
Thing-in-itself is insurmountable - that is, no empirical object, no
representation [Vor.ftellune] of it can adequately present [dar.ftellen] the Thing
(the suprasensible Idea); but the Sublime is an object in which we can
experience this very impossibility, this permanent failure of the
representation to reach after the Thing. Thus, by means of the very failure
of representation, we can have a presentiment of the true dimension of the
Thing. This is also why an object evoking in us the feeling of Sublimity gives
us simultaneous pleasure and displeasure: it gives us displeasure because of
its inadequacy to the Thing-Idea, but precisely through this inadequacy it
gives us pleasure by indicating the true, incomparable greamess of the Thing,
surpassing every possible phenomenal, empirical experience:
3
Ibid., p. 1 19·

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The feeling of the Sublime is, therefore, at once a feeling of displeasure, arising from the inadequacy of imagination in the aesthetic
estimation of magnitude to attain, to its estimation by reason, and
a simultaneously awakened pleasure, arising from this very judgement of the inadequacy of the greatest faculty of sense being in
accord with ideas of reason, so far as the effort to attain to these is
for us a law.4
We can now see why it is precisely nature in its most chaotic, boundless,
terrifying dimension which is best qualified to awaken in us the feeling
of the Sublime: here, where the aesthetic imagination is strained to its
utmost, where all finite determinations dissolve themselves, the failure
appears at its purest.
The Sublime is therefore the paradox of an object which, in the very
field of representation, provides a view, in a negative way, of the dimension of what is unrepresentable. It is a unique point in Kant's system,
a point at which the fissure, the gap between phenomenon and Thing-in-itself, is abolished in a negative way, because in it the phenomenon's
very inability to represent the Thing adequately is inscribed in the phenomenon itself- or, as Kant puts it, 'even if the Ideas of reason can be in no
way adequately represented [in the sensuous-phenomenal world], they
can be revived and evoked in t

Otherness, as unrepresentable, still remains the extreme point of the logic of representation.

But here again, this Hegelian approach can give way to misunderstanding if we read it as an assertion that - in opposition to Kant, who tries to reach the Thing through the very breakdown of the field of phenomena, by driving the logic of representation to its utmost - in dialectical speculation, we must grasp the Thing 'in itself, from itself, as it is in its pure Beyond, without even a negative reference or relationship to the field of representation. This is /lot Hegel's position: the Kantian criticism has here done its job and if this were Hegel's position, Hegelian dialectics would effectively entail a regression into the traditional metaphysics aiming at an immediate approach to the Thing. Hegel's position is in fact 'more Kantian than Kant himself - it adds nothing to the Kantian notion of the Sublime; it merely takes it more literallY than Kant himsel£

Hegel, of course, retains the basic dialectical moment of the Sublime, the notion that the Idea is reached through purely negative presentation - that the very inadequacy of the phenomenality to the Thing is the only appropriate way to present it. The real problem lies elsewhere: Kant still presupposes that the Thing-in-itself exists as something positively given beyond the field of representation, of phenomenality, the breakdown· of phenomenality, the experience of phenomena, is for him only an 'external reflection', only a way of indicating , within the domain of phenomenality, this transcendent dimension of the Thing which persists in itself beyond phenomenality.

Hegel's position is, in contrast, that there is notlli118 beyond phenomenality, beyond the field of representation. The experience of radical

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negativity, of the radical inadequacy of all phenomena to the Idea, the experience of the radical fissure between the two - this experience is already Idea itselJas pure¸ radical negativity. Where Kant thinks that he is still dealing only with a negative presentation of the Thing, we are already in the midst of the Thing-in-itself -for this Thing-in-itselJ is nothing but this radical negativity. In other words - in a somewhat overused Hegelian speculative twist - the negative experienc? of the Thing must change into the experience of the Thing-in-itself as radical negativity. The experience of the Sublime thus remains the same: all we have to do is to subtract its transcendent presupposition - the presupposition that this experience indicates, in a negative way, some transcendent Thing-in-itself persisting in its positivity beyond it. In short, we must limit ourselves to what is strictly immanent to this experience, to pure negativity, to the negative self-relationship of the representation.

Homologous to Hegel's determination of the difference between the death of the pagan god and the death of Christ (the first being merely the death of the terrestrial embodiment, of the terrestrial representation, figure, of God, while with the death of Christ it is God of beyond, God as a positive, transcendent, unattainable entity, which dies) we could say that what Kant fails to take into account is the way the experience of the nullity, of the inadequacy of the phenomenal world of representation, which befalls us in the sentiment of the Sublime, means at the same time the nullity, the non-ex

e case of Rabinovitch, it is precisely thus that we
produce its speculative truth, because this negativi?J, this unbearable discord,
coinddeswithsubjectivi?J itse![,it is the only way to make present and 'palpable'
the utmost -that is, self-referential-negativity which characterizes spiritual
subjectivity. We succeed in transmitting the dimension of subjectivity ry
means if the failure itse![, through the radical insufficiency, through the
absolute maladjustment of the predicate in relation to the subject. This
is why 'the Spirit is a bone' is a perfect example of what Hegel calls the
'speculative proposition', a proposition whose terms are incompatible,
without common measure. As Hegel points out in the Preface to the
Phenomenology if Spirit, to grasp the true meaning of such a proposition
we must go back and read it over again, because this true meaning arises
from the very failure of the first, 'immediate' reading.
Does not the proposition 'the Spirit is a bone' - this equation of two
absolutely incompatible terms, pure negative movement of the subject
and the total inertia of a rigid object - offer us something like a Hegelian
version of the Lacanian formula of fantasy: $ Oa? To convince ourselves
that it does, it is enough to place this proposition in its proper context:
the passage from physiognomy to phrenology in the Phenomenology of
Spirit.
Physiognomy - the language of the body, the expression of the subject's
interior in his spontaneous gestures and grimaces - still belongs to the
level oflanguage, of signifying representation: a certain corporeal element
(a gesture, a grimace) represents, signifies, the non-corporeal interior of
the subject. The final result of physiognomy is its utter failure: every signi-
fying representation 'betrays' the subject; it perverts, deforms what it is
supposed to reveal; there is no 'proper' signifier of the subject. And the

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passage from physiognomy to phrenology functions as the change oflevel
from representation to presence; in opposition to gestures and grimaces, the
skull is not a sign expressing an interior; it represents nothing; it is - in
its very inertia - the immediate presence of the Spirit:
In physiognomy, Spirit is supposed to be known in its own outer aspect,
as in a being which is the utterance of Spirit - the visible invisibility
of its essence . . . In the determination yet to be considered, however,
the outer aspect is lastly a wholly immobile reality which is not in its
own self a speaking sign but, separated from self-conscious movement,
presents itself on its own account and is a mere Thing.6
The bone, the skull, is thus an object which, by means of its presence, fills
out the void, the impossibility of the signifYing representation of the subject.
In Lacanian terms it is the objectification of a certain lack: a Thing occupies
the place where the signifier is lacking; the fantasy-object fills out the lack
in the Other (the signifier' s order). The inert object of phrenology (the skull-
bone) is nothing but a positive form of cettain failure: it embodies, literally
'gives body' to, the ultimate failure of the signifYing representation of the
subject. It is therefore correlative to the subject in so far as - in Lacanian
theory - the subject is nothing but the impossibility of its own signifYing
representation - the empty place opened up in the big Other by the failure

es the heroism ifIlatte,y.8 The medium of activity of the consciousness is no longer deeds, it is now language, flattery addressed to the person of the Monarch, who embodies the State.

It is not difficult to detect the historical background of this passage: the transformation of medieval feudalism, with its notions of honourable service, and so on, into absolute Monarchy. But here we are far from a simple corruption or degeneration of silent and devoted service into hypocritical flattery. The paradoxical syntagm 'heroism of flattery' is not to be taken as an ironic conjunction of two otherwise opposed notions; here we are concerned with heroism in the full sense of the word. The 'heroism of flattery' is a notion that deserves to be interpreted on the same level as that of'voluntary servitude'; it announces the same theoretical deadlock: how can 'flattery', usually perceived as a non-ethical activity par excellence, as a renunciation of the ethical stance in pursuit of'pathological' interests of gain and pleasure, obtain a properly ethical status, the status of an obligation whose fulfilment draws us 'beyond the pleasure principle'?

According to Hegel, the key to this enigma is the role played in it by language. Language is, of course, the very medium of the 'journey of consciousness' in Phenomenology, to such a point that it would be possible to define every stage of this journey, every 'figure of consciousness', by a specific modality of language; even in its very beginning, in the 'sense-certainty', the dialectical movement is activated by the discord between what the consciousness 'means to say' and what it effectively says. In this

8

Ibid., p. 3 10.

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series, the 'language of flattery' none the less presents an exception: only here is language not reduced to a medium of the dialectical process but becomes as such, in its very form, what is at stake in the struggle; it 'has for its content the form itself, the form which language itself is, and is authoritative as language. It is the power of speech, as that which performs what has to be performed'.9

This is why 'flattery' is not to be conceived at the psychological level, in the sense ofh ypocritical and avaricious adulation: what announces itself here is rather the dimension of an alienation proper to language as such - it is the very form oflanguage which introduces a radical alienation; noble-minded consciousness betrays the sincerity of its internal conviction as soon as it starts talking. That is to say, as soon as we start talking, truth is on the side of the Universal, of what we are 'effectively saying', and the 'sincerity' of our innermost feelings becomes something 'pathological' in the Kantian sense of the word: something of a radically non-ethical nature, something which belongs to the domain of the pleasure principle.

The subject can pretend that his flattery is nothing but a simple feigning accommodation to an external ritual which has nothing whatsoever to do with his innermost and sincere convictions. The problem is that as soon as he pretends to feign, he is already the victim of his own feigning: his true place is out there, in the empty external ritual, and what he takes for his innermost conviction is nothing but the narcissistic vanity of his null subjectivity - or, in modern parlance, the 'truth' of what we are saying depends on the way our speech constitutes

by the
difference in the starting point of the respective dialectical movements: if we start from language reduced to 'gestures and grimaces of the body', the objective counterpart to the subject is what at this level presents total inertia - the skullbone; but if we conceive language as the medium of the social relations of domination, its objective counterpart is of course wealth as the embodiment, as the materialization of social power.

Positi11g, external, determinate riflection

This paradox of the 'infinite judgement' is what escapes Kant - why? To put it in Hegelian terms, because Kant's philosophy is one of 'external reflection' - because Kant is not yet able to accomplish the passage from 'external' to 'determinate' reflection. In Kant's view, the whole movement which brings forth the feeling of the Sublime concerns only our subjective reflection external to the Thing, not the Thing-in-itself - that is, it represents only the way we, as finite subjects caught in the limits of our phenomenal experience, can mark in a negative mode the dimension of the trans-phenomenal Thing. In Hegel, however, this movement is an immanent reflexive determination of the Thing-in-itself - that is, the Thing is nothing but this reflexive movement.

To exemplify this movement of reflection - namely the triad of positing, external and determinate reflection,IO let us take the eternal hermeneutical question of how to read a text. 'Positing reflection' corresponds to a naive

10
G. W. F. Hegel, Wissenschafi der Logik, volumes I and II, Hamburg: Hg. von G. Lasson, 1966.

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reading claiming immediate access to the true meaning of the texl: we know, we pretend to grasp immediately what a text says. The problem arises, of course, when there are a number of mutually exclusive readings claiming access to the true meaning: how do we choose between them, how do we judge their claims? 'External reflection' provides a way out of this impasse: it transposes the 'essence', the 'true meaning' of a text into the unattainable beyond, making of it a transcendent 'Thing-in-itself. All that is accessible to us, finite subjects, are distorted reflections, partial aspects deformed by our subjective perspective; the Truth-in-itself, the true meaning of the text, is lost for ever.

All we have to do to pass from 'external' to 'determinate' reflection is to become aware how this ve!)' externality of the external riflexive determinations of the 'essence'(the series of distorted, partial reflections of the true meaning of the text) is alreatfy internal to this 'essence' itse!(,how the internal ' essence' is already in itself'decentred', how the 'essence' of this essence itself consists in this series of external determinations.

To make this somewhat speculative formulation clearer, let us take the case of conflicting interpretations of some great classical text - Ant(gone, for example. 'Positing reflection' claims a direct approach to its true meaning: 'Ant(goneis in fact a drama about . . .'; 'external reflection' offers us a gamut of historical interpretations conditioned by different social and othet contexts: 'We don't know what Sophocles really meant, the immediate truth about Ant(gone is unattainable because of the filter of historical distance, all that is within our grasp is the succession of historical influences of the text: whatAnt(gonemeant in the Renaissance

, to Holderlin
and Goethe, in the nineteenth centuty, to Heidegger, to Lacan . . . ' And
to accomplish the 'determinate reflection', we have only to experience how
this problem of the 'true', 'original' meaning of Ant(gone - that is, the
status of Ant(gone-'in-itself, independent of the string of its historical
efficacy - is ultimately a pseudo-problem: to resume the fundamental
principle of Gadamer's hermeneutics, there is more truth in the later
efficacy of a text, in the series of its subsequent readings, than in its
supposedly 'original' meaning.

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The 'true' meaning of Antigone is not to be sought in the obscure origins
of what 'Sophocles really wanted to say', it is constituted by this very series
of subsequent readings - that is, it is constituted oftenvards, through a
certain structurally necessary delqy. We achieve the' determinate reflection'
when we become aware of the fact that this delay is immanent, internal
to the 'Thing-in-itself: the Thina-in-itseffis found in its Truth t1zrol18h the loss
ofits immediary. In other words, what appears, to 'external reflection', as
an impediment is in fact a positive condition of our access to Truth: the Truth
of a thing emerges because the thing is not accessible to us in its immediate
self-identity.
Yet what we have just said is insufficient inasmuch as it still leaves
room for a certain misunderstanding: if we grasp the plurality of phenom-
enal determinations which at first sight blocked our approach to the
'essence' as so many self-determinations of this very 'essence' - if we trans-
pose the fissure separating the appearance from essence into the internal
fissure of the essence itself- it could still be said that in this way - through
'determinate reflection' - the appearance is ultimately reduced to the self-
determination of the essence, 'sublated' in its self-movement, internalized,
conceived as a subordinate moment of self-mediation of the essence. We
have yet to add the decisive emphasis: it is not only that the appearance,
the fissure between appearance and essence, is a fissure internal to the
essence itself; the crucial point is that, inversely, essence' itseffis nothina but
the seff-rupture, the seff-fissure of the appearance.
In other words, the fissure between appearance and essence is internal
to the appearance itself; it must be reflected in the very domain of appear-
ance - this is what Hegel calls 'determinate reflection'. The basic feature
of Hegelian reflection is thus the structural, conceptual necessity of its
redoubling. it is not only that the essence must appear, must articulate its
inner truth in a multiplicity of determinations (this being one of the
commonplaces of Hegelian commentary: 'the essence is only as deep as it
is broad'); the point is that it must appear for the appearance itseff- as essence
in its difference to appearance, in the form of a phenomenon which,
paradoxically, gives body to the nullity of phenomena as such. This

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redoubling characterizes the movement of reflection; we run into it at all
levels of the Spirit, from the State to religion. The world, the universe, is
of course the manifestation of divinity, the reflection of God's infinite
creativity; but for God to become effective he must again reveal himself
to his creation, embody himself in a particular person (Christ). The St

ate
is, of course, a rational totality; but it establishes itself as an effective sublation-mediation of all particular contents only by embodying itself again in the contingent individuality of the Monarch. This redoubling movement is what defines 'determinate reflection', and the element which embodies again, which gives positive form to the very movement of sublation of all positivity, is what Hegel calls 'reflexive determination'.
What we must grasp is the intimate connection, even identity, between this logic of reflection (positing, external, determinate reflection) and the Hegelian notion of the ' absolute' subject - of the subject which is no longer attached to some presupposed substantial contents but posits its own substantial presuppositions. Roughly speaking, our thesis is that what is constitutive for the Hegelian subject is precisely this redoubling of the reflection, the gesture by means of which the subject posits the substantial 'essence' presupposed in the external reflection.
Positina the presuppositions
To exemplify this logic of , positing the presuppositions', let us take one of the most famous 'figures of consciousness' from Hegel's Phenomenology of Spirit. the 'beautiful soul'. How does Hegel undermine the position of the 'beauriful soul', of this gentle, fragile, sensitive form of subjectivity which, from its safe position as innocent observer, deplores the wicked ways of the world? The falsity of the 'beautiful soul' lies not in its inactivity, in the fact that it only complains of a depravity without doing something to remedy it; it consists, on the contrary, in the very mode of activity implied by this position of inactivity - in the way the 'beautiful soul' structures the 'objective' social world in advance so that it is able to assume, to play in it the role of the fragile, innocent and passive victim. This, then,

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is Hegel's fundamental lesson: when we are active, when we intervene in the world through a particular act, the real act is not this particular, empirical, factual intervention (or non-intervention); the real act is of a strictly symbolic nature, it consists in the very mode in which we structure the world, our perception of it, in advance, in order to make our intervention possible, in order to open in it the space for our activity (or inactivity).
The real act thus precedes the (particular-factual) activity; it consists in the previous restructuring of our symbolic universe into which our [factual, particular) act will be inscribed.
To make this clear, let us take the care of the suffering mother as the 'pillar of the family': all other members of the family - her husband, her children - exploit her mercilessly; she does all the domestic work and she is of course continually groaning, complaining of how her life is nothing but mute suffering, sacrifice without reward. The point, however, is that this 'silent sacrifice' is her imaginary identification: it gives consistency to her self-identity - if we take this incessant sacrificing from her, nothing remains; she literally 'loses ground'.
This is a perfect case of Lac ani an communication (by which the speaker gets back from the recipient his own message in its inverted - that is, true - meaning). The meaning of the mother's incessant groaning is a demand. 'Keep on exploiting me! My sacrifice is all that gives meaning to my life!', so that by

f objective knowledge into
that of knowing reali9' as something produced by consciousness."
Before we intervene in reality by means of a particular act, we must accomplish the purelY formal act of converting reality as something which is objectively given into reality as 'effectivity', as something produced, 'posited' by the subject. Here the interest of the 'beautiful soul' is to make us see this gap between the two acts (or two aspects of the same act): on the level of positive content she is an inactive victim, but her inactivity is already located in a field of effectivity, of social reality 'that results from action' - in the field constituted by the ' conversion' of the ' objective' reality into effectivity. For the reality to appear to us as the field of our own activity (or inactivity), we must conceive it in advance as 'converted' - we must conceive ourselves as formallY responsible-guil9' for it.
Here we finally encounter the problem of posited presuppositions: in his particular-empirical activity, the subject of course presupposes the 'world', the objectivity on which he performs his activity, as something given in advance, as a positive condition of his activity; but his positive-empirical activity is possible only if he structures his perception of the world in advance in a way that opens the space for his intervention - in other words, only ifhe retroactively posits the very presuppositions of his activity, of his 'positing'. This 'act before act' by means of which the subject posits the very presuppositions of his activity is of a strictly formal nature; it is a purely formal 'conversion' transforming reality into something perceived, assumed as a result of our activity.
The crucial moment is this previousness of the act offormal conversion in relation to positive-factual interventions, whereby Hegel differs radically from Marxian dialectics: in Marx, the (collective) subject first transforms the given objectivity by means of the effective-material process of
1 1
Hegel,
of Spirit, p. 385.

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production; he first gives it 'human form', and thereupon, reflecting the results ofhis activity, he formally perceives himself as the' author ofits world', while in Hegel the order is reversed before the subject 'actually' intervenes in the world, he must formally grasp himself as responsible for it.
In ordinary language, the subject 'doesn't really do anything', he only assumes the guilt-responsibility for the given state of things - that is, he accepts it as 'his own work' by a purely formal act: what was a moment ago perceived as substantial positivity ('reality that merely if) is suddenly perceived as resulting from his own activity (' reality as something produced by consciousness'). 'In the beginning' is thus not an active intervention but a paradoxical act of'imitation', of'pretending': the subject pretends that the reality which is given to him in its positivity - which he encounters in its factual substantiality - is his own work. The first 'act' of this kind, the act defining the very emergence of man, is the funeral ritual; Hegel develops this in a formal, explicit way apropos ofPolynices' burial in Antigone:
This universality which the individual as such attains is pure being, deatFr, it is a state which has been reached immediatefy, in the course qjNature, not the result of an action COIlSa"OUSfy done. The duty

between the spiritual form and the given
content, which drives the subject to incessant activity.!l
It is thus not difficult to realize the connection between this gesture
of , choosing what is given', this act of formal conversion by means of
which the subject assumes - determines as his own work - the given
objectivity and the passage from external to determinate reflection
accomplished when the positing-producing subject posits the very
presuppositions of his activity, of his 'positing': what is 'positing of
presuppositions' if not that very gesture of formal conversion by means
of which we 'posit' as our own work what is given to us?
It is likewise not difficult to recognize the connection between all this
and the fundamental Hegelian thesis that the substance is to be conceived
as subject. If we do not want to miss the crucial point of this Hegelian
conception of substance as subject, we have to take into account the break
that separates the Hegelian 'absolute' subject from the Kantian-Fichtean,
still 'finite' subject: the latter is the subject of practical activity, the 'positing'
subject, the subject which actively intervenes in the world, transforming-
mediating the given objective reality; he is consequently bound to this
presupposed reality. In other words, the Kantian-Fichtean subject is the
subject of the work-process, the subject of the productive relationship to
reality. Precisely for this reason he can never entirely 'mediate' the given
objectivity, he is always bound to some transcendent presupposition (Thing-
in-itselQ upon which he performs activity, even if this presupposition is
reduced to the mere 'instigation [Ansto/iJ' of our practical activity.
The Hegelian subject is, however, 'absolute': he is no longer a 'finite'
subject bound to, limited, conditioned by some given presuppositions; he
himself posits these very presuppositions - how? Precisely through the
act of'choosing what is already given' - that is, through the symbolic act,
13
G. W. F. Hegel, philosophie deT Religion, volumes I and II, Frankfurt: Suhrkamp
Verlag, 1969.

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mentioned above, of a purely formal conversion; by pretending that the
given reality is already his work; by assuming responsibility for it.
The current notion according to which the Hegelian subject is 'even
more active' than the Fichtean subject in so far as he succeeds where the
Fichtean subject still fails - that is, in 'devouring' -mediating-internalizing
the whole effectivity without any leftover - is entirely wrong: what we
must add to the Fichtean 'finite' subject to arrive at the Hegelian 'absolute'
subject is just some purely formal, empty gesture - in common parlance:
an act of pure feigning by means of which the subject pretends to be liable
for what is happening anyway, without taking part in it. This is the W'9'
substance becomes suEved: when, by means of an empty gesture, the subject
takes upon himself the leftover which eludes his active intervention. This
'empty gesture' receives from Lacan its proper name: the signifier; in it
resides the elementary, constitutive act of symbolization.
In this way, it is also clear how we connect the Hegelian concept of
'substance as subject' with the fundamental feature of the dialectical
process: in this process, we can say that in a sense evel)lthing has alrearfy
happened; all that is actually going on is a pure change of form through

which we take note of the fact that what we arrived at has alw'9's alrearfy been. For example, in the dialectical process the fissure is not 'sublated' by being actively overcome: all we have to do is to state formally that it never existed. This happens in the Rabinovitch joke, where the bureaucrat's counter-argument is not actively refuted by Rabinovitch's more accurate arguments; all Rabinovitch has to do is to accomplish a purely formal act of conversion by simply stating that the bureaucrat's very counter-argument is effectively an argument in his favour.

There is no contradiction between this 'fatalistic' aspect of Hegelian dialectics - the idea that we are simply taking note of what has already happened - and his claim to conceive substance as subject. Both really aim at the same conjunction, because the 'subject' is precisely a name for this 'empty gesture' which changes nothing at the level of positive content (at this level, everything has already happened) but must nevertheless be added for the 'content' itself to achieve its full effectivity.

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This paradox is the same as that of the last grain of sand to be added before we have a heap: we can never be sure which grain is the last one; the only possible definition of the heap is that even if we take awqy one grain, it will still be a heap. So this 'last grain of sand' is by definition superfluous, but none the less necessary - it constitutes a 'heap' by its very superfluity. This paradoxical grain materializes the agency of the signifier - paraphrasing the Lacanian definition of the signifier (that which 'represents the subject for another signifier'), we are even tempted to say that this last, superfluous grain represents the subject for all the other grains in the heap. It is the Hegelian Monarch which embodies this paradoxical function at its purest The State without the Monarch would still be a substantial order - the Monarch represents the point ofits subjectivation - but what precisely is his function? Only 'dotting the i's' in a formal gesture of taking upon himself(by putting his signature on them) the decrees proposed to him by his ministers and councillors - of making them an expression of his personal will, of adding the pure form of subjectivity, of ' It is our will . . . " to the objective content of decrees and laws.14 The Monarch is thus a subject par excellence, but only in so far as he limits himself to the purely formal act of subjective decision: as soon as he aims at something more, as soon as he concerns himself with questions of positive content, he crosses the line separating him from his councillors, and the State regresses to the level of Substantiality.

We can now return to the paradox of the phallic signifier: in so far as, according to Lacan, the phallus is a 'pure signifier', it is precisely a signifier of this act of formal conversion by means of which the subject assumes the given, substantial reality as his own work. This is why we could determine the basic 'phallic experience' as a certain ' everything depends on me, but for all that I can do nothing'. Let us exemplify it by reference to two cases which should be read together: the theory of the phallus found in St Augustine, and a certain well-known vulgar joke.

14
G. W. F. Hegel, Grundlinien der philosophie des Reches, Frankfurt Suhrkamp Verlag, 1969, Paragraph 280.

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'NOT ONLY AS SUBSTANCE'
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St Augustine developed his theory of sexuality in one of his minor but none the less crucial texts, De Nuptiis et Concupiscentia. His reasoning is extremely interesting because at its very outset it differs from what is commonly regarded as the basic premises of the Christian notion of sexuality: far ITom being the sin which caused man's Fall, sexuality is on the contrary, the punishment, penitence for the sin. Original sin lies in man's arrogance and pride; it was committed when Adam ate from the Tree of Knowledge, wanting to elevate himself to the divine heights and to become himself master of all creation. God subsequently punished man - Adam - by implanting in him a certain drive - the sexual drive - which strikes out, which cannot be compared with other drives (hunger, thirst, and so on); a drive which radically exceeds its organic function (reproduction of the human species) and which, precisely because of this non-functional character, cannot be mastered, tamed. In other words, if Adam and Eve had stayed in the Garden of Eden they would have had sexual intercourse, but they would have accomplished the sexual act in the same way as they accomplished all other instrumental acts (ploughing, sowing . . .). This excessive, non-functional, constitutively perverse character of human sexuality represents God's punishment for man's pride and his want of power.
How can we detect, where can we locate, this uncontrollable character of sexuality? It is at this point that St Augustine proposes his theory of the phallus: if man has a strong will and self-control, he can master the movement of all parts ofhis body (here Augustine evokes a series of extreme cases: an Indian fakir who is able to stop the beating of his heart for a moment, and so on); all parts of the body are thus in principle submitted to man's will, their uncontrollabilities subsisting only in the factual degree of weakness or power of man's will- all parts except one; the erection of the phallus escapes in pnilClpleman' s free wilL This is therefore according to StAugustine, the 'meaning of the phallus': the part of man's body which escapes his control, the point at which man's own body takes revenge on him for his false pride. Someone with a strong enough will can starve to death in the middle of a room full of delicious food, but if a naked virgin

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passes his way, the erection of his phallus is in no way dependent on the strength of his will . . .
This, however, is only one side of the phallus paradox; its reverse is indicated by a well-known riddle/joke: What is the lightest object on earth? - The phallus, because it is the only one that can be elevated by mere thought.' And to obtain the true 'meaning of phallus', we have to read both examples together: 'phallus' designates the juncture at which the radical externality of the body as independent of our will, as resisting our will, joins the pure interiority of our thought. 'phallus' is the signifier of the short circuit whereby the uncontrollable externality of the body passes immediately into something bound to pure interiority of'thought' and, in contrast, the point at which the innermost 'thought' assumes features of some strange entity, escaping our 'free will'. To use the traditional Hegelian terms, 'phallus' is the point of the 'unity of opposites': not a 'dialectic

al synthesis' (in the sense of a kind of mutual completion)
but the immediate passage of one extreme into its opposite, as in Hegel's example where the lowest, most vulgar function of urination passes into the most sublime function of procreation.
It is this very 'contradiction' that constitutes the 'phallus experience': EVERYTHING depends on me - the point of the riddle - but for all that I can do NOTHING - the point ofSt Augustine's theory. And from here - from this notion of the phallus as pulsation between 'all' and 'nothing' - we can conceive the 'phallic' dimension of the act offormal conversion of reality as given into reality as posited. This act is 'phallic' in so far as it marks the point of coincidence between omnipotence ('everything depends on me': the subject posits all reality as his work) and total impotence (,but for all that I can do nothing': the subject can formally assume only what is given to him). It is in this sense that the phallus is a 'transcendental signifier': if, following Adorno, we define as 'transcendental' the inversion by means of which the subject experiences his radical limitation (the fact that he is confined to the limits of his world) as his constitutive power (the a priori network of categories structuring his perception of reality).

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Presupposi118 the positi118
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There is, however, one crucial weakness in what we have just articulated: our presentation of the process of reflections was oversimplified at a decisive point which concerns the passage from positing to external reflection. The usual interpretation of this passage, which we have accepted automatically, is as follows: positing reflection is the activity of the essence (pure movement of mediation) which posits the appearance - it is the negative movement sublating every given immediacy and positing it as 'mere appearance'; - but this reflexive sublation of the immediate, this positing of it as 'mere appearance', is in itself bound to the world of appearance; it needs appearance as something already given, as the basis upon which to perform its negative mediation activity. In short, reflection presupposes the positive world of appearance as the starting point of its activity of mediating it, of positing it as 'mere appearance'.
To exemplifJ this presupposing, let us take the classical procedure of the 'criticism of ideology': this procedure 'unmasks' a certain theoretical, religious, or other edifice by enabling us to 'see through it', by making us see in it Just an [ideological] appearance', an expression-effect of some concealed mechanisms; this procedure consists thus in a purely negative movement which presupposes a 'spontaneous', 'non-reflected' ideological experience in its given-immediate positivity. To accomplish the passage from positing to external reflection, the movement of reflection has only to take note of how it is always bound to some given, external presuppositions which are subsequently mediated-sublated through its negative activity. In short, the activity of positing has to take note of its presuppositions - external to the movement of reflection are precisely its presuppositions.
In contrast to this current view, Dieter Heinrich, in his excellent study on Hegel's logic of reflection, demonstrated how the whole dialectic ofpositi118 and presupposi118 still falls within the categOlY of 'positi118 reflection: '5 Let us

escribed above - only, that is, in so far as the essence presupposes itself as something alien, as its own Other. If the essence is not in itself split, if - in the movement of extreme alienation - it does not perceive itself as an alien Entity, then the very duality essence/appearance cannot establish itself This selfflSsure if the essence means that the essence is 'subject' and not onfy 'substance': to express this in a simplified way, 'substance' is the essence in so far as it reflects itself in the world of appearance, in phenomenal objectivity; it is the movement of mediation-sublation-positing of this objectivity, and the 'subject' is substance in so far as it is itself split and experiences itself as some alien, positively given Entity.

We could say, paradoxically, that the subject is substance precisefy ill so Jar as it expen''ences itself as substance (as some alien, given, external, positive Entity, existing in itselfj: 'subject' is nothing but the name for this inner distance of'substance' towards itself, the name for this empty place from which the substance can perceive itself as something 'alien'. Without this self-fissure of the essence, there can be no place distinguished from essence in which essence can appearas distinct from itself- that is, as 'mere appearance': essence can appear only in so far as it is already external to itself

What, then, is the nature of the passage from external to detenninate reflection? If we remain on the level of the common interpretation of the logic of reflection, in which the passage of positing into external reflection coincides with that of positing into presupposing, things are, of course,

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clear. To accomplish the passage in question, we simply have to take note of the fact that the very presuppositions are already posited - thus we find ourselves already in determinate reflection; in the reflexive movement which retroactively posits its own presuppositions. To refer again to the active-producing subject which mediates-negates-forms the presupposed objectivity: all he has to do is to experience how the ontological status of this presupposed objectivity is Ilothing butthe presupposition ofhis activity, how it exists, how it is here only for him to use, to perform on it his mediating activity: how, then, it is itself retroactively 'posited' through his activity. 'Nature', the presupposed object of activity, is so to speak already 'by its own nature', in itself, the object, the material for the subject's activity; its ontological status is determined by the horizon of the process of production. In short, it is in advance posited as such - that is, as a presupposition of subjective positing.

If, however, external reflection cannot be sufficiently defined by the fact that positing is always bound to some presuppositions; if, to reach external reflection, essence must presuppose iese!f as its other, things become a little complicated. At first sight, they are still clear enough; let us refer again to the Feuerbachian analysis of religious alienation. Does not the passage from external to determinate reflection consist simply in the fact that man has to recognize in 'God', in this external, superior, alien Entity, the inverse reflection of his own essence - its own essence in the form of otherness; in other words, the 'reflexive determination' of its own essence? And thus to affirm

n which the hidden essence
can reflect itself By taking into consideration this necessity of the
redoubled reflection, we can also demonstrate what is amiss with the
Feuerbachian model of surpassing the external reflection.
This model, in which the subject overcomes alienation by recognizing,
in the alienated substantial Entity, the inverse image of his own essential
potential, implies a notion of religion that corresponds to the Enlighten-
ment's portrait of the Jewish religion (almighty God as an inverse image
of man's powerlessness, and so on); what escapes such an understanding
is the logic behind the fundamental motif of Christianity: God's incarna-
tion. The Feuerbachian gesture of recognizing that God as an alien essence
is nothing but the alienated image of man's creative potential does not
take into account the necessity for this reflexive relationship between God
and man to reflect itself into God himself, in other words, it does not suffice
to ascertain that 'man is the truth of God', that the subject is the truth
of the alienated substantial Entity. It is not enough for the subject to
recognize-reflect himself in this Entity as in his inverse image; the crucial
point is that this substantial Entity must itself split and 'engender' the
subject (that is, 'God himself must become man').
As regards the dialectics of positing and presupposing, this necessity
means that it is not enough to affirm that the subject posits its own presup-
positions. This positing of presuppositions is already contained in the logic
of positing reflection; what defines determinate reflection is, rather, that the
subject must presuppose himself as positing. More precisely: the subject effec-
tively 'posits his presuppositions' by presupposing, by reflecting himself in
them as positing. To exemplifjr this crucial twist, let us take the two usual

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examples: the Monarch and Christ. In the immediacy of their lives, subjects
as citizens are, of course, opposed to the substantial State which determines
the concrete network of their social relations. How do they overcome this
alienated character, this irreducible otherness of the State as the substantial
presupposition of the subjects' activity-'positing'?
The classical Marxist answer would be, of course, that the State as an
alienated force must 'wither away', that its otherness must be dissolved
in the transparency of non-alienated social relations. The Hegelian answer
is, on the contrary, that in the last resort, subjects can recognize the State
as 'their own work' only by reflecting free subjectivity into the very
State at the point of the Monarch; that is to say, by presupposing in the
State itself - as its 'quilting point', as a point which confers its effectivity
- the point of free subjectivity, the point of the Monarch's empty-formal
gesture 'This is my will . . .'
From this dialectic, we can very neatly deduce the necessity behind the
double meaning of the word 'subject' - (1) a person subject to political
rule; (2) a free agent, instigator of its activity - subjects can realize them-
selves as free agents only by means of redoubling themselves, only in so
far as they 'project', transpose, the pure form of their freedom into the
very heart of the substance opposed to them; into the person of the subject-
Monarch as 'head of the State'. In other words, subjects are subjects only
in so far as they presup